Practical Knight Endings



GM Edmar Mednis

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Grandmaster Edmar Mednis

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Preface

One of the many marks showing that the inventor of chess was a genius is making the Bishop and Knight - two absolutely different pieces - about equivalent in material value. In my book *Practical Bishop Endings* I addressed the important principles and techniques of playing same color and opposite color Bishop endings. The Bishop is inherently a logical, straightforward piece. The principles of Bishop endings are inherently logical and straightforward also. Knowing and understanding these principles, when added to the not very large number of sophisticated techniques presented in the above book, is enough for the practical player.

Knight endings is quite another matter. As every beginner realizes, the Knight is a very tricky piece. More knowledge and effort are required to handle Knight endings well as compared to Bishop endings. Of course, Knight endings also have important principles and these need to be mastered. But Knight endings need a lot more. A simplified comparison with Bishop endings gives the following guidelines: the special need in Bishop endings is sophistication; Knight endings require lots of creativity and calculation. Since there is more to know in Knight endings, *Practical Knight Endings* is, of necessity, longer than *Practical Bishop Endings*.

Most of the material in the book is based on my writings on endgames in magazines. As required, the material has been rewritten, expanded and corrected. Sources have been the standard ones: magazines, books and personal contacts. When appropriate, direct credit is given in the text. Of course, any errors remain my responsibility. I would appreciate your calling them to my attention.

To ensure that the reader and the author are on the

same wavelength regarding the meaning of the questions and exclamation marks as they are used in the characterization of moves, these are the presently accepted meanings:

!	= a strong move
!!	= a very strong move; a fantastic move
?	= a bad move; a weak move
??	= a horrible move; a blunder
!?	= an enterprising move; a move worthy of consideration
?!	= a dubious move, for theoretical or practical reasons

This is my fifth book for Chess Enterprises. I am happy to be associated with this fine publishing firm and it president, Bob Dudley.

Edmar Mednis

New York, 1993

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Introduction

Characteristics of the Knight

The Knight's strong points are:

(1) It can jump over pieces - thus is effective in blocked positions or for general infighting.

(2) It can change color readily - thus can attack or control any square on the board.

The Knight's weak points are:

(1) It can only travel a short distance at a time - thus is particularly ineffective in stopping passed pawns which are far away.

(2) Every move must involve not only a change of the color of square the Knight occupies, but each move brings about a clearly different position - thus it is unable to keep the "status quo" and is incapable of bringing about a zugzwang situation.

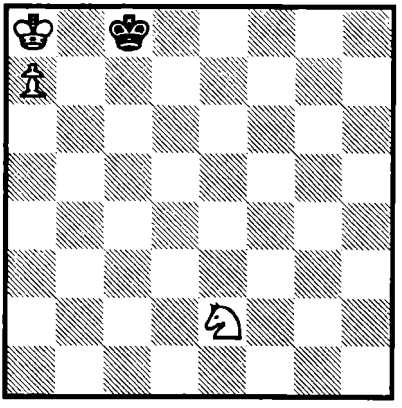
In both of the above matters, the Knight is much inferior to the Bishop. Its difficulties in stopping passed pawns which are far away will be illustrated many times, starting with Chapter 1. The second weakness will be demonstrated by means of the following two thematically important examples.

Diagram 1 (on the next page) shows a typical zugzwang case. White's King is trapped in front of his pawn and will not be able to get out as long as Black's King can remain on either c7 or c8. If we replace White's Knight by a Bishop of either color, the position is a trivial win, irrespective of who is on move. Yet, with a Knight, the question of who is on move is crucial. The principle is straightforward:

If the Knight and Black King stand on the same color, then it is bad to be on move.

If the Knight and Black King stand on opposite colors, then it is good to be on move.

Diagram 1



Therefore, for the specific case of Diagram 1, the following is true.

White on move only draws; Black on move loses.

Black on move loses very quickly:

1...Kc7 2 Nd4 Kc8 3 Nb5 (or 3 Nc6) **3...Kd7 4 Kb7** White wins.

Yet, if White is on move, it does not matter how the Knight jumps around - there is no win. For example:

1 Nd4 Kc7 2 Nb5+ Kc8 3 Nd6+

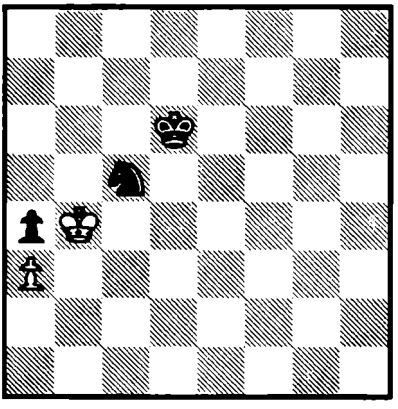
Unfortunately for White, the Knight must move and thus give up control of c7.

3...Kc7 4 Nc4 Kc8 5 Nb6+ Kc7 6 Nd7 Kc8! Draw.

There is no way for White to progress because he cannot prevent Black from shuttling back and forth between c7 and c8. Try the above exercise: put White's Knight on any light square - and you will see that there is no win; put the Knight on any dark square - and you will see that everything wins.

Just as frustrating for the stronger side is the situation of Diagram 2, which is the conclusion of an endgame study by Kakovin and Motor. It is drawn irrespective of who is on move. White's King keeps Black's Knight glued on c5 to protect its pawn, while Black's King is needed to protect its Knight. With Black to move, the best try would be:

Diagram 2



1...Kd5

After 1...Kc6, 2 Kc4?? loses after 2...Na6, yet the active 2 Ka5! holds easily.

2 Kb5 Kd4 3 Kb4!

Keeps the draw in hand. But please note that if the immobile Knight on c5 is replaced by a Bishop on either the d1=a4 or a4-e8 diagonal, then Black wins easily even though he has the wrong Bishop for his a-pawn.

3...Kd3 One last tactical try.

4 Kxc5 Kc3 5 Kd5!

The King must be in position to reach c2 as quickly as possible. Therefore losing is the offside 5 Kb5??: 5...Kb3 6 Kc5 Kxa3 7 Kc4 Kb2 and Black wins.

5...Kb3 6 Kd4 Kxa3 7 Kc3! Ka2 8 Kc2 a3 9 Kc1 Draw.

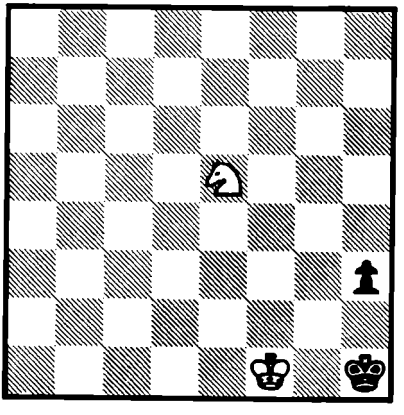
Part I

Material Advantage

Chapter 1: Knight vs. Pawn

Except for one situation, it is only the side with the pawn that has winning chances. The exception is where the King is hemmed in by his own RP on the 2nd or 7th rank. This thematic case is illustrated in Diagram 3, when White has a mate in two:

Diagram 3



1 Ng4! h2 2 Nf3 mate.

This theme is used periodically as the concluding motif in endgame studies. Its appearance in practical games is rare. If it will occur once to you, that is a lot!

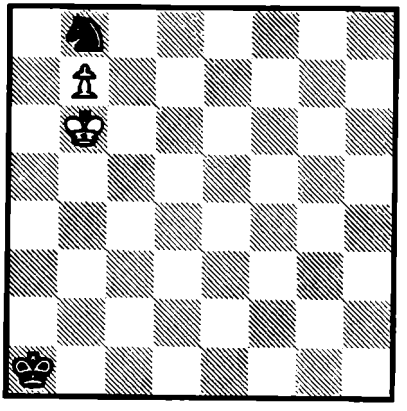
Except for the above "forced suicide", the pawn can only be a positive factor. Obviously, where the defending King is in front of the pawn, the position is a trivial draw. If the defending King cannot get in front of the pawn, the Knight should do so. Then the following principle holds:

A Knight immediately in front of the passed pawn can be itself stop the pawn, except for the RP on the 7th rank.

The usual case is shown in Diagram 4. It is drawn no matter who moves. For instance with Black to move he even

has the following thematic elegant draw:

Diagram 4

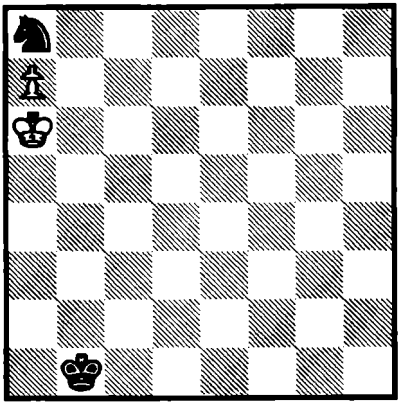


1...Nd7+ 2 Kc7 Nc5! 3 b8=Q Na6+ 4 Kb7 Nxb8 Draw.

Of course, there is no reason for Black to go for such fancy stuff in the example above. Yet that drawing motif is a very important one and often is the only way to cope with a passed pawn on the 7th rank.

Because this Knight fork is not possible against a RP on the 7th rank, the Knight by itself loses. If we now look at Diagram 5, we see that there is no defense. White threatens 1 Kb7, trapping and winning the Knight. Black on move can try:

Diagram 5



1...Nc7+ 2 Kb7 Nb5, but there is no Knight fork after **3**

a8=Q and Black loses.

This is our first demonstration of the very important principle that **the RP is the most difficult passed pawn for the Knight to stop.**

When faced with positions where the Knight is away from the pawn, i.e. in the back of it or on the side of it, the question becomes whether the Knight can get in front of it. There is never a simple answer. Many possible Knight maneuvers must be considered to determine if there is a successful route back for the Knight. It is less question of theoretical knowledge or a flash of brilliance and more of hard, resourceful analysis. Consider first Diagram 6 which is the end of a 1938 endgame study by N. Grigoriev. Black threatens 1..Kc5, chasing the Knight away and then queening his pawn. There is a series of Knight jumps, however, which lead to the opportunity for White to use the technique shown from Diagram 4. Thus White first of all must be familiar with that technique and then work very hard to see how the Knight could get back so as to utilize it. The drawing method is:

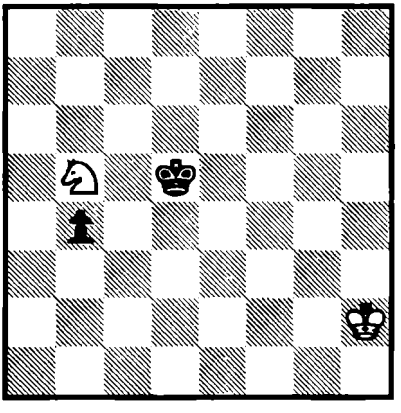


Diagram 6

1 Nc7+ Kc4

White has it easier after other King moves: 1...Kd4 2 Kg2 b3 3 Nb5+ followed by 4 Na3 or 1...Kc6 2 Ne6 Kb5 3 Nd4+ Kc4 4 Nc6! b3 5 Na5+.

2 Ne8!!

The only move. White plans to get the Knight back via the route d6/f6-e4-d2. If Black tries to stop this, White has the auxiliary route c7-b5-a3.

2 ... Kc5

Or 2...b3 3 Nd6+ Kb4 (3...Kd3 4 Nb5 b2 5 Na3) 4 Ne4 b2 5 Nd2.

3 Nf6 Kd4 4 Ne8! Ke5

If 4...b3 5 Nd6 Kc3, the Knight gets back as follows: 6 Ne4+! Kc2 7 Nd6! b2 8 Nc4! b1=Q 9 Na3+ and 10 Nxb1.

5 Nc7 Kd6! 6 Ne8+!

Only so. The Knight needs to retain mobility. Losing is 6 Nb5+? Kc5 when we have our starting point with Black having already gotten in ...Kc5. Black then wins easily: 7 Nc7 b3 8 Ne6+ Kc4 etc. After the text Black has nothing better than to acquiesce to one of the thematic drawing lines.

6 ...Kc5 7 Nf6 Kd4 8 Ne8! b3 9 Nd6 Kc3 10 Ne4+! Kc2 11 Nd6! b2 12 Nc4 b1=Q 13 Na3+ Draw.

Earlier it was demonstrated why the RP is the most difficult one for the Knight to stop. Yet if the pawn is far enough away from queening, there are instances when the Knight can get back in time. A fine example of this is from

Diagram 7

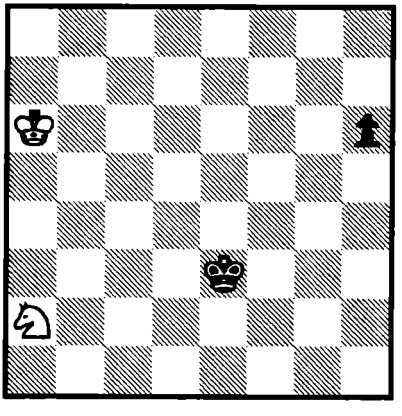


Diagram 7, a 1932 study by N. Grigoriev. Do not bother *memorizing* the specifics as they are not that important for future cases. What is important is to realize that the Knight is very agile. That appreciation plus a lot of hard work is the road to success for discovering the correct jumps, which often are quite surprising ones. White to play and draw as follows:

1 Nb4!

The key question is whether the Knight can get back in time to h2. The two most likely jumps to h2 are from f1 or g4. The prospects of reaching f1 are poor and therefore g4 is the only square worth fighting for. White's chances of getting to g4 are a lot better from b4 than from c3 or c1. Therefore, only the text is worth trying.

1 ...h5 2 Nc6

As was already seen by the play from Diagram 6, the Knight has access to more routes when its starting point is farther from the King. Without prospects are 2 Nd5+?, Kf3! or 2 Nc2+ Kf2!.

2 ...Ke4!

To prevent the Knight from reaching e5. After 2...h4 3 Ne5 White already is safe.

3 Na5!!

This paradoxical looking retreat utilizes the same technique as in the previous example where the far away e8 square was the starting point for the successful road back.

The logic behind the correctness of the text is as follows: the key way posts for the Knights's return are the square e5, e3 and d2. Which square is the springboard for reaching them? The answer, of course, is c4 and that is what the Knight heads for.

Losing is 3 Nd8? h4 4 Ne6 Kf5! 5 Nd4+ Kg4 when the Knight's return has been blocked off.

3 ...h4

Black might as well push since 3...Kd4 and 3...Kd3 lead nowhere after 4 Nc6(+) , while 3...Kd5 allows 4 Nb3 h4 5 Nd2.

4 Nc4

By now it should be clear that only this can work since 4 Nb3? Ke3! leaves the Knight shut off.

4 ...Kf3

The Knight gets back immediately after 4...h3: 5 Nd2+ followed by 6 Nf1 and 7 Nh2.

5 Ne5+!

But now there is not time for 5 Nd2+? because after 5...Ke2! 6 Ne4 h3 7 Ng3+ Kf2 the Knight either gets chased away or is trapped on h1.

What White must keep in mind throughout is that the Knight is interested in getting to h2 - the square in *front* of the pawn.

5 ...Kg3 6 Nc4!

Back again, for a new step forward!

6 ...h3 7 Ne3 h2

If 7...Kf3, 8 Nf1; if 7...Kf2, 3 Ng4+.

8 Nf1+ Kg2 9 Nxh2 Draw.

Chapter 2
Knight and Pawn vs. Knight

The most basic of all Knight endings is that of Knight + pawn vs. Knight. Much is known about it and therefore the key principles can be stated with great confidence. I will be discussing what I consider to be *normal situations*, i.e. those where the Kings and Knights are already near the pawn or can reach it readily enough.

The defending King obviously wants to be in front of the pawn, thereby inhibiting the pawn's advance. *In all reasonable cases the positions are routine draws.* Therefore, in this chapter I will be considering only those situations *where the defending King is to the side of the pawn or in the rear of it.* The important knowledge will be presented in conjunction with the following seven key principles:

(1) Once the Pawn has reached the seventh rank in safety, the win is assured.

This principle makes the objective of how to handle the N + P vs. N endgame easy to state and clear to follow: advance the passed pawn as rapidly as possible so that it can reach the 7th rank. The first definitive analysis was provided by I. Kling in 1867. One of his instructive positions is shown in Diagram 8. White wins, irrespective of who is on move.

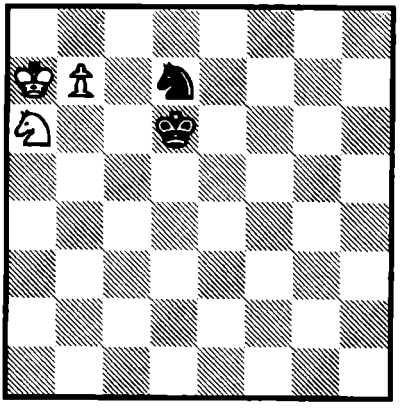


Diagram 8

The winning technique *always consists of chasing away the defending Knight*. With White to play, this is how it is done:

1 Nb4!

White's King stands well enough at the moment so it is logical for the Knight to get off the edge of the board.

1...Kc5

Passive defense is hopeless: 1... Kc7 2 Nd5+ Kd6 3 Nf6! and already Black's Knight must give up control of the queening square.

2 Nd3+ Kd5 3 Nf4+ Kd6 4 Ng6!

Black's King has succeeded in keeping White's Knight out of f6; therefore, the Knight heads for f8 so as to undermine the Black Knight's position on d7.

4...Kd5 5 Nf8 Ne5!

Black prevents the immediate end because of the thematic trick 6 b8=Q?? Nc6+. Yet the inevitable is just delayed by a bit.

6 Ka8! Nc6 7 Nd7!

The Knight now proceeds to chase away Black's Knight from c6 and that will be the end because with White's King on a8 Black will have no more opportunities for a Knight fork.

7... Kd6 8 Nb6

White's Knight can menace Black's from, for instance, a5, b4 or e5. There is no way that Black's King can guard all these squares simultaneously.

8... Kc7 9 Nd5+!

After 9 Nc4 Nb8 Black is safe for the moment, though, of course, White still wins soon enough by retracing his steps

with 10 Nb6!.

9... Kd7 10 Nb4 White wins

A typical example from tournament play is Diagram 9, T. Weinberger - P. Ostojic, 1975 Cleveland International, after Black's 71st move. Because Black will get his e-pawn to e2 in safety, he is sure to win. The game continued:

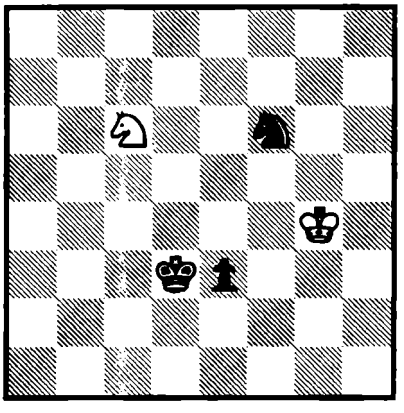


Diagram 9

72 Kf4

White avoids 72 Kf3 because he wants to leave open f3 for his Knight. After 72 Kf3, Black wins as follows: 72... Nd7! (preventing 73 Ne5+) 73 Nb4+ Kd2 74 Nc2 Ne5+ 75 Ke4 e2.

72...e2 73 Ne5+

The game was adjourned here with White sealing this move. He resigned without resuming play. The reason:

73...Kc2!

It is useful to choose a King route which avoids both checks and eventual Knight forks.

74 Nf3 Kd1

This formation is equivalent to that of the previous

example when Black's Knight had already been driven to c6.

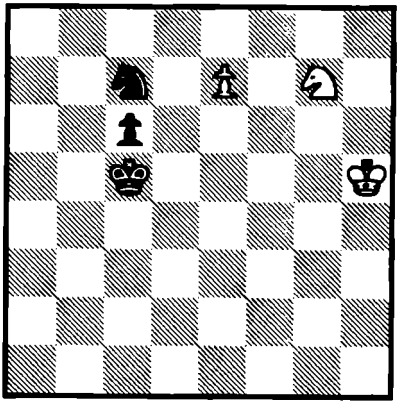
75 Kg3

Or 75 Ke3 Ng4+ 76 Kd4 Nh2!.

75...Ne4+ 76 Kg2 Nd2 Black wins

The strength of a pawn on the 7th rank is so great that often it wins even if the opponent also has a pawn. An instructure example is shown in Diagram 10, an endgame study by the Argentine composer J. Mugnos published in JAQUE in 1972. The winning technique uses the principles demonstrated in the previous two examples.

Diagram 10



1 Kg6!

Heading for the active location on f7 after which the deflection of Black's Knight will start.

1...Kb4

Retreating the King is no help at all as it even gets in the way of his Knight. The following variation is illustrative of that: 1...Kd6 2 Kf7 (3 Ne8+ is the threat) 2...Ke5 3 Ne6! Nb5 4 Kf8 Nd6 5 Nd8! (6 Nf7+ is the threat) 5...Kf6 6 Nb7 (or 6 Nf7). White has deflected the Knight and queens his pawn.

2 Kf7!

Premature is 2 Ne6? since after 2...Ne8 3 Kf7 Nd6+ Black has gained sufficient time to advance his pawn and obtains a theoretically drawn Q + N vs. Q endgame: 4 Kf8 c5 5 Nd8 c4 6 Nb7 c3! etc.

2...c5 3 Ne6 Nb5 4 Ke8!

The King heads to d7 to chase away Black's Knight from d6. After 4 Kf8? Nd6 Black draws as given in the note after White's 2nd move.

4...Nd6+

After 4...c4 White queens first and then stops Black's pawn: 5 Kd7 c3 6 e8=Q c2 7 Qc8! Nc3 8 Qc5+ Kb3 9 Nd4+.

5 Kd7 Ne4 6 Nc7 Nf6+

If 6...c4, 7 Nd5+ followed by 8 e8=Q wins; if 6...Kc4, then 7 Kc6 is the end.

7 Ke6 Nh5

A last gasp : 8 c8=Q?? Ng7+.

8 Kf7! White wins

White's King completes his instructive series of maneuvers by returning to f7. After having caused Black's Knight to give up control of the queening square.

Because of the great difficulties the Knight has in coping with the RP, the next three principles deal with that important pawn:

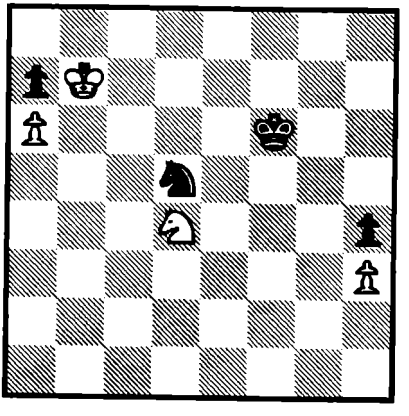
(2) The RP on the 6th rank usually wins

Once the RP has reached the 6th rank in safety, the game is won in the vast majority of cases. An excellent practical example is the play from Diagram 11 (on the next page), H. Pfleger - B. Larsen, Manila 1974, after White's 58th move. The

mutual h-pawns both add a real life element as well as prevent the trivial solution of 58... Nb4 followed by 59... Nxa6 and a draw.

As far as our theme is concerned, White's a-pawn is already on the 6th rank and will become a passed pawn after the imminent Kxa7. White won as follows:

Diagram 11



58...Kg5

Activating the King so as to eliminate White's h-pawn.

Obviously Black must do something as otherwise White will just gobble up Black's a-pawn and then promote his own. The attempt to sacrifice the Knight for the a-pawn fails because of the following variation: 58...Nb4 59 Nf3! Kf5 60 Nxh4+ Kf4 61 Ng2+! Kg3 62 h4.

59 Nf3+ Kf4 60 Nxh4 Kg3 61 Ng2! Kxh3

After 61...Kxg2 62 h4 one of the rook pawns will queen. Black actually resigned after White's 61st move as he apparently did not want to be shown the pretty win after...

62 Nf4+!!

Drawing away Black's Knight just long enough from the a-pawn.

62... Nxf4 63 Kxa7 Nd3

Or 63...Nd5 64 Kb7; or 63...Ne6 64 Kb6.

64 Kb6! Nb4 65 a7 White wins

(3) A draw against the RP on the 6th rank is possible only in a very few favorable ("lucky") situations, and only if the defending King can attack the pawn from the rear.

As already suggested in the previous principle, the drawing chances in practice are very poor. To have any chances at all, the defending King must be actively placed, i.e. be attacking the pawn from the rear. A theoretical example of a draw is Diagram 12, an endgame study by Richard Reti in 1929. It is drawn irrespective of who is on move. Black's King and Knight have ideal defensive locations whereas White is handicapped by having his Knight awkwardly placed on c7. (Another study by Reti in 1929 has demonstrated that White wins if his Knight is on c5.) Black on move draws starting with 1...Nf7! - which will be occuring in our main line on the third move. The main line with White to move is as follows:

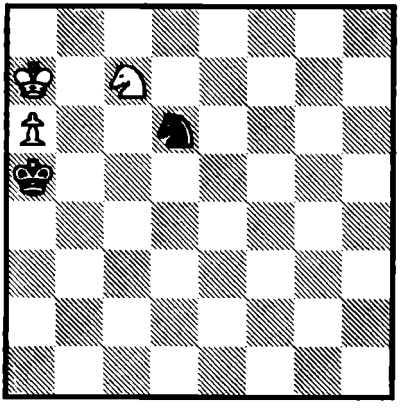


Diagram 12

1 Kb8 Nb5! 2 Kb7 Nd6+

Of course, Black loses immediately after 2...Nxc7?? 3 a7

3 Ka7

By triangulating with his King, White has given the move to Black from our starting position. Therefore, Black's Knight must give up its active location, but by an eyelash the draw is still achievable.

3... Nf7! 4 Ne6

Aiming for c5. After a King move Black draws with 4... Nd8(+).

4...Kb5!

White's Knight must be kept away from c5. Therefore, losing is 4...Nd6? when White plays 5 Nc5!, reaching the Reti position with the Knight on c5. The main line then is 5...Nb5+ 6 Kb7 Kb4 (6...Nd6+ 7 Kc7! Nb5+ 8 Kc6! Na7+ 9 Kb7 Nb5 10 Ne4 - see the main line continuation.) 7 Kb6 Nd6 8 Ne4! Nc8+ 9 Kc7! Kb5 10 Kb7 Ka5 11 Nc5 Nd6+ 12 Kc7 Nb5+ 13 Kc6 Na7+ 14 Kb7 Nb5 15 Ne4! Kb4 16 Kb6 Kc4 17 Nc3! Nd6 18 Kc7 Kc5 19 a7 White wins. White's winning method is of course quite instructive; nevertheless its existence demonstrates how close Black always is to the abyss in the fight against a RP on the 6th rank.

5 Nd4+ Ka5! 6 Nc6+ Kb5 7 Nb4! Nd8!

Losing is 7...Kxb4?? 8 Kb8 Nd8 9 Kc7 Ne6+ 10 Kb6. Black's only attention must be devoted to stopping the a-pawn.

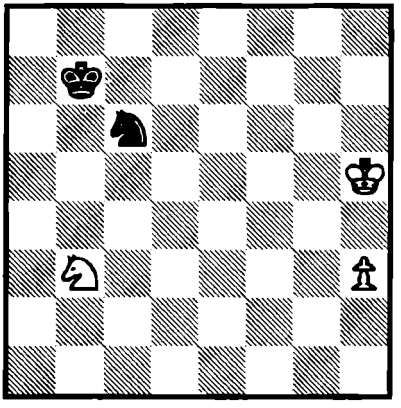
8 Kb8 Nc6+! 9 Kb7 Na5+ 10 Kc7 Nc6!! Draw

White has not way of improving his position, e.g. 11 Kb7 Na5+ 12 Kc8 Kb6 etc.

(4)If the RP is not yet on the 6th rank, the question always is whether it can get there under normal, i.e. favorable, circumstances. The position is won if the answer is "yes".

A model example for arriving at the correct answer is Diagram 13, M. Podgaets - M. Tal, USSR Championship 1968/69, White on move.

Diagram 13



It is clear that White is *close* to a theoretical win, yet the offside Knight and the pawn still being on only the third rank make the answer as yet uncertain. We must start the play to get nearer the clarity:

1 Kg6 Ne5+ 2 Kf6 Nd3!

The Knight has to try to hinder the pawn's advance from a safer location because the obvious 2...Nf3? is refuted by 3 Nd4!! When after 3...Nxd4 4 h4 the person's decissive advance cannot be prevented, while 3...Nh4 4 Kg5 Ng2 5 Nc2! leads to a trapped Knight (6 Kg4 and 7 Kg3).

We can now add the following important principle in a more formal way: in positions with a RP, a Knight sacrifice is often the key maneuver to deflect the opponent's Knight and thus gain the 1-2 tempos required for victory.

3 h4 Nf4 4 Nc5+?

The move that throws away the win. Not only does it allow Black's King to come closer, but also the Knight winds up on a square which offers little future. G.M. Averbakh has demonstrated that a thematic win can be gained with the centralizing 4 Nd4! : 4...Kc8 5 Kf5 Nh5 (Or 5...Nd5 6 h5 Ne7+ 7 Ke6 Ng8 8 Nf5 Kd8 9 Kf7) 6 Ne2! Ng7+ (The threatened 7 Kg6 forces Black's Knight to a passive location.) 7 Kf6! Ne8+ 8 Kg6 Kd7 (After 8...Nc7 White keeps Black's Knight passive

by 9 Nf4!.) 9 h5 Ke7 10 h6 (The RP on the 6th rank and the defender passive is an assured win.) 10...Nd6 (After 10...Nf6 White wins with 11 Nf4 Nd7 12 Kg7 Nf6 13 Nd5+!.) 11 h7 Nf7 12 Kg7 Nh8! 13 Ng3! (But not 13 Kxh8?? Kf7!! and Black draws - see Diagram 1!) 13... Nf7 14 Ne4 Nh8 15 Nd6!! and White wins.

4... Kc6 5 Nd3 Nh5+!

Overlooked by White when he played 4 Nc5+?. Black's Knight gains a stable attacking location and it will cost White valuable time to chase it away.

Of course, 5...Nxd3?? would have justified White's play since after 6 h4 the pawn is unstoppable.

6 Kg6 Ng3

Compared to the winning variation given under White's 4th move, Black's Knight has a lot more scope now and the position is a theoretical draw.

7 Nf2 Kd6 8 Nh1!

The only way to chase away Black's Knight, yet White is forced to lose precious time and this allows Black's King to come closer. Of course, White's Knight remains poisoned.

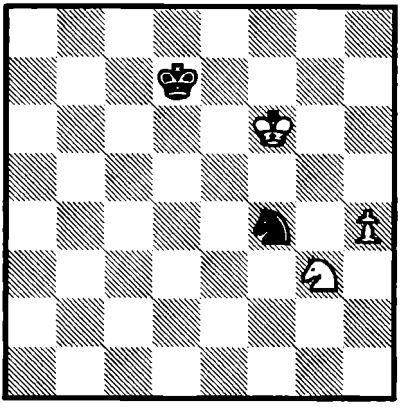
8... Ne2 9 Kf6

Both 9 Kf5 (9...Ke7) and 9 Kg5 (9...Ke6) allow Black's King to get closer to the pawn. Yet after Black's response to the text we see clearly the change in the position : White's pawn is still on the 4th rank while Black's King has progressed from b7 to d6.

9...Nf4 10 Ng3 Kd7

Black's King tries to get to the Kingside via e8, f8 etc. Also drawing - and perhaps more simply so - is 10...Nd5+ 11 Kg5 (11 Kf7 Nf4 12 Ne2 is the game course.) 11...Ke7 12 h5 Kf7 13 h6 Ne7 14 Nh5 Kg8! and Black is safe.

Diagram 14



11 Kf7

Harmless. White should have challenged Black with 11 Ne2! when 11...Nxe2?? loses to 12 h5 and 11...Nh5+?? loses to 12 Kg6. Therefore, Black must play 11...Nd5+ 12 Kf7 Ne3 13 h5 Ng4!. He still draws because White cannot get his pawn to the 6th rank while preventing Black's King from reaching g8. One possible sequence is 14 Ng3 Ne5+ 15 Kf6 Ng4+ 16 Kg5 Ne5 17 Kf5 Nf7 18 Kf6 Ke8 19 Kg7 Ke7 (Averbakh) and Black holds because White cannot advance his pawn.

11...Kd6! 12 Ne2

There is no win, but now Black draws instantaneously.

12...Nxe2

The game was called a draw here. The further course could have been...

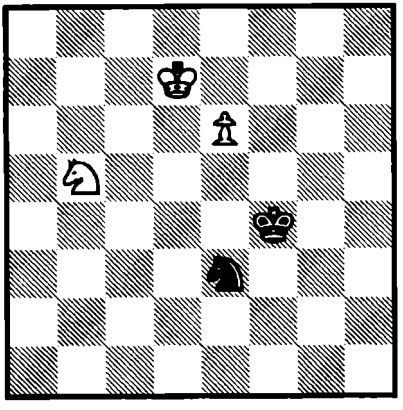
13 h5 Nf4 14 h6 Nc6 Drawn

Because White's King is on f7, Black draws since 15 h7 allows 15...Ng5+. In general, a K + N combination can stop a RP on the 6th rank, e.g. 15 Kf6 Nf8 16 Kf7 Nc6 17 Kg8 Ng5 etc.

(5) Other pawns on the 6th rank usually draw, if the defending King is actively placed in the back of the pawn.

An excellent example - of great practical value - is shown in Diagram 15. It is drawn no matter who is on move. For instance, with White to move:

Diagram 15



1 Nd6

1 e7 fails to 1...Nd5 2 e8=Q Nf6+.

1...Nd5 2 Nc4 Ke4 3 Kd6 Kd4!

With Black's King active to the rear of the pawn, it can help its Knight keep the excellent post on d5. In addition, because the pawn is only on the 6th rank, various Knight deflection sacrifices fail, e.g. 4 Ne3 Nxe3 5 e7 Nf5+.

4 Na3 Ke4 5 Nb5 Ne3! 6 Kd7

Black now needs to show some care. Thus 6...Nd5?? loses to 7 Nc3+! Nxc3 8 e7 since the pawn queens with check; 6...Nf5?? allows 7 Nd6+. Therefore Black plays

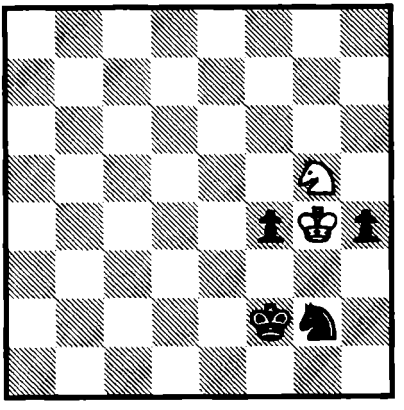
6...Kf4! Drawn

We're back to our starting position!

Wins are usually only possible if some special factor(s)

allow the stronger side to achieve by force a very favorable position. Such a case is illustrated from Diagram 16, E. Paoli - M. Kovacs, Hungary 1971. Black on move. At the moment White's King and Knight have excellent defensive locations, yet Black, by sacrificing one of his pawns will be able to misplace White's forces. Black won as follows:

Diagram 16



1...Ke3 2 Nf3

After the passive retreat 2 Kh3, Black wins routinely with 2...f3.

2...h3!! 3 Nh2

White is forced to deactivate the Knight. The h-pawn will be won, but the game lost.

3...Kf2! 4 Kxh3

After 4 Nf3 Black wins by the thematic Knight deflection sacrifice 4...Nh4!!.

4...Ne3!

White's Knight now cannot move.

5 Kh4 Kg2 6 Kg5 Kg3! White resigns

Because of zugzwang White loses the Knight.

Two additional principles should always be kept in mind when deciding to enter or play a N + P vs. N endgame. These are:

(6) After the RP, the most difficult pawn for the Knight to handle is the NP.

The b- and g-pawns are also close to the edge of the board and therefore tend to cramp the Knight's activity.

(7) The defending King should always be in position to be able to attack the pawn from the rear. This is a much superior location for the King than to be to the side of the pawn.

Chapter 3

Material Advantage - All Pawns on the Same Side

Section 1: Introduction

The general exchanging principles also apply to Knight endgames:

- The side up material wants to exchange Knights.

- The side down material wants to achieve *routine* exchanges of pawns.

Just as it is generally true in other endgames, so too in Knight endgames it is in the interest of the defender to have pawns only on one side. This minimizes the area that must be defended and thus significantly increases the chances for a draw.

The following three principles are more specific to Knight endgames:

(1) Under normal conditions a two pawn advantage is a sure win.

A typical position from a practical game is shown in Diagram 17.

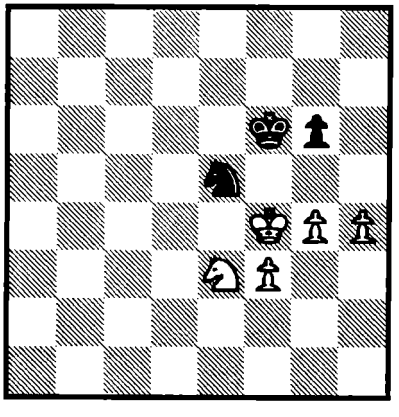


Diagram 17

The winning technique consists of first creating connected passed pawns and then carefully advancing them. With White on move, a model continuation is:

1 Ke4 Nd7 2 f4 Nc5+ 3 Kf3 Nd3 4 f5 g5!

The best defense. After 4...gxf5?! 5 Nxf5 White's connected passed pawns are secure, sound and ready to be mobilized, making the win relatively easy to achieve. However, after the text things are not so obvious because after 5 hxg5+?! Kxg5 Black's King has successfully blockaded the g-pawn and White will have to work very hard to make his pawns mobile again. Also inadvisable is 5 h5?! Ne5+ 6 Ke4 Nf7 and Black's pieces are well placed for the blockade.

What White needs is to achieve the pawn exchange on his terms, i.e. without giving Black the opportunity to blockade on g5.

5 Kg3! Nc5

After 5...gxh4+?! 6 Kxh4 it is now White's King which controls g5 and White is already prepared to play 7 g5+.

6 Nd5+ Ke5 7 Nc3! Kf6

After 7...Kd4 8 hxg5! Kxc3 9 g6 the passed pawns win.

8 Kh3!

Placing Black in zugzwang: a Knight move loses to 9 Ne4+; a King move allows 9 hxg5. Therefore, Black must capture and allow White connected passed pawns in a favorable position.

8 ...gxh4 9 Kxh4 Nd3

After 9...Ke5, White's King moves forward: 10 Kg5!

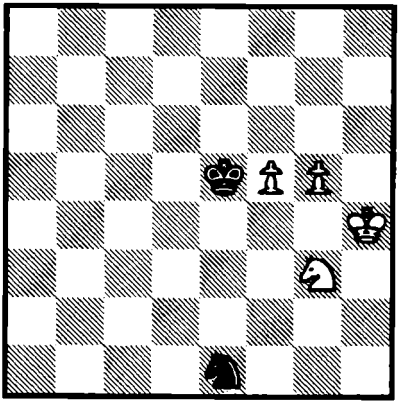
10 Ne4+ Ke5 11 Ng3!

By protecting the f-pawn, White enables the g-pawn to

advance.

11 ...Ne1 12 g5!

Diagram 18



White has now achieved connected passed pawns in the mobile side-by-side position. His win is assured as long as White follows these guidelines:

(1) advance the pawns carefully and, as much as possible, in unison

(2) keep the King and Knight active so that they can help the pawns' advance.

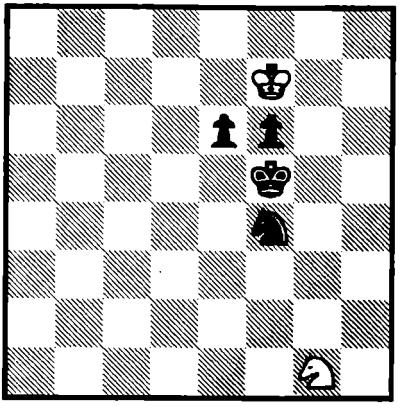
12 ...Nf3+ 13 Kg4! Nd4 14 Kh5! Nc6 15 Kg6 Kf4 16 Nh5+ Ke5 17 f6 Nd8 18 f7 Ne6 19 Kh6! Kd6 20 Nf4! Nf8 21 g6! Ke7 22 Kg7 Nd7 23 Nd5+ Ke6 24 f8=Q White wins.

(2) When down two pawns, a draw is only possible in those rare situations when an impregnable blockade can be organized or the defender's King is unusually active.

At irst glance Diagram 19, M. Taimanov - B. Spassky, Leningrad 1952, White on move, must look like a certain win for Black: he is up two pawns, the pawns are connected and not blockaded, the King and Knight are in position to protect the pawns. Yet White has one very favorable factor: his King is placed exceedingly actively behind both pawns and these pawns are only on the third rank. This factor, helped by the

specific "quirkiness" of the position allows White to draw:

Diagram 19



1 **Nf3 Kg4**

It turns out that nothing works for Black. GM Averbakh provides the following alternatives:
(1) 1...e5 2 Nh4+ Kg5 3 Nf3+ Kg4 4 Kxf6 e4 5 Ne5+ Kg3 6 Nc4 with a draw. The e-pawn cannot get to even the 6th rank.
(2) 1...Ke4 2 Nd2+ Kd3 3 Nf1 f5 (or 3...Ke2 4 Kxf6! Kxf1 5 Ke5) 4 Kf6 Kd4 5 Ng3 followed by 6 Nxf5. We will see an echo of this in the game continuation.

1 **Nh2+ Kh3 3 Nf1 f5 4 Kf6** Draw!

Not a thing can be done about the coming 5 Ne3 followed by 6 Nxf5.

(3) In endgames with a one pawn advantage the stronger side has always much better winning chances than in the corresponding Bishop vs. Bishop endgame.

The superior winning chances derive from the Knight's capability of operating on squares of either color. Therefore, it is able to help its own pawn to advance, as well as to attack the enemy pawn(s) no matter what color they are on. Moreover, a blockading King can be checked off his square and then the stronger side's King can advance.

Compare this to the Bishop endgame: if the defender places its pawns on a color opposite that of the enemy Bishop and has his King on a safe blockading square, then there is absolutely no way for the stronger side to penetrate.

Section 2: Knight + 2 Pawns vs. Knight + Pawn

This section takes a thorough look at the N+2P vs N+P endgame because it is the most important one. The reason for its importance is very simple: it is the basic form into which more complicated endgames can be reduced.

Two broad principles encompass the N+2P vs N+P endgame with the significant knowledge presented thereunder.

(1) N+2P vs. N+P is drawn, unless the stronger side already has a passed pawn or some other significant advantage.

The kind of typical position that is quite drawn is shown in Diagram 20, A. Karpov - V. Korchnoi, 1974 Final Candidates Match, Game 20, after Black's 44th move. There is not a thing wrong with Black's position and he can feel sure of the draw. The game continued:

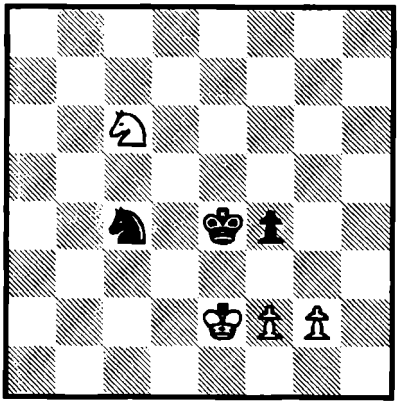


Diagram 20

45 f3+ Kd5 46 Nb4+ Ke5

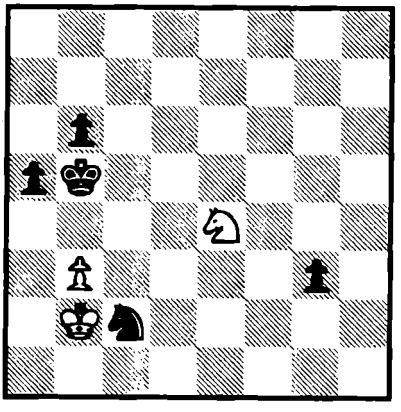
Of course, not the "active" 46...Kd4?? because 47 Nd3 wins the pawn and the game.

47 Nc2 Kf5 48 Kd3 Ne5+ 49 Kd4 Ng6! 50 Kd5 Nh4 51 Ne1 Ng6! Draw.

Black's King is well placed for the defense and the Knight ties down White's Knight to the defense of the g-pawn. There is absolutely no way for White to make any progress.

Knowing principle (1) allows White to handle with ease the position in Diagram 21, E. Mednis - B. Amos, Siegen Olympiad 1970, After Black's 101st move:

Diagram 21



102 Nxg3!

White is quite happy to enter a securely drawn N+2P vs.. N+P endgame. In a practical game, foolish is the greedy 102 Kxc2?! even though it appears that White can draw after 102,..g2: 103 Nc3+ Kb4 104 Ne2 Ka3 105 Ng1 b5 106 Ne2 Ka2 107 Nc1+ Ka1 108 Ne2 b4 109 Ng1 a4! 110 Ne2! (White loses after 110 bxa4?? Ka2!) 110...Ka2 (110...a3 offers no winning chances since Black's King remains boxed in on the a-file. After 110...g1=Q 111 Nxg1 Ka2 White is saved by a Knight check: 112 bxa4 b3+ 113 Kd2! b2 4 Ne2 b1=Q 115 Nc3+) 111 Nc1+ Ka3 112 Ne2 axb3+ 113 Kb1 and White is safe.

102 ...Nd4 103 Kc3 Draw.

Offered by Black. White's position is not as active as Black's was in the previous example, but it is sound enough for

a certain draw. A likely continuation is 103...Ne6 104 Ne4 Nc5 105 Nd6+ Kc6 (105...Ka6 106 b4) 106 Nc4 Na6 107 Kb2 Kb5 108 Kc3 when Black has shown no progress.

Drawn also is Diagram 22, M. Stean - E. Geller, European Team Championship, Bath England, 1973, after Black's 50th move. However, as drawn positions go, this is a fairly favorable one for Black: his pawns are flexible, King position good, while White's Knight is momentarily passive. The theoreticians can dismiss such positions as "obvious draws", *but in real life they are played out.* Thus, it is important to not only know how to defend them for a draw, but also how to squeeze them in trying for the win. GM Geller did try to win this position for over 50 moves.

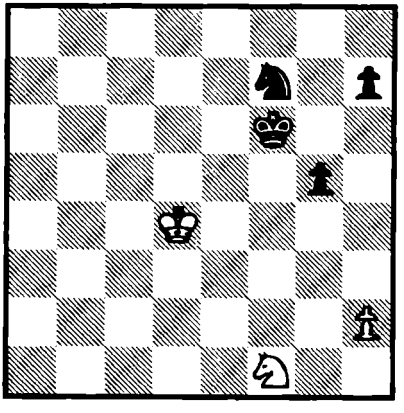


Diagram 22

Nevertheless, the weaker side should have no qualms in accepting a Diagram 22 type position in trying to secure the draw. Unlike, for instance, saving a draw in the R+B vs. R endgame, which requires significant specific theoretical knowledge as well as great care, normal sensible play is all that is required here. For the play to come, follow the ideas involved and do not be distracted by occurrences such as repetition of moves. These are also valid parts of practical chess strategy.

51 Ke4!

Quite correctly White's King wants to be where the action will be: the kingside.

51 ...Nd6+ 52 Kf3 Nf5 53 Nd2 Ng7

The immediate 53...h5 is of course playable, but Black is in no hurry. White cannot prevent that, anyway, and Black wants to get closer to the time control at move 56 before making any irreversible decision about pushing pawns. Always remember that Pawn moves cannot be taken back!

54 Kg4 Kg6 55 Ne4 h5+ 56 Kg3 Kf5 57 Nd6+ Ke5 58 Nc4+ Kd5 59 Nb6+ Ke4 60 Nd7!

Knights are most effective in attacking pawns from *behind*. White heads for f6 where it would accomplish one of the following: force Black's King back, tie down Black's Knight to the defense of the h-pawn or force the h-pawn forward.

60 ...Nf5+ 61 Kf2 Kf4

Compared to the starting diagram position Black has made definite progress in activating his King.

62 Nf6! Ng7

On his part, White's perceptive Knight maneuvers have caused Black's Knight to retreat. Throughout the game Black avoids playing ...h4, because with White's pawn on h3, Black's g-pawn could not advance without allowing a routine pawn exchange. The result of having a pawn formation of White: h3; Black: g5, h4 is that Black's g-pawn is considered to be "fixed" on g5, while White effectively has control of g4. Such positions offer Black scant winning chances.

63 h3!

Black was planning 63...g4 followed by ...h4, thereby further encroaching on White's space on the kingside. The text prevents this for all time. The Pawn on h3 is a bit more vulnerable than on h2, but White can protect it well enough. White's move turns out to be the last pawn move in the game since Black gets no attractive moment for playing either ...g4 or ...h4. Without a capture or pawn move this game can proceed only 50 moves before either side can claim a draw. Here that

moment is after move 113.

63 ...Ke5 64 Nd7+ Ke6 65 Nc5+ Kf5 66 Kf3!

Black has chased away the Knight, but now White's King gets a location one rank forward.

66 ...Ne6 67 Nd3

White can enter a drawn K & P endgame after 67 Nxe6 Kxe6 68 Ke2! when White establishes the distant opposition. This is sufficient to draw because the presence of the h-pawn robs Black of the usual winning opportunities.

67 ...Nf4 68 Nf2 Ng6 69 Ke3 Ne7 70 Nh1!

An excellent defensive maneuver, which keeps reappearing. White "threatens" a Ng3 attacking Black's h-pawn, while also being ready to return to f2 to protect his own pawn. There is no way for Black to break this plan.

70 ...Ke5 71 Nf2

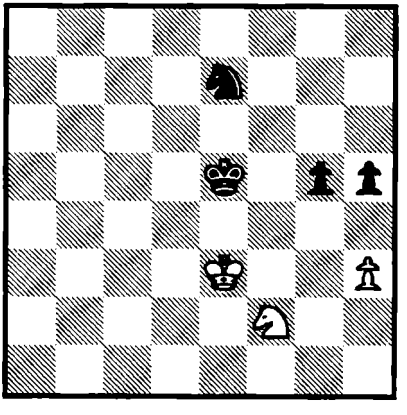


Diagram 23

Again, just as on move 67 (and later on move 79) White can enter a drawn K & P endgame after 71 Ng3 Nf5+ 72 Nxf5 Kxf5 73 Kf3. In all instances GM Stean declines the simplification. From a practical standpoint this is well justified. He can be sure that the Knight endgame is a theoretical draw. Yet the K & P endgame is either a theoretical draw or a theoretical

loss. If you know for sure, go for it. But do not guess! A wrong guess means turning a drawn Knight endgame into a lost K & P endgame, whereas a correct guess just speeds up the achievement of a draw. It is important to realize that the existence of the available draw in the K & P endgame is specific for the pawn formation and the King locations. In other words, White can achieve either the normal or distant oppositions as they are required.

71 ...Nf5+ 72 Kf3 Nd4+ 73 Ke3 Nc2+ 79 Kf3 Kf5 75 Nh1! Ne1+ 76 Ke2 Ng2 77 Kf3 Nh4+ 78 Ke3 Kg6 79 Nf2

Continuing with the tried and true. Again 79 Ng3 is playable when 79...Nf5+ 80 Nxf5 Kxf5 81 Kf3 is the same drawn position given above and 79...Ng2+ 80 Kf3 Nf4 allows the drawing 81 h4!.

79 ...Ng2+ 80 Kf3 Ne1+ 81 Ke2 Nc2 82 Kf3 Kf5 83 Nh1!

We have the same position as after White's 70th move, except that Black's Knight is on c2 rather than e7. This is of little importance. What matters is that White's Knight knows the right maneuver: Nh1! with the ideas Nf2 or Ng3.

83 ...Nd4+ 84 Ke3 Ne6 85 Kf3 Nc5 86 Nf2

Here too simpler seems 86 Ng3+ Kg6 87 Nh1.

86 ...Nd7 87 Nd1!

Here a bit of a change of plans is advisable. After 87 Nh1?! Ne5+ 88 Kf2 (88 Ke3?! Nc4+ 89 Kf3? Nd2+ 90 Ke3 Ne4) 88...Kf4 89 Ng3 Nd3+ 90 Kg2 h4 White has been pushed back into a very passive and unattractive position. Unless required, there is just no sense in ceding so much space to the enemy.

87 ...Ne5+ 88 Ke3 Nc4+ 89 Kf3 Ke5 90 Nf2! Kd4

Black quite logically attempts to penetrate with the King. Nevertheless, with the help of tactics, White is able to keep Black out. Note also how important it is for Black to keep

his h-pawn on h5 as otherwise White penetrates with his King after Kg4.

91 Kg3! Ne5

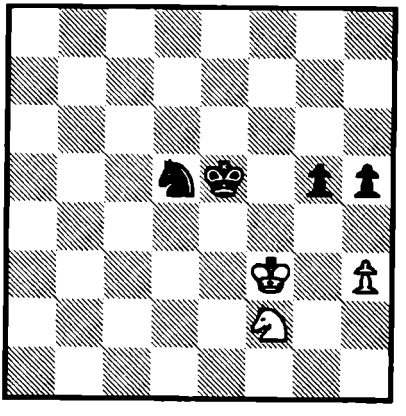
The immediate 91...Ke3 allows both 92 h4 g4 93 Nxg4+ and 92 Ng4+! hxg4 (otherwise 93 Nf6) 93 Kxg4 - in each case all of Black's pawns will be gone.

92 Nd1 Kd3 93 Nf2+ Ke3 94 Nd1+ Kd3 95 Nf2+ Kd4

An unwanted retreat, yet the active 95...Ke2 is foiled by 96 h4! g4 97 Nxg4!! Nxg4 (97...hxg4 98 h5) 98 K4 Nf6 99 Kg5 Kf3 100 Kxf6 Kg4 101 Ke5 Kxh4 102 Kf4, with a draw.

96 Nd1 ND3 97 Kf3 Ne1+ 98 Kf2 ND3+ 99 Kf3 Ke5 100 Ke3 Nf4 101 Nf2 Nd5+ 102 Kf2

Diagram 24



We are pretty much back to the position seen thirty moves earlier!

102 ...Nf6 103 Ke3 Kf5 104 Kf3 Nd5 105 Nh1! Ke5 Draw.

Offered by Black who finally decides to give up the ghost. White would have played 106 Ng3! which forces the undesirable 106...h4 when Black's winning chances are scant after 107 Ne4 Kf5 108 Nd6+ etc. Black cannot keep his pawn formation whole with 106...Nf6 (or 106...Nf4) because of 107 Nxh5! Nxh5 108 Kg4.

A long endgame? Yes, definitely. Not particularly interesting? Quite probably so. Of practical value? Very much so! And that's what this book is about!

To enable the stronger side to win with the type of pawn configurations shown in Diagrams 20-22, something special must exist. One such situation is shown in Diagram 25, D. Rajkovic - R. Maric, Yugoslavia 1974, White on move. At the moment White is up two pawns, yet after the imminent loss of the f-pawn White will be left with the apparently unwinnable N + 2P vs. N + P configuration discussed earlier. However, White finds a most enlightening maneuver to make life unpleasant for Black. If Black captures the f-pawn, he will wind up with an imprisoned Knight. This is how it was done:

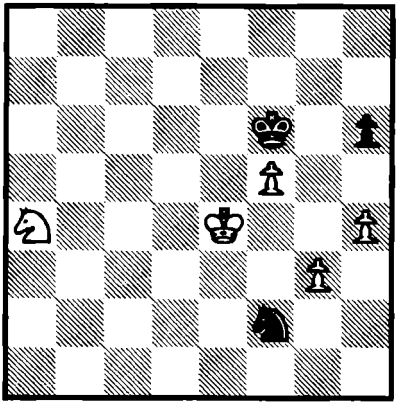


Diagram 25

1 Ke3!!

Insufficient is 1 Kf3?! because Black's Knight becomes active after 1...Nd3!: 2 Kg4 (or 2 g4 h5! when neither 3 Nh6 nor 3 g5+ Kxf5 will win because Black's pieces are very active.) 2...Ne5+ 3 Kh5 Kxf5 4 Kxh6 Kg4 and again Black's active piece location will stop White's pawns: 5 h5 Nf7+! 6 Kg7 (6 Kg6 Ne5+ 7 Kf6 Kxh5!) 6...Kxh5! 7 Kxf7 Kg4. In all of these variations White is handicapped by having his Knight offside.

1 ...Nb3!?

This is the only way to prevent White from successfully protecting the f-pawn. After other Knight moves White

wins with the simple 2 Kf4. After the text, 2 g4? again allows 2...h5! with a draw. White must, therefore, continue with his original plan.

2 Kf3! Kxf5 3 Nc3!!

The Knight must join the fray as otherwise Black's Knight cannot be captured. The impetuous 3 g4+? allows Black to draw: 3...Kf6! 4 Nc3 h5! 5 gxh5 Kf5 6 h6 Nf4 7 h5 Ne6! and Black will blockade the forward pawn with 8...Nf8 - analysis by GM Rajkovic.

3 ...Ng1+ 4 Kf2!

The trapped Knight must not be allowed to escape which would happen after 4 Kg2? Kg4! 5 Ne4 Ne2.

4 ...Kg4 5 Ne4 Nf3

Black acquiesces to a lost K & P endgame. The alternative is to lose the trapped Knight: 5...Kf5 6 Nd2! (the K & P endgame after 6 Kxg1? Kxe4 is drawn because Black's King is very active.) 6...Kg4 7 Nf1! Nh3+ (7...Nf3 8 Ne3+; 7...h5 8 Kxg1) 8 Kg2 h5 9 Ne3+.

6 Nf6+ Kf5 7 Kxf3 Kxf6 8 Ke4!

While all the potential endgames from Stean - Geller were drawn, here White wins by force, because there are just enough differences. The active King is the key and the pawn placement is just right. If now 8...h5, White gains the opposition with 9 Kf4! and wins thereby. Yet note that the immediate 8 Kf4?? h5 9 Ke4 Ke6 gives Black the opposition and the draw.

8 ...Ke6 9 g4! Kf6 10 Kd5!

The active King penetrates further and White wins.

10 ...h5 11 g5+ Ke7 12 Ke5 Kf7 13 Kd6! Black resigns.

White's further progress is inevitable: 13...Kg7 14 Ke7!

Kg6 15 Kf8! Kh7 16 Kf7 Kh8 17 Kg6! etc.

(2) N + 2 P vs. N + P gives excellent winning chances if the extra pawn is in the form of a sound passed pawn.

If we again go back and look at Diagrams 20-22 and the ensuing play, you will see that the stronger side could not create a passed pawn without allowing a routine exchange of a pair of pawns, which would have brought about a drawn N + P vs. N endgame. However, if the stronger side already has a viable passed pawn, this changes the complexion of the position considerably. In all cases the winning chances are excellent; in some positions the win an be forced. An excellent example of a won position is Diagram 26, R. Sanguinetti - N. Padevsky, Nice Olympiad 1974, after Black's 63rd move.

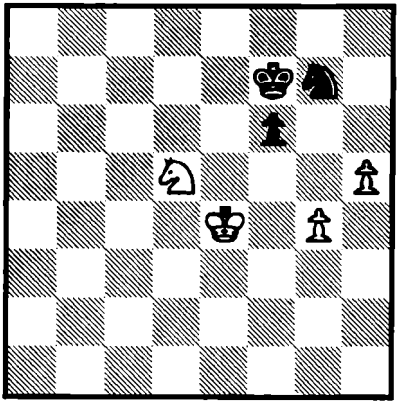


Diagram 26

Here White has a number of large pluses: a nice passed protected h-pawn (the RP being the most annoying pawn for a Knight to stop), centralized active King and centralized active Knight. On the other side, Black's King is passive and his Knight is even more so. Therefore, it should come as no surprise that White has a forced win:

64 Nf4!

Frees d5 for White's King, while taking away e6 from Black's King.

64 ...Ne8

Hoping to bring the Knight into the game. Because of Black's passive piece placement, sacrificing the f-pawn to split White's pawns brings no relief: 64...f5+ 65 gxf5 Kf6 66 Nd5+ Kg5 (66...Kf7 67 h6 etc.) 67 f6 Ne8 68 Ke5! and White wins (analysis by GM Padevsky).

65 Kd5! Nc7+ 66 Kc6! Na6

Insufficient, but 66...Ne8 allows 67 Kd7 when both 67...Ng7 and 67...Kf8 lose to 68 h6, while 67...f5 is foiled by 68 g5.

67 Nd3!!

Imprisoning Black's Knight and threatening to capture it with 68 Kb7. There is no hope in 67...Nb8+?! 68 Kc7 Na6+ 69 Kb7 since White wins routinely after 69...Kg7 70 Kxa6 Kh6 71 Nf4 Kg5 72 Ne6+. Black therefore aims for immediate counterplay, setting also a sophisticated trap.

67 ...Kg7!? 68 Kd6!!

Heading for the Kingside is now required. There is no time for 68 Kb7? Kh6 69 Kxa6 because after 69...f5!! 70 gxf5 Kxh5 White cannot save his remaining pawn.

68 ...Kf7

Or 68...Kh6 69 Ke7 Kg5 70 Nf2 f5 71 Nh3+ Kxg4 72 h6 and the pawn queens.

69 Kd7!

Note how relentlessly White's King move deeper into Black's territory. Black's King again has to give ground because 69...Nb8+ 70 Kc7 loses as given in the note after White's 67th move.

69 ...Kg7 70 Ke7! Nc7 71 Nf4!

Reestablishing the Knight placements as after move 65, but with the huge difference that White's King has penetrated

decisively. The end is near.

71 ...Na6 72 Ne6+ Black resigns.

White wins easily with the two connected passed pawns.

However, the position of Diagram 27, T. Weinberger - P., Ostovic, Cleveland 1975, after White's 49th move, is nowhere as favorable for the stronger side as was Diagram 26. Black does have a safe, sound, extra passed pawn. Yet because the respective Kings and Knights are about equivalent as far as active placement is concerned, the position is tenable for White. Nevertheless, to first hold and ultimately draw such positions is a most thankless task. In practical play the winning chances for the stronger side are always very high. White loses this game without apparently making any major errors. His moves seem plausible enough, yet to draw such positions two needs are required: (1) knowing the proper strategic defensive approach, and (2) utmost technical care in executing the defense. The instructive game course is:

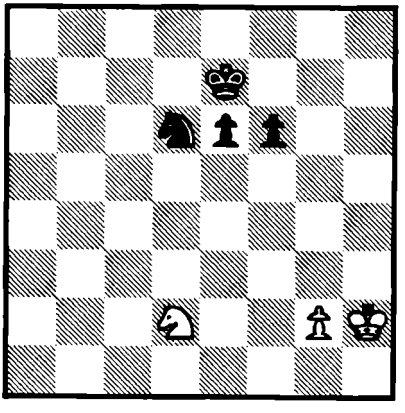


Diagram 27

49 ...e5!

Not so much to get the pawn going but to get the King going via e6 and d5. Therefore less effective is 49...f5.
50 g4?!

Is this a good move or not? Its purpose of course, is to prevent ...f5, but if that move is so good, why didn't Black play

it on his previous move? Anyway, there are two reasons why I do not like it. Firstly, the pawn is more exposed and vulnerable on g4 than back home on g2. Secondly, the King is a tempo behind in marching forward toward the center. Sounder and better is the immediate 50 Kg3.

50 ...Ke6 51 Kg3 Kd5 52 Kf3 Kd4!

Note how Black first activates his King as much as possible before undertaking anything else.

53 Nb3+

I would have preferred the blockading 53 Nf1 Kd3 54 Ne3! with the idea 55 Nd5. However, the text is also satisfactory, if properly followed up.

53...Kc4! 54 Nd2+ Kd3 55 Nb3 Nf7!

Heading for g5 where the Knight would serve a dual purpose: 1) blockade the g-pawn, 2) go to e4 at its convenience. There is nothing immediate in the position, e.g.:

(1) 55...Ne4?! 56 Nc1+ forces the retreat 56...Kd4 57 Ne2+ Kd5 since 56...Kc2? 57 Kxe4 Kxc1 58 g5 is an immediate draw.
(2) 55...e4+?! 56 Kf4 e3 57 Kf3! is premature because all that Black has "achieved" is to weaken his e-pawn. The position is not yet ripe for the advance of the e-pawn, as White's King is placed too well. Always be careful with pawn moves - you can't take them back!

56 Nc5+ Kd4 57 Ne6+

Since Knights are most effective in attacking pawns from behind, more efficient here is 57 Nd7! Ng5+ 58 Ke2 Ne4 59 Nb6! and how is Black to progress? White's King blockades the e-pawn while also guarding the important e3 square and his Knight is ready to return to d7 to watch the f-pawn.

57 ...Kd5 58 Nc7+ Kd6 59 Nb5+?!

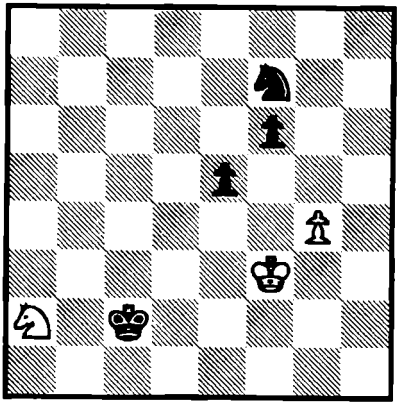
Dubious on its own merits and on the way to committing the decisive error. It surely was logical (and correct) to chase the King back with 59 Ne8+! Ke7 and then to play either 60 Nc7 or 60 Ng7. With Black's King back on e7 it is clear that he has made no progress for winning purposes.

59 ...Kc5 60 Nc3?

The losing moment. The knight must be kept active with 60 Nc7!. Then White holds after both 60...Ng5+ 61 Ke3 and 60...Kd4 61 Ne6+ Kd3 62 Nc5+ etc. However, after the passive text, Black's King + Knight are able to penetrate.

60 ...Kd4 61 Ne2+ Kd3 62 Nc1+ KC2 63 Na2

Diagram 28



Placing the Knight on the edge cannot work out well. But also after the central 63 Ne2 Black plays 63...Kd2! followed by 64...Ng5(+) and his forces are in.

63 ...Kd2!

The decisive maneuver. Black's e-pawn is now ready to start its winning run. White has no time for 64 Ke4 Ng5+ 65 Kf5 because after 65...e4! there is no way to stop the pawn.

64 Nb4 Ng5+ 65 Kf2 Ne4+ 66 Kf3 Nc3!

With Black's King + Knight working together, it is certain that the e-pawn can advance. All that remains for Black

is to exercise the necessary care so that White cannot sacrifice his Knight for the e-pawn while also being able to exchange off Black's remaining pawn.

67 Nc6 e4+ 68 Kf4 e3 69 g5

If 69 Nd4, 69...Ne2+ is the end.

69 ...Nd5+

Of course, not 69...fxg5+ 70 Kxg5 e2?? (70...Nb5! still wins because the pawn gets to the 7th rank) 71 Nd4! e1=Q 72 Nf3+, with a draw.

The Knight check has two points. In the first place, 70 Ke4 allows 70...e2! since after 71 Nd4 the e-pawn queens with check.

70 Kg4 Kd3!

Taking away d4 from the Knight. None of White's tactics work, e.g. 70 g6 e2 71 g7 e1=Q 72 g8=Q Qg1+ followed by 73...Qxg8, or 70 Nb4+ Nxb4 71 gxf6 Nc6 72 f7 Ne5+.

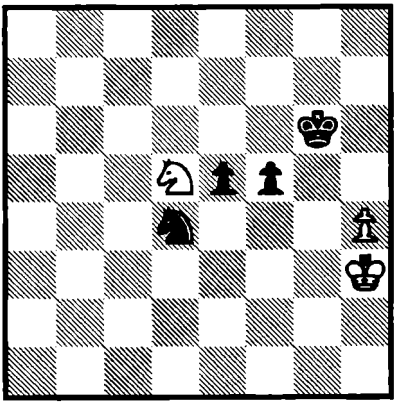
71 gxf6 Nxf6+ Black wins.

The second point of 69...Nd5+: the Knight not only protected his f-pawn, but is also able to recapture with check. After the text we have reached the Diagram 9 position discussed earlier. The conclusion was 72 Kf4 e2 73 Ne5+ when *White* resigned in view of 73...Ke2! 74 Nf3 Kd1 75 Kg3 Ne4+ 76 Kg2 Nd2.

Not only instructive, but also surprising is the course of play from Diagram 29 (on the following page), C. Zuidema - P. Benko, Skopje Olympiad 1972, After Black's 51st move. Black has two beautiful, faultless, connected, passed central pawns, whereas White's passed h-pawn can be readily stopped - and yet it turns out that Black cannot win. There are two reasons for this. Firstly, the fact that White's passed pawn is a h-pawn makes it harder for Black's Knight to cope with it. Secondly, White's pawn and Black's pawns are just close enough so that

White's King can do two jobs: protect his pawn and help stop Black's pawns. White's technique in gaining the draw is impeccable:

Diagram 29



52 Kg3!

White's Knight has a flexible and active central location so that there is no point in unnecessarily moving it. If Black now plays 52...Kh5, then 53 Nf6+ chases it back. Therefore Black embarks on a piece redeployment: the Knight will be used to stop the h-pawn and the King will try to assist his pawns' advance.

52 ...Nc6 53 Kh3! Nd8 54 Kg3 Nf7 55 Kh3 Nh6 56 Kg3 Ng4 57 Kh3 Kf7 58 h5!

Now that Black's King has given up control of h5, White can and *should* advance the pawn. This increases his counterchances.

53 ...Ke6 59 Nc3!

From here the Knight serves both to keep out Black's King and blockade the pawns, e.g. 59...e4? 60 Nxe4!

59 ...Nh6 60 Kh4 Nf7

Necessary to prevent 61 Kg5, but the Knight here is

passive and therefore of little help for its pawns' coming advances.

61 Ne2!

The King must retain his active position so that at the moment the Knight has to shoulder the defense load.

61 ...Kf6

Basically a holding operation. Black sees that nothing immediate is good enough to win and thus takes some time off for reflection, possibly time killing until adjournment or to hope for a misstep on White's part. The direct 61...Kd5 leads to the same position as in the game after Black's 71st move and White draws with 62 h6!. To make progress Black eventually will have to advance his pawns, yet the time never seems to be ripe. No matter which pawn Black moves, that frees squares for White's pieces to set up a blockade. For instance, 61...e4 62 Kg3 Ke5 63 Nf4! or 61...f4 62 Kg4 Nh6+ 63 Kg5 f3 53 Ng3.

62 Nc3 Kg7 63 Nd5! Kh6 64 Ne7!

Keeping the Knight active. If now 64...f4, then 65 Kg4 followed by Ng6/Nd5/Nc6 (depending upon Black's play) when the Knight sacrifices itself for both of Black's pawns.

64 ...Nd6 65 Ng8+! Kg7 66 Ne7 Kf7 67 Nd5 Ke6 68 Nc7+

Equivalent is the immediate 68 Nc3. With the text White demonstrates that Black's King lacks access to d6.

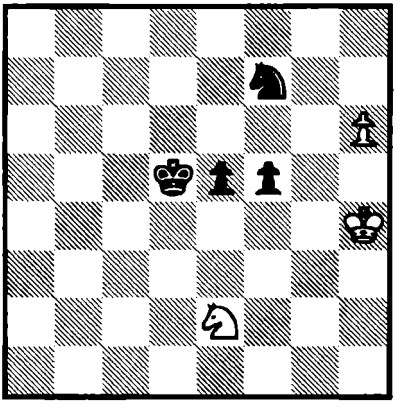
68 ...Kd7 69 Nd5 Nf7 70 Nc3! Ke6 71 Ne2

Exactly the same position has arisen as after White's 61st move when Black played 61...Kf6. Black now makes a more determined effort, but White turns it away with some deft tactics.

71 ...Kd5 72 h6!!

See Diagram 30 on the following page.

Diagram 30



With Black's King too far away from the kingside, White's pawn can advance. If the King heads back, White draws as follows: 72...Ke6 73 Kh5 Kf6 74 h7! Kg7 (or 74...Nh8 75 Ng3 Ng6 76 Kh6) 75 h8=Q+! Kxh8 (75...Nxh8 76 Kg5) 76 Kg6 Nd6 77 Kf6 e4 78 Ke5.

72 ...Nxh6 73 Kg5 Ke4

Obviously the only try.

74 Kxh6 f4 Draw.

The game was adjourned here and subsequently called a draw without resumption of play. The following important principle applies here: **The Knight usually stops King + two connected passed pawns if its own King can help out.** White's King does just get back in time: 75 Kg5! Ke3 76 Nc3! f3 (76...e4?! 77 Nd5+ and 78 Nxf4) 77 Kf5! f2 (77...Kd3 78 Ne4) 78 Nd1+ Ke2 79 Nxf2 Kxf2 80 Kxe5.

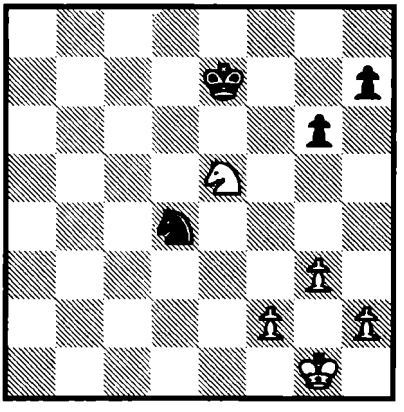
Section 3: Knight + 3 Pawns vs. Knight + 2 Pawns

For this case also, there are two broad important principles.

(1) N + 3 P vs. N + 2 P endgames are drawn, but only if the position is a "normal" one.

The presence of more pawns, compared to the basic N + 2 P vs. N + P endgame, significantly increases the stronger side's winning chances. The defending side must have a rather normal, symmetrical pawn formation to hold the draw. An excellent practical example of such a drawn position shown in Diagram 31, L. Christiansen - J. Kaplan, Cleveland 1975, after White's 38th move. The only problem that Black has is that the f-pawn is missing. With good play Black is sure to hold the draw. Play continued:

Diagram 31



38 ...Ne6

Black's only interest here is to make the time control on move 40. Therefore there is little to discuss in regard to the reasoning behind his moves.

39 Kg2 Kf6 40 Nc4 Kg7 41 Ne3

The game was adjourned here with White sealing his move. Home analysis showed that with correct defense Black can draw.

41 ...Kf6 42 f4 h5!

A well thought out move. Its primary purpose is to prevent White from mobilizing his pawn chain via a later g4. After the text, for White to get in g4 will require allowing the routine exchange of h-pawns, thus bringing Black closer to the draw.

The secondary purpose is to enable Black to play an opportune ...h4, thus again achieving the welcome routine exchange of h-pawns. Of course, quite wrong is 42...g5? as after 43 f5 White gets a protected passed pawn and a most likely win.

43 Kf3 Nd8

Since his King is already well placed, Black now maneuvers the Knight to a good defensive location. At this moment 43...h4? is premature since after 44 g4 Black's h-pawn will turn out to be a serious weakness.

44 h3 Nf7 45 Ke4 Ke6!

Keeping White's King out of d5.

46 Nc4 Kf6

Yet now the position has changed sufficiently so that 47 Kd5 can be met by 47...g5!, with Black achieving a welcome pawn swap.

47 Nd2 Ke6! 48 Nf3 Nd6+ 49 Kd3 Kf6 50 Ng5 Kf5

Black's King and Knight have good active locations, while his g- and h-pawns are readily defensible. For winning purposes White has made no progress, as compared to our starting position.

51 Ke3 Nc4+ 52 Kf3 Nd2+ 53 Ke2

See Diagram 32 on the following page. This move allows a forced draw, yet it is very clear that Black was quite well holding it, anyway.

53 ...Ne4!

Black grabs the opportunity to simplify into a theoretically drawn K + P endgame. i do want to caution the practical player to be at least 100% sure before entering *voluntarily* a pawn down K + P endgame. The important practical point is

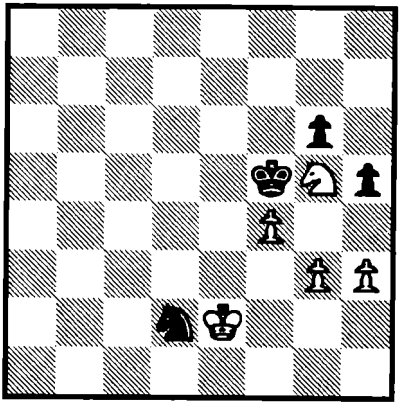


Diagram 32. after White's 52nd move

that Black has no theoretical need to do so, since after e.g. 53...Nc4 he keeps the drawish status quo.

54 Nxe4 Kxe4 55 h4

Forced as otherwise Black plays ...h4 with an obvious draw: 55 Kf2 h4 56 Kg2 Ke3 37 Kh2 Kf3! 53 gxh4 Kxf4.

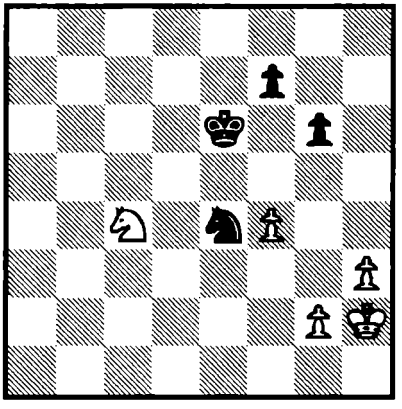
55 ...Kf5! 56 Kf3 KF6! 57 Ke3 Kf5 58 Kf3 Draw.

Offered by White. The problem with the pawn formation from White's viewpoint is that to make progress he will have to play g4 and will then be left with an unwinnable f- and h-pawn vs. g-pawn structure. For instance, 58...Kf6 59 g4 hxg4+ 60 Kxg4 Kf7 61 Kg4 Kg7 and no matter whether White advances the f- or h-pawn, Black gets safely in front of the remaining pawn. Moreover, after 58...Kf6 White's King is not able to penetrate directly, e.g. 59 Ke4 Ke6 60 Kd4 Kd6 61 Kc4 Kc6 and Black keeps the vertical opposition. Then 62 Kb4?? even allows Black's King to penetrate with 62...Kd5 and win.

Something like a mirror image - for Black - of Diagram 31 is shown in Diagram 33, E. Geller - L. Portisch, Portoroz Play-Off 1973, after White's 53rd move. Again the pawn formation is a rather normal one, except that instead of missing the f-pawn as in Diagram 31, here Black has no h-pawn. As you will see, also his play will be the mirror image of that from Dia-

gram 31. With accurate and logical play GM Portisch is able to hold the position for a draw - until something unbelievable happens at the very end!

Diagram 33



53 ...Kf5

But not 53...g5? 54 fxg5 when White has a passed h-pawn and fantastic winning chances. While it is quite true that Black wants to exchange pawns, he only wants to do it on *his terms*. This means a symmetrical type of exchange, such as f-pawn for f-pawn, or Black's g-pawn for White's h-pawn or Black's f-pawn for White's g-pawn. The last thing that Black wants to allow is a passed pawn.

54 g3 Nc5 55 Kg2 Nd3 56 Kf3 Nc5 57 Nd6+

As will be seen in the course of the game, it is insufficient for White to play only with the King + Knight. It was necessary to start utilizing the pawn majority with 57 g4+!. White thereby gains space and an eventual ...f5 can be met by g5! when Black's g-pawn can turn out to be a serious weakness.

57 ...Ke6 58 Ne4 Nd7!

An excellent defensive spot. Since at this time there is nothing vulnerable in White's camp, "attacking" moves such as ...Nb3 or ...Nd3 serve no purpose. Exchanging Knights leads to a normally lost K + P endgame.

59 Ke3

Also 59 g4 is met by 59...f5!, with an attack on the Knight.

59 ...f5!

The drawing maneuver which is the mirror image of that from Diagram 31. It paralyzes White's pawn majority since a later g4 allows the symmetrical ...fxg4 pawn exchange and with it a more securely drawn for Black N + 2P vs. N + P endgame. The text turns out to be the last pawn move in the game. This was Black's sealed move and the game was resumed after a four hour break for another two sessions (32 moves) of play.

With the help of hindsight we can now say that from Diagram 33 Black should have played the immediate 53...f5!. GM Portisch was reluctant to make such a committal decision before reaching the time control on move 56.

60 Ng5+ Kf6

Black's King is going to remain near his weakened g-pawn. There is little point in the "aggressive" 60...Kd5.

61 Kd4 Kg7! 62 Ne6+

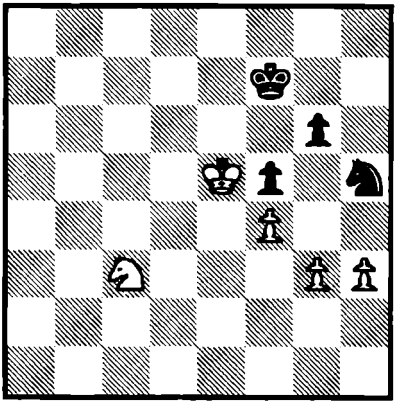
62 Kd5?! leads nowhere: 62...Nf6+ 63 Ke6? Nh5 and White's g-pawn goes lost.

62 ...Kf7 63 Nc7 Nf6 64 Nd5 Nd7!

Black has achieved what to him looks like an impregnable defensive formation and he is not about to depart from it except for the best of reasons. Therefore he avoids 64...Ne4?! 65 g4 Nf2 66 g5! Nxh3 67 Ke3! when his Knight is trapped and may well go lost.

65 Nc7 Nf6 66 Nd5 Nd7 67 Nc3 Nf6 68 Ke5 Nh5!

Diagram 34



Please note how the lack of having played 57 g4+! has given Black's Knight more scope.

69 Ne2 Ke7! 70 Kd5 Nf6+ 71 Ke5 Nh5 72 Kd4 Nf6 73 Ke3 Nd5+ 74 Kf3 Kf7! 75 Nc1 Kg7!

Black is more than happy to keep the status quo.

76 Nd3 Kf7 77 Kf2 Kg7 78 Ne5 Nf6 79 Ke3 Kh7 80 Nd3

It is obvious that White has made no progress over the last twenty moves. He again refrains from 80 g4 because of 80...Nd5+ 81 Kf3 fxg4+ etc. GM Geller cannot get himself to concede the draw. See what happens soon...

80 ...Kh6 81 Ne5 Kg7 82 Nc4 Kf7 83 Kf3 Nd5 84 Ke2 Kg7 85 Kd3 Nf6 86 Ke3 Kf7 *White overstepped the time limit and lost.*

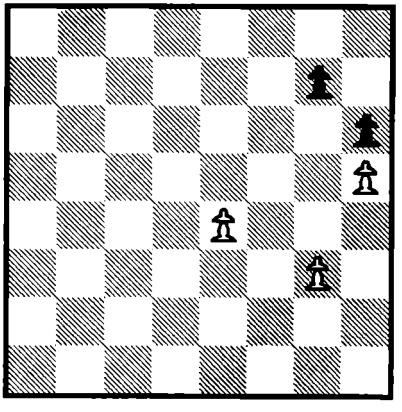
As GM Geller was playing 87 Kf3 his flag fell and obviously he had to be forfeited. How can this have happened in such an "easy to play" position? The explanation is almost unbelievable. As a result of a massive mental block - induced no doubt by over-exertion of his nervous system - he had marked down on his score sheet move 84 (instead of the correct 88) as the end of the time control. Thus "with the time control over" Geller paid no more attention to the clock until he was forfeited. This was more than a single tragedy as exactly this missing half point prevented him from reaching the 1974

Candidates Matches. Talking about "bad luck": the observant reader will have no doubt noticed that out of two Knight endgames with a one pawn advantage (see also Diagram 24!) Geller scored exactly one half point! The meaning of this: Grandmasters too are very human and under the pressure of competitive play strange things can and do occur.

(2) In N + 3P vs. N + 2P endgames, any steps toward dissimilarity of pawn configurations significantly increase the stronger side's winning chances. A passed pawn is almost a sure win.

Whenever the pawn formations are not balanced or symmetrical, the stronger side has excellent chances for penetration and victory. The lack of symmetry necessarily means that many squares are either weak or insufficiently guarded and the Knight's inherent agility can exploit such factors. This is in marked contrast to the Bishop who is rather limited in its options because it can only work on squares of its own color.

Diagram 35

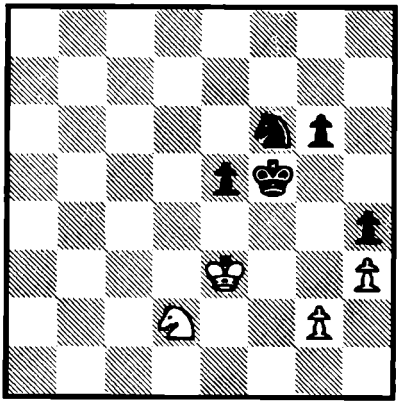


Let us illustrate this important point by considering the thematic pawn configuration of Diagram 35. For the sake of reality add Kings; White's at f4 and Black's at e6 are surely reasonable locations. We can turn this position into a same color Bishop endgame by adding, e.g., a White Bishop on e3 and a Black Bishop on f6, giving us dark square Bishops, or by putting a White Bishop on e2 and a Black Bishop on a4 we get a light square Bishop endgame. No matter - given reasonably correct play by Black - all these endgames are drawn. Black can prevent White's King from penetrating, while the Bishop

by itself cannot achieve anything either. However, replace the Bishops with Knights and the situation changes markedly!

Now consider Diagram 36, which arose in H. Rossetto - L. Stein, Amsterdam Interzonal 1964, after Black's 73rd move.

Diagram 36



The pawn formation is exactly the same as in Diagram 35, except that, as so often happens in real life, it is Black who is up the pawn. this position arose from a N + 4P vs. N + 3P endgame - see the next section for play up to this point. At first glance it may appear that White's position is defensible, yet that is incorrect. Black's Knight will soon be able to push back White's King and then Black's King will start penetrating. This is how it happened.

74 Nb3 e4!

The advanced pawn is safe and there is no reason to tarry. If now 75 Kd4, then 75...Kf4!. It falls upon the Knight to try to hold back Black's King.

75 Nd4+ Ke4 76 Nc6+ Kd6

Of course, not 87...Kd5? 77 Ne7+ winning the g-pawn.

77 Nd4?!

Passive resistance will not work. Knight activity is always of essence in such endgames and therefore the only

worthwhile try is 77 Nd8!.

77 ...Kd5! 78 Ne2 Ke5

Black has successfully obtained his first objective: his King is safe from checks and after the imminent ...Nd5+, White's King will be pushed back.

79 g3?!

Leads to a vulnerable h-pawn, thereby speeding up the loss. In inferior positions, *always refrain from crating new weaknesses.* Inevitably this only makes matters worse. There was nothing better than the retreat 79 Kf2. in the long run White would lose similarly to the game continuation, but would not have the additional handicap of an indefensible h-pawn.

79 ...g5!

Yes, of course! Black keeps the bind created by the advanced h-pawn. White's h-pawn has become very vulnerable because Black can easily attack it. On the other hand, Black's h-pawn only *appears* weak, because White is in no position to menace it.

80 gxh4 gxh4 81 Ng1 Nd5+ 82 Kf2 Kd4!

King penetration starts.

83 Ne2+ Kd3 84 Nc1+ Kc2!

After the immediate 84...Kd2 White could continue the checks with 85 Nb3+. With the text move/maneuver Black ensures that when his King gets to the decisive d2 square, White's Knight will have no checks.

85 Ne2 Kd2 36 Nd4 Nf4

The vulnerability of the h-pawn is now obvious. White's coming attempt to go after Black's h-pawn will be too little too late. Yet the defensive 87 Nb3+ Kd3 88 Nc5+ Kd4 89 Nb3+ Ke5 loses the h-pawn for nothing. With a two pawn advantage

Black then has an elementary win.

87 Nf5 Nxh3+ 88 Kf1 e3!

The pawn will get to the 7th rank in safety and thereby ensure the win.

89 Nxh4 e2+ 90 Kg2 Ng5! White resigns.

Compared to the previous diagram, Diagram 37, R. Bernard - Janicki, Lublin II 1974, after Black's 41st move, is a more favorable case for the defender because his forces have assumed somewhat more active locations. Nevertheless, the extra pawn in the form of a passer and the holey Black position, mean that White's Knight will be able to maneuver successfully and thus in due course set up his King for the decisive penetrating march. Though the position is theoretically won for White, it is not yet resignable by Black.

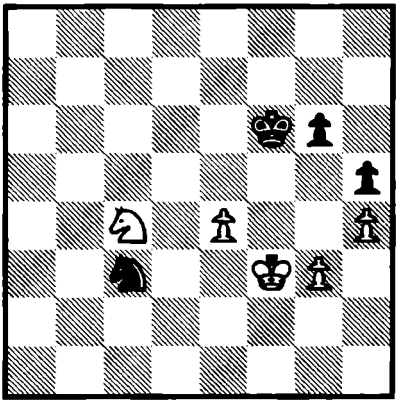


Diagram 37

42 Nb2

A sophisticated redeployment. The Knight is to first go to d3 and then possibly to f4, before the King is centralized. on d3 the Knight combines its offensive and defensive functions better than from c4.

42 ...g5?!

The same type of error as in the previous game: the

defending side weakens its remaining pawn. As the game goes, this has no direct bearing, but nevertheless is wrong since it decreases the flexibility of potential defenses. Correct is to keep the status quo via 42...Ke5 43 Nd3+ Kf6!.

43 Nd3 Nb5 44 Ke3 Nc3 45 Nf2!

On the way to h3 from where it will force Black's g-pawn to declare its intentions. No matter what they are, White will regain control of f4.

45 ...Nb5 46 Nh3 gxh4

Equally unattractive is 46...g4 47 Nf4 Ke5 48 Nd3+! (48 Nxh5?! Nc3! is unclear) 48...Kf6 49 Nb4! Ke5 (49...Nc3 50 Kd3!) 50 Nc6+ Kf6 51 Nd4! followed by 52 Kf4 when the centralized White pieces control the board.

47 gxh4 Ke5 48 Nf4 Nc3 49 Nd3+ Kf6 50 Ne1!

Another fine Knight maneuver. It heads for f3 where it will accomplish two important objectives: keep out Black's King from e5, while protecting the h-pawn. Then White's King will be free to start penetrating via the queenside along the d-file.

50 ...Ke5 51 Nf3+ Kf6 52 Kd3 Nb5 53 Kc4 Nd6+ 54 Kd5

The rest is relatively easy. Still it is instructive how White makes use of both the King and Knight for the coming advance of the e-pawn.

54 ...Nf7 55 e5+ Kf5 56 e6 Nh6 57 Nd4+

Continual care is required. The obvious 57 e7? throws away the win after 57...Ng8! when 58 e8=Q=R=B allows 58...Nf6+, while 58 e8=N Ne7+ 59 Kd4 Ng6 also looks drawish.

57 ...Kf6 58 Kd6 Ng8 59 Nc6 Nh6 60 e7 Nf5+ 61 Kd7 Nxe7 62 Nxe7

Black's Knight has gone lost, yet White's Knight will still have to come up with some nice maneuvers for the win.

62 ...Ke5 63 Ke8 Ke6! 64 Kf8 KF6!

Black's King is doing his best to contain the White King. To win, White's Knight must start a long journey so that Black's King is pulled away from his pawn just long enough for White to achieve a won K + h-pawn vs. K endgame.

65 Nd5+! Ke5 66 Ne3 Kf4 67 Ng2+! Kg3 68 Kg7 Black resigns.

After 68...Kxg2 69 Kg6 Kg3 70 Kxh5 Kf4 71 Kg6 Black's King cannot get back in time.

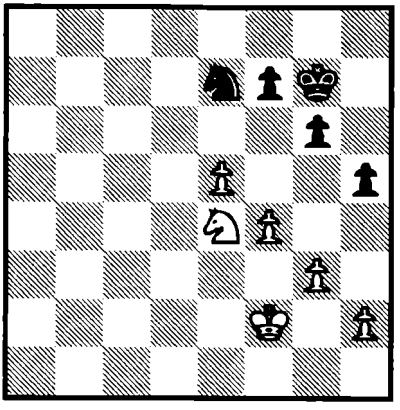
Section 4: Knight + 4 Pawns vs. Knight + 3 Pawns

The situation here is quite clear: *N + 4P vs. N + 3P endgames are almost always won.*

The burden is just too great for the defender: he has three pawns to worry about and the enemy Knight will be too versatile on the attack. There are two methods/goals that should be used in going for the win: (1) create an enemy pawn weakness, attack and capture the pawn, thereby gaining a routinely won endgame two pawns up, and or (2) simplify down into a won N + 3P vs. N + 2P endgame where the extra pawn is a viable passed one, as shown in Diagrams 36 and 37.

A perfect example of how to win from a semi-blockaded pawn formation is shown by the play from Diagram 38, M. Taimanov - G. Stahlberg, Zurich Candidates 1953, after Black's 43rd move. Again a Bishop endgame would be drawn, yet a win is certain with Knights. White's pluses are obvious: he is up a sound pawn and has a clear spatial advantage. Yet Black has no fundamental weaknesses. How should White progress? The immediate task is as follows: (1) centralize the King on e4, followed by (2) trying to crate a weakness in Black's camp.

Diagram 38



44 Kf3 Kf8 45 Nd6 Nc6 46 Ke4 Ke7 47 f5!

With White's King + Knight activated it is time to start action. The text is the first assault on Black's pawn formation. Black cannot afford to capture as that saddles him with an isolated, chronically weak h-pawn: 47...gxf5+? 48 Nxf5+ Kf8 49 Nd4! Ne7 50 Ne2! Kg7 51 Nf4 Kh6 52 h4!, when Black is in zugzwang. The Knight must move and White's King penetrates decisively via f5.

Of course, it would be completely wrong for White to "prepare" the f5 advance with 47 h3 and 48 g4 since that allows Black to exchange off the h-pawns and reach a drawish position. *The stronger side must avoid routine pawn exchanges.*

47 ...Nb4 48 f6+!

Also good is 48 fxg6 fxg6 49 Nb5! followed by 50 Nd4, leading to the type of position shown in Diagram 37. Nevertheless, the text is even stronger as it ensures White a fantastic space advantage and allows his King to penetrate. White's remaining task will then be to devise a way to break the semi-blockade.

Black's King now has to head back since, if 48...Ke6, 49 Nb7 threatens both 50 Nc5 mate and 50 Nd8+, thus forcing the retreating 49...Kd7 50 Nc5+ Ke8, anyway.

48 ...Kf8 49 Nb7 Na6 50 Kd5 Nc7+ 51 Kd6 Nb5+ 52 Kd7 Nd4 53 Nc5!

Establishing control of e6. White's next objective is to break - at the proper moment, with e6. If Black now plays 53...Nf3, White continues as in the game with 54 Kd8! (54...Nxe5 55 Nd7+ wins).

53 ...Nf5 54 Kd8!

The immediate 54 e6?! fxe6 55 Kxe6 is premature because it is unclear how White is to progress after 55...Nd4+. Therefore White prepares to first push Black's King back further.

54 ...Nd4 55 Nd7+ Kg8 56 Ke8! Ne6 57 Ke7! g5 58 Ke8!

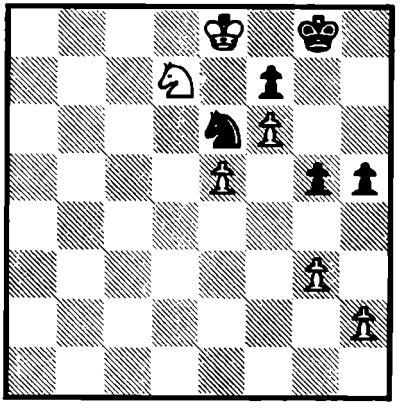


Diagram 39

Black is now almost in zugzwang: his King cannot afford to move, he has almost exhausted the pawn moves, and if the Knight gives up its location on e6, White plays Nc5 followed by e6. Black's only hope are some Knight checks, but White's King, by triangulation, puts a stop to those.

58 ...Nc7+ 59 Kd8! Ne6+ 60 Ke7! Nd4

60...g4 just delays the inevitable by a bit: 61 Ke8! Nc7+ 62 Kd8! Ne6+ 63 Ke7 etc.

61 Nc5 Nc6+ 62 Kd6 Na5 63 e6!

Note how harmoniously White's pieces are now placed for this advance while Black's have been chased "far" away.

63 ...fxe6 64 Ke7! Nc6+ 65 Ke8 Ne5 66 Nxe6 Nf7

White has simplified down to a very favorable case of the N + 3P vs. N + 2P endgame: a powerful far advanced passed pawn, assisted by active King and Knight. White's win is not in doubt.

67 Ke7 g4 68 Ng7!

The practical approach: prior to undertaking decisive operations, White for good measure captures the h-pawn.

68 ...Nh6 69 Nxh5 Nf5+ 70 Ke8 Nd6+ 71 Kd7! Nf5 72 Ng7

A pretty tactical motif, which gains a tempo and speeds up the win. Of course, the prosaic 72 Ke6 also wins in due course: 72...Nd4+ 73 Ke5 Nf3+ 74 Kf5 Nxh2 75 Nf4! Kf7 76 Ng6 etc.

If Black now exchanges Knights, the K + P endgame is hopeless. Black's position is resignable.

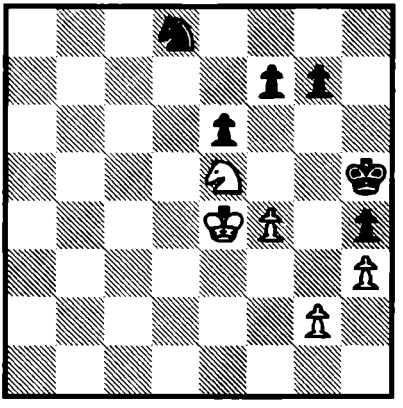
72 ...Nh6 73 Ke7 Nf7 74 Nf5 Black resigns.

The f-pawn will cost Black his Knight: 74...Ng5 75 Nh6+ followed by 76 f7. A technical masterpiece by GM Taimanov.

In our last example we will see how to simplify the basic N + 4P vs. N + 3P endgame down to a winning N + 3P vs. N + 2P one, where the extra pawn is in the form of a sound passed pawn. Good technique means the ability to achieve simpler winning positions from more complicated ones. I will return once more to H. Rossetto - L. Stein, Amsterdam Interzonal 1964, this time to the situation after White's 44th move, as shown in Diagram 40. Black is aiming for the position of Diagram 36, but how to get there? At the moment White's position appears defensible: his pieces are well placed in the center while Black's h-pawn seems to require continual protec-

tion,. Yet note how GM Stein pushes White back, step-by-step:

Diagram 40



44 ...f6 45 Nf3 Nc6

Black activates his Knight and prevents Nd4. Quite wrong now is 46 f5? because after 46...e5 Black already gets a protected passed pawn. After 45 Nf3 White's force deployment is the optimum possible for defense. Therefore it should be left as is. It is up to Black to make progress!

46 Kd3 Nb4+ 47 Ke4 Na6!

Instead the immediate 47...Nd5?! allows 48 f5 and 47...g6? drops the e-pawn after 48 Nd4. Thus Black first ensures the safety of the e-pawn.

48 Kd4 Nc7! 49 Ke4 g6!

By safeguarding f5 Black eliminates the danger from White's f5 advance and enables his Knight to start active maneuvers.

50 Kd4 Nd5 51 Ke4 Nc3+!

The start of a long road to f5. Yet it must be executed with precision, e.g., an immediate 51...Ne7? allows 52 Nd4. Black must ensure that White's Knight does not get the opportunity to reach the key d4 square.

52 Kd3 Nb5 53 Ke4 Nd6+ 54 Kd3 Nf5!

The first major intermediate goal has been achieved: from f5 the Knight prevents White's Nd4 and protects the h-pawn. Therefore Black's King now is freed for action on the central front.

55 Nd2 Kh6! 56 Ne4 Kg7 57 Nd2 Kf7 58 Ne4 Ke7!

With Black's King centrally placed, there is no way to prevent the coming ...e5 which will yield Black a sound passed e-pawn. Yet note that Black has delayed this advance until his King can both protect the passed pawn as well as exploit its strength.

59 Nd2 e5! 60 fxe5 fxe5 61 Ke4 Kf6 *Black has a won position.*

Black has achieved a safe and sound passed pawn. For instance, 62 Nf3 is parried by 62...Ng3+ 63 Kd5 e4 64 Nxh4? g5. The next dozen moves consisted of quiet maneuvering, with the decisive action beginning on more 74 - see the play from Diagram 36 in the previous section.

Section 5: Knight + 5 Pawns vs. Knight + 4 Pawns

The conclusion for this is loud and clear: **The endgame of N + 5 P vs. N + 4 P is a sure win.**

This endgame occurs seldom in tournament play. At the very least, the stronger side will achieve a favorable N + 4 P vs. N + 3 P endgame. Therefore it is a sure win and the techniques for that endgame guarantee success here also.

Chapter 4

Material Advantage - Pawns On Both Sides

Section 1: General Principles

(1) Winning Prospects and Techniques

To increase its winning prospects, the stronger side always wants pawn to exist on both sides of the board.

The general winning procedures is the same as for Bishop endgames and consists of the following steps:

(1) Centralize your King and Knights.

(2) Create a passed pawn on the side having the extra pawn.

(3) If the defending Knight blockades the passed pawn, deflect it by offering to exchange Knights.

(4) If the defending King is busy stopping the passed pawn, penetrate with your King on the other side of the board and capture sufficient pawns to win the game.

(2) Drawing Prospects and Technique

The defending side's drawing chances are better than in the corresponding Bishop endgames.

There are two reasons for this: (1) The versatility of the Knight increases chances for counterplay. (2) A passed pawn, even if obtained at heavy material cost, can severely immobilize the stronger side's Knight. The Bishop can stop a passed pawn from far away, whereas the Knight obviously must be quite close.

The two general a proaches in aiming for a draw are:

(1) Exchange off as many pawns as possible, with the ultimate goal of leaving the stronger side with just one pawn. This approach is true for *all* endgames.

(2) Create a passed pawn so as to tie down the stronger side's Knight.

Section 2: The Stronger Side Has A Passed Pawn

If the stronger side has already obtained a passed pawn, its winning chances are excellent. This is particularly so if its King and Knight are well placed. Diagram 41, W. Schmidt - H. J. Hecht, Wijk aan Zee II 1972, with Black on move, is a good example of a won position. The characteristics of it are: (1) The f-pawn is a sound passed pawn, (2) Black's Knight is momentarily a bit awkwardly placed, but on an over-all basis the King and Knight are located well enough, (3) Black has only three pawns left.

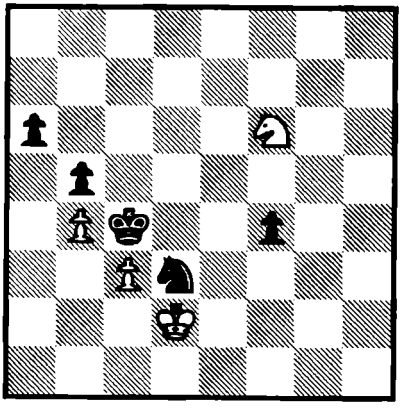


Diagram 41

The paucity of material remaining does give White some slight drawing chances, but with accurate play the win is there:

1 ...Nb2!

The Knight must be extricated from its unsafe location. From b2 it plans to head for a4 to attack the c-pawn. A gross error would have been 1...f3? because of 2 Ng4 when the threat of 3 Ne3+ forces Black to abandon the f-pawn (2...Nb2 3 Ne5+ Kb3 4 Nxf3 with a draw).

2 Kc2?

Such passivity is equivalent to voluntarily awaiting the undertaker. Imperative is the active 2 Ne8!. Black's road to victory then is considerably harder: 2...Na4 3 Nd6+ Kd5 4 Ne8 f3 5 Nc7+ (5 Ke3 Kc6! 6 Kxf3 Nxc3 followed by 7...Nd6 and 8...Nxb4) 5...Kc6! 6 Nxa6 (6 Ne6 Nxc3 7 Nd4+ Kb6! 8 Nxf3 N5 followed by 9...Nxh4) 6...Kb6! (White is safe after 6...Nxc3? 7 Ke3!) 7 Nb8 Kc7 8 Na6+ Kb7 9 Nc5+ Nxc5 10 bxc5 Kc6 with a won K + P endgame.

2 ...Na4 3 Ne4 Kd5 4 Nd2 Nb6 5 Kd3 Nc4 6 Nb3 Ne5+

Black has regrouped (and centralized!) his K + N and is thus ready to win on either side of the board. If now 7 Ke2, Black wins with 7...Kc4 8 Nc5 a5!.

7 Kd2 f3 8 Nd4 f2! 9 Ke2 Kc4

Black's play continues to be most thematic: the f-pawn is used as a decoy to draw away White's King from the queenside so that Black' King can capture both pawns there. Obviously hopeless now is 10 Kxf2 Kxc3 followed by ...Kxb4.

10 Ne6 Kxc3 11 Nc5 Kxb4 12 Nxa6+ Ka5! 13 Nc5 Ng4 White resigns.

Black retains the f-pawn and a two pawn advantage for an easy win.

A somewhat similar state exists in Diagram 42, J. Szalajdewicz - R. Mallee, Lublin III 1975, after White's 51st move.

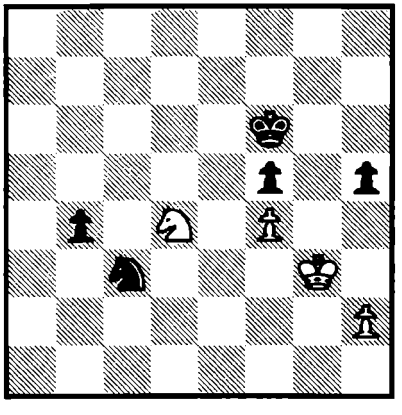


Diagram 42

Black is ahead a passed b-pawn, yet is handicapped by having isolated kingside pawns. To win, Black's King will have to penetrate into White's kingside, at the cost of the b-pawn. Even after penetration Black's play will have to be most exact.

51 ...Ne4+ 52 Kf3 Nc5 53 Ke3 Ne6!

For Black's King to progress, White's Knight must be dislodged from d4 from where it controls e6 and menaces the f-pawn. Instead premature is 53...b3? 54 Kd2 b2 55 Kc2 Nd3 56 Ne2 when White has an excellent defensive formation. For instance, if Black tries to move his King toward the queenside, White plays Nd4 with an attack on the f-pawn.

54 Ne2 h4!

Preventing White's Ng3 forevermore helps safeguard Black's kingside.

55 Kd3 Ke7 56 Kc4 Kd6 57 Kxb4

White might as well capture since he has no reasonable waiting moves. But, of course, now Black's King gets into White's kingside.

57 ...Kd5 53 Kc3 Ke4 59 Kd2 Kf3!!

Black's King has penetrated, all right, but the win is nowhere routine. Black's first problem is that because of the presence of h-pawns (the RPs are the worst pawns to have for winning purposes in K + P endgames!), the K + P endgame after 59...Nxf4? 60 Nxf4! Kxf4 61 Ke2 is drawn:
(1) 61...Kg4 62 Kf2 Kh3 63 Kg1 f4 64 Kh1 f3 65 Kg1;
(2) 61...Ke4 62 Kf2 f4 63 Ke2 f3+ 64 Kf2 Kf4 65 Ke1! Ke3 66 Kf1 f2 67 h3 Kf3 stalemate.

If White now plays the routine 60 Ke1?!, he is immediately in zugzwang after 60...Kg2.

60 Kd1! Kg2 61 Ke1 h3!

Black's second problem is that after 61...Kxh2? 62 Kf2! his King cannot get off the edge of the board (62...Kh3 63 Kf3!) and the position becomes drawn. With the necessary text he now zugzwangs White, albeit at the cost of opening up g3 for White's Knight.

62 Ng3 Nd4 63 Nf1!

The only try at a defense. In the game White lost routinely after 63 Nh5? Nf3+ 64 Ke2 Nxh2 65 Ng7 Nf1 66 Nxf5 Ng3+ 67 Nxg3 Kxg3 68 Kf1 h2, White resigns.

After the text 63...Nf3+ 64 Ke2 Nxh2? 65 Nxh2 Kxh2 66 Kf2 again leads to a drawn K + P endgame. Mallee, nevertheless, has demonstrated the following problem win:

63...Kg1! 64 Ne3 Nf3+ 65 Ke2 Nxh2 66 Nxf5 Nf1 67 Nh4

Also 67 Nd4 fails to 67...Nd2!!

67...Nd2!! 68 Kxd2

68 Nf5 only delays the inevitable after 68...Nf3+ 69 Ke2 h2 70 Ng3 Kg2 71 Nh1! Nd4+! (Not 71...Kxh1? 72 Kf1 with a draw - see Diagram 1) 72 Ke1 Nf5 73 Nf2 Ng3! 74 f4 Nxf5 75 Nh1 Ng3 76 Nf2 Kf3 and Black wins.

This final position demonstrates once more how difficult it is for the Knight to cope with a RP.

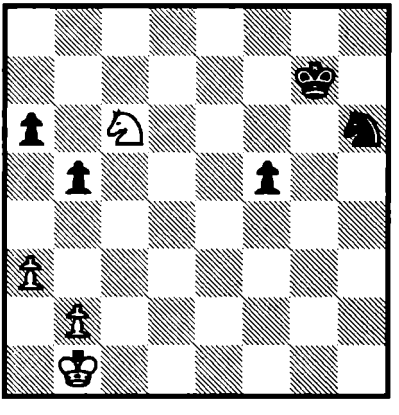


Diagram 43

A cursory look at Diagram 43, B. Ivkov - R. Fischer, Bled 1961, after White's 57th move, may lead to the conclusion that the result would be the same as in the previous two examples. After all, Black is up a safe and sound f-pawn and both sides have two good pawns on the queenside. Yet there is a crucial difference: White's active Knight is able to menace Black's queenside pawns and Black's forces are too far away for effective help. With a deft series of maneuvers White is able to sufficiently weaken Black's queenside pawn formation so that the pawns become vulnerable to exchanges. Then he successfully sacrifices the Knight for the f-pawn.

57...Nf7 58 Kc2!

On the way to centralizing the King so that it can help stop the f-pawn or to head for the queenside pawns. Black's King also heads for the center.

58...Kf6 59 Nb4!

At the moment White's King is close enough to the f-pawn so that the Knight can start bothering the queenside pawns.

59...a5 60 Nc6 a4 61 Nd4 Nd6 62 b3! Ke5

The previous moves were obvious enough, but here Black overlooks White's diabolical plan. Only 62...f4! gave wining chances, though, after 63 Kc3! axb3 64 Kxb3 Ke5 65 Nf3+ White's position is sufficiently defensible.

63 Nxf5!! Nxf5

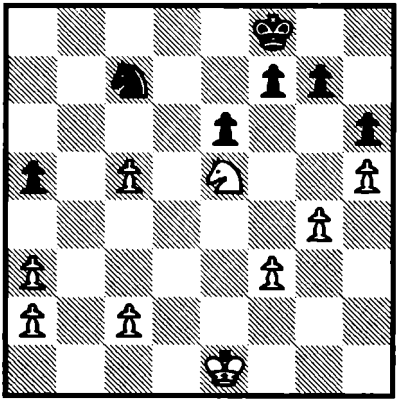
Or 63...axb3+ 64 Kxb3 Nxf5 65 a4; or 63...Kxf5 64 bxa4 bxa4 65 Kc3 Nc8 66 Kb4 Nb6 67 Kb5.

64 bxa4 bxa4 65 Kc3 Draw.

There is nothing to be done about 66 Kb4 followed by 67 Kxa4. A triumph of the strategy of gaining a draw by

eliminating the stronger side's pawns - and a most impressive thematic and creative effort by GM Ivkov.

Diagram 44



Compared to the rather normal positions in the previous three examples, Diagram 44, J. M. Bellon - A. Pomar, Orense 1976, after Black's 29th move, appears exotic. Yet a cool evaluation shows the following features:
(1) White has transformed his queenside majority into a passed pawn (actually *doubled* passed pawns),
(2) White's extra a-pawn, though of little offensive power, has definite defensive value because if Black captures one a-pawn he will would not have a passed a-pawn himself,
(3) since White has a three pawn majority on the queenside, Black's only hope is his one pawn kingside majority.

The unbalanced nature of the position requires creative play by White to ensure the win. GM Bellon comes through in fine style:

30 Kd2! Ke7 31 Kd3!

White thematically centralizes the King so that it can take part wherever the action will be. It would be risky to go after the a-pawn with 31 Nc6+?! since Black gets strong counterchances on the kingside. White already has a sufficient advantage to win and therefore the major need at present is to contain Black's expected counterplay.

31...Kf6 32 Nc4 g6!

Black aims to create a passed h-pawn, as that would give White the most difficulty. Unsatisfactory now is 33 hxg6?! because after 33...fxg6! followed by 34...h5 Black gets a dangerous passed pawn. White also correctly avoids capturing the a-pawn and instead concentrates on preventing Black's kingside play.

33 Nd6! gxh5 34 gxh5 Kg5 35 Nxf7+ Kxh5 36 Ke4! Kg6 37 Nxh6!!

The crowning point of White's play. The dangerous h-pawn is eliminated and the active King will help the passed pawns carry the day.

37...Kxh6 38 Ke5 Kg6 39 Kd6 Nb5+ 40 Kxe6 Nd4+

Useless is 40...Nxa3 because Black doesn't gain a passed pawn thereby. With the text Black tries to set up a defensive formation.

41 Kd5 Nf5 42 c6 Kf7 43 c7 Ne7+ 44 Kd6 Ke8 45 f4!

There is no way that the short range Knight can cope with passed pawns on both flanks.

45...Nc8+ 46 Kc6 Ne7+ 47 Kb7 Kd7 48 c4 Black resigns.

The pawns march inexorably forward: 48...Nc8 49 c5 Ne7 50 f5 Nc8 51 f6 etc.

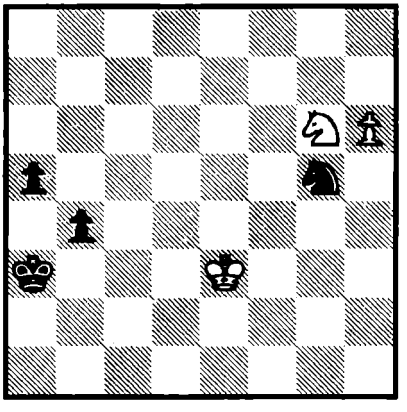
Section 3: Both Sides Have Passed Pawn(s)

As already briefly discussed, it is in inferior N + P endgames that the creation of a passed pawn becomes a powerful drawing tool because the Knight - as a result of its short range - is severely handicapped in coping with passed pawn(s). For situation where both sides have passed pawns it is difficult to give hard and fast rules. Mostly it's a question of careful calculations and tactical creativity in considering the

proper King maneuvers and Knight jumps. The single most important principle to keep in mind is that **the RP is by far the most difficult pawn for the Knight.**

An excellent practical example of the type of play that can result is shown from Diagram 45, N. Minev - K. Honfi, Bern 1974, with White on move. Black has two strong connected passed pawns on the queenside, yet White's h-pawn which is already on the 6th rank creates good counterplay. The two major strategic considerations are: (1) The h-pawn is difficult for Black's Knight to stop, and (2) K + RP on the 7th rank vs. Queen is drawn if the stronger side's King is too far away and the Queen does not control the queening square.

Diagram 45



With perfect play Diagram 45 is a draw. The game was drawn, though with a serious error by each side thrown in:

1 Ne5!

The best move: the Knight heads back to stop the b-pawn. White's King then will have sufficient time to chase Black's Knight away from the h-pawn. The immediate 1 Kf4 allows 1...Nf7! when after 2 h7 b3 3 Ne5 Nxe5! 4 Kxe5 b2 7 h8=Q b1=Q the Q + P endgame gives Black good practical chances for the win.

1...b3 2 Kf4 Nh7!

White has a routine draw after 2...Ne6+ 3 Kf5 Nf8 4 Kf6 followed by 5 Kg7.

3 Kf5?

Now White is lost. The King can always get to Black's Knight. Therefore White's first business should have been to bring back his Knight to stop the b-pawn. The drawing method was 3 Nd3! b2 4 Nxb2 Kxb2 5 Nf5 a4 6 Kg6 Nf8+ 7 Kf7 a3 8 Kxf3 a2 9 h7.

3...Kb2?

Black reciprocates. The win was to be had with 3...Kb4!, preventing 4 Nc4+. IM Minev provides the following variations as convincing proof:
(1) 4 Kg6 Kc3! 5 Kxh7 b2 6 Kg7 b1=Q 7 h7 Qxh7+ a4 and the pawn cannot be stopped,
(2) 4 Nd3+ Kc4! 5 Nb2+ Kc3 6 Na4+ Kb4 7 Nb2 a4 8 Kg6 a3 9 Nd3+ Kc3, winning.

4 Nc4+!

Only so: the Knight is safely back and White is safe. White loses after 4 Nd3+? Kc2! and 4 Kg6? Kc3!.

4...Kc3 5 Na3 b2

Or 5...a4 6 Kg6 Kb4 7 Nb1 a3 8 Nxa3! leading to the same position as in the game.

6 Kg6 Kb3

There is nothing is 6...Nf8+ 7 Kf7 etc.

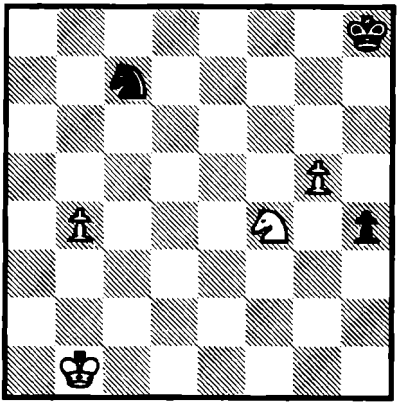
7 Nb1 a4 8 Kxh7 a3 9 Nxa3! Kxa3 10 Kg8 Draw.

After 10...b1=Q 11 h7 Qg6+ 12 Kh8! Black must choose between stalemating White or allowing the h-pawn to queen.

Considerably more sophistication is required to correctly handle the position of Diagram 46, which is the conclusion of a marvelous 1964 study by the Dutch composer J. H. Marwitz.

White has a significant advantage by virtue of having two widely separated passed pawns, yet Black's single passed pawn is the "naughty" h-pawn. White to play and win is the task - but how? The obvious 1 Ng6+? leads to nothing after 1...Kg7 2 Nxh4 Nd5 3 b5 Nc3+ followed by 4...Nxb5. No better is 1 Kb2? Nd5! when both 2 Nxd5? h3 or 2 b5? Nxf4 3 b6 Nd3+ 4 Kc3 Nc5 lead to wins for *Black*. Other "normal" moves by the King also are foiled by 1...Nd5!, as is 1 Nh3?.

Diagram 46



And the winner is . . .

1 Ka1!!

A surprising, though with the above discussion in mind, readily understandable solution. White places his King on a square where it is momentarily out of reach for Black's Knight. This gives White time to play Nh3 and then the King will be able to start advancing and assist the b-pawn.

1...Nd5!

Still the best try. After 1...Kg7 2 Nh3! White wins similarly to what happens later on.

2 b5! Kg7

After 2...Nxf4? 3 b6 Black's Knight lacks a tempo gaining check to get back in time to stop the pawn.

3 Nh3!

Here too there is not time for 3 Nxd5? because Black reaches a theoretically drawn position with 3...h3 4 Nf4 h2 5 Nh5+ Kg6 6 Ng3 Kxg5 7 b6 Kg4 8 Nh1 Kf3 9 b7 Kg2 10 b8=Q Kxh1. Note how similar this motif is to that of the previous example.

3...Kf7

Also losing is 3...Kg6 4 Kb2! Kh5 5 Kb3 because there is not time for 5...Kg4: 6 g6 Kxh3 7 g7 Nf6 3 b6 Kg2 9 b7 h3 10 b8=Q h2 11 Qb7+ Kg1 12 Qb6+ Kg2 13 Qxf6 and White wins.

4 Kb2 Ke6 5 Kb3 Kd6 6 Ka4! Kc7 7 Ka5

White's b-pawn is now secure and the combination of the far advanced and widely separated passed pawns is too much for Black's Knight. Still, White wins only by a hair.

7...Kb7 8 g6 Ne7 9 g7 Ng8 10 b6!

Passed pawns must be pushed!

10...Nf6 11 Kb5 Ng8 12 Ng5!

The return of the Knight into the fray will be decisive. Black loses quickly after 12...Nh6 13 Nf7! Ng8 14 Nd8+ and 12...Nf6 13 Ne4! Ng8 14 Nc5+ etc.

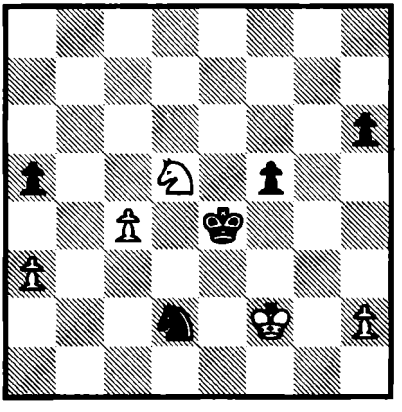
12...Ne7! 13 Ne6! h3 14 Nd8+ Kc8 15 Nc6! Ng8 16 Ka6 h2 17 b7+ Kd7 18 b8=Q h1=Q 19 Qd8+! White wins.

At last success: 19...Ke6 loses to 20 Qxg8+; 19 Kxc6 drops the Queen after 20 Qa8+.

At the moment material is equal in Diagram 47, A. Donchenko - R. Holmov, Dubna 1973, after Black's 43rd move. Yet it is readily apparent that the c-pawn is on its last legs and then Black will have the material advantage of a passed f-pawn. However, the significant factor in the position

will turn out to be the RPs: Black's Knight is well placed to capture White's a-pawn, whereas White's Knight can go after Black's h-pawn. In the resulting play Black will have the active King and Black's passed a-pawn will be further advanced than White's passed h-pawn, GM Holmov in a detailed analysis in *Shahmaty Bjulletin*, #5, 1975, has convincingly proven that Black wins by force from Diagram 47. Much of this analysis is too detailed for our needs, but the major conclusions are valuable and I have made grateful use of them. White now played:

Diagram 47



44 Ne3

White protects the c-pawn and if chased away by 44...f4, will go after the h-pawn via g4. On the face of it this is a logical approach. Extensive subsequent analysis, however, has shown that Black's task would have been considerably more difficult after 44 Nf6+! Ke5 45 Nd7+! (45 Ng8 leads to play similar to the game continuation.) Holmov then gives the following as the main line: 45...Kd4 46 c5 Ne4+ 47 Kf3 Nxc5 48 Nb6 (48 Nb8 is met by 48...a4!) 48...Ne6! (Keeping out White's King from f4.) 49 h4 h5! 50 Nc8 Kc4 51 Nd6+ Kb3 52 Nxf5 Kxa3 53 Ke3 (White has to try to stop the a-pawn. After 53 Ng3?! Kb2! 54 Nxh5 a4 Black's RP will be well ahead of White's.) 53...Kb2! 54 Kd2 a4 55 Ne3! Nd4! 56 Kd3 Nf3 57 Nc4+ Kb3 58 Na5+ Kb4 59 Nc6+ Kc5 60 Nd8 (60 Nb8 Kd6!) 60...Kd5 61 Kc3 Nxh4 62 Kb4 Nf3 63 Nf7 Ke6! 64 Nh6 Ne5 65 Kxa4 h4 and Black wins. White's King has indeed conquered the a-pawn,

but now is too far away from the passed h-pawn!

44...f4 45 Ng4 Nxc4 46 a4

White can choose whether the a-pawn is captured on a3 or a4, but it is hardly surprising that it makes little difference. After the immediate 46 Nxh6 Nxa3 White's best is 47 Nf7 Nb5 48 Nd8, yet Black still wins after 48...a4 49 Nc6 a3 50 Nb4 Nc3 51 h4 a2 52 Nc2 (or 52 Nxa2 Nxa2 53 h5 Nb4 54 h6 Nd3+ 55 Kf1 Ne5 56 h7 Ng6 and the h-pawn has been one move too slow.) 52...Nd1+ 53 Ke1 Ne3 54 Na1 Kd3 (Or the simple 54...Ng2+ and 55...Nxh4.) 55 h5 Nc2+ etc.

46...Nb6 47 Nxh6 Nxa4 48 Nf7

Heading back via 48 Ng4 loses after 48...Nb2 49 Ke2 Nc4 50 h4 a4 51 Nxf2+ Kd4 52 h5 a3 53 h6 a2 54 h7 f3+ 55 Kxf3 Ne5+ 56 Ke2 Nf7 when White's h-pawn has been stopped while Black's a-pawn queens.

Moreover, if White's King goes to stop the a-pawn then Black wins with the f-pawn: 48 Ke1 Nb2 49 Kd2 Nc4+ 50 Kc3 Ne5! 51 Ng8 Ng4! 52 h3 f3 53 Kd2 Nh2! 54 Nf6+ Ke5 55 Nh5 f2 (Holmov).

48...Nc3 49 Ng5+

The other route is 49 Nd6+ Kd5 50 Nb7 (50 Nc8 Kc5!) 50...a4 51 Kf3 Ne4! 52 Kxf4 a3 53 Na5 Nc5!, but White's Knight is cut off from stopping the a-pawn.

49...Kd3 50 Ne6 Kc4!

Just as in the previous note, Black's goal is to prevent White's Knight from getting back to stop the a-pawn. Black's forces are well placed, White's King is too far away - therefore Black's success is assured.

51 Nxf4 a4 52 Ng6 a3 53 Ne5+ Kb5! White resigns.

The likely end would have been: 54 Nf3 a2 55 Nd4+ Kc4 56 Nc2 Kb3 57 Na1+ Kb2. Note again the difficulty the Knight has with a RP.

We will now consider situations with more pawns.

Diagram 48

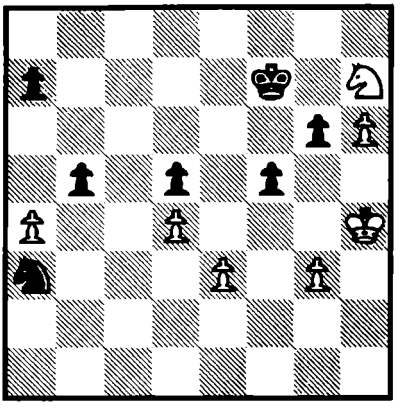


Diagram 48 shows P. Brandts - E. Mednis, New York 1952, after Black's 46th move. White has the advantage: he has the active King, the active Knight, a passed far advanced h-pawn, and after the imminent capture of the g-pawn will be a pawn up. Black's drawing prospects rest with quickly creating a passed pawn on the queenside (as can be seen he has just started on this) to tie down White's Knight there. Then Black hopes to utilize his Knight to get at White's kingside pawns. The game course shows that Black is just able to achieve his aim:

47 Ng5+ Kg8! 48 axb5 Nxb5 40 Ne6 a5! 50 Kg5 Nd6!

The g-pawn can't be defended (50...Kf7?? 51 h7; 50...Kh7? 51 Nf8+) and the Knight is needed to guard both the f-pawn and the f7 square. Luckily for Black, the Knight will only have to be inactive for a short period.

51 Kxg6 a4 52 Nc5

The strength of White's h-pawn has been neutralized by Black's a-pawn. Since 52 h7+?! Kh8 just makes White's h-pawn vulnerable while gaining nothing in turn, White's Knight must head back. Black first advances his passed pawn as far as possible and then send his Knight after White's pawns.

52...a3 53 Nb3 a2 54 Kf6 Ne4+ 55 Ke5

White wants to first capture the d-pawn so as to obtain another passed pawn as quickly as possible.

55...Nxg3 56 Kxd5 Nf1 57 Ke5 Nxe3 58 Na1

After the immediate 58 Kf4, Black gains time for defense with 58...Nc2 59 d5 Nd4!.

58...Kh7 59 Kf4 Nc4 60 Kxf5 Kxh6 Draw.

There are no winning chances left.

A fine example of how to handle a two pawn majority on one side is shown starting from Diagram 49, E. Mednis - R. Fischer, 1963/64 U. S. Championship, after Black's 41st move.

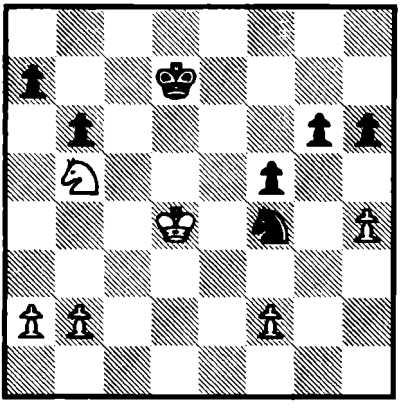


Diagram 49

Of course, Black does not have such a majority yet, but my "generosity" makes it immediately possible. After coming through time pressure well enough (though missing a forced draw) and now having another hour on the clock, I thoughtlessly - both literally and figuratively - played:

42 Nxa7??

There is no rational explanation for such a move. White takes off an unimportant pawn far from the scene of action

while forgetting about everything else. Just a few seconds of actual *thinking* would have shown that only the active 42 Ke5! makes sense. Then 42...Ng2 is harmless because of 43 h5 gxh5 44 Kxf5. Moreover, 42...Nd3+ 43 Kf6 Nxf2 44 Kxg6 f4 45 Nd4 also looks quite safe for White. After 42 Ke5! a draw is the likely result.

42...Ng2 43 Ke5?!

Giving Black two connected passed pawns is proven to be hopeless. Therefore, a better practical try was 43 h5 gxh5 44 Kd3! h4 45 Ke2 h3 46 Kf1, even though White's prospects remain bleak after 46...Nh4 47 Kg1 Nf3+.

43...Nxh4 44 Kf4 g5+ 45 Kg3 Ng6 46 a4

White does have an extra pawn on the queenside, but GM Fischer will with ease demonstrate how to make it harmless.

46...f4+ 47 Kg2 g4 48 Nb5 Ne5!

Black executes the thematic piece play strategy: with this move centralizing the Knight and on the next move, the King.

49 Nc3 Ke6! 50 b4 Nc6!

Black paralyzes White's queenside play. He does not even give White a chance for a viable passed pawn there.

51 f3?!

It is simply wrong to make it easier for Black to obtain connected passed pawns. Better is 51 b5.

51...h5 52 b5 Ne5! 53 fxg4 hxg4 54 Kf2 Nd3+ 55 Ke2 Nc5!

Black's Knight ties down White's, while establishing itself on an active location. GM Fischer's technique, whereby he continually maximizes his chances, while minimizing those of his opponent, is exemplary.

56 Kf1 Kf5 57 Kg2 Ke5 58 Kf2 Nd3+ 59 Ke2 g3! 60 Kf3 Ne1+ 61 Ke2 g2 62 Kf2 f3 White resigns.

I could have done so with a clear conscience already some moves earlier. Black's next moves will be 63...Nd3(+), 64...Nf4, 65...Nh3(+).

Section 4:
The Stronger Side Can Force (Create) A Passed Pawn

If the stronger side doesn't yet have a passed pawn, it wants to create one. therefore, once the preliminary steps of King and Knight centralization have been accomplished, it is time to work on creating a passed pawn on the side having the extra pawn. Part of the time direct pawn advances will do the job. However, the opponent will be fully aware of this aim and will try to prevent it. Then the winning procedure consists of penetrating into the other side of the board, while the defender is busy trying to prevent the creation of a passed pawn on the "normal" side.

This interplay of factors is well illustrated from our first example, Diagram 50, E. Fucak - S. Cvetkovic, Yugoslavia 1968, Black on move. Black has a nice, normal, "one pawn advantage" position. The extra pawn is part of a healthy 2P vs. P kingside majority. His next step should be to further mobilize his kingside pawns as this will tie White down on that side and give Black the opportunity to penetrate into White's queenside. Black's next move opens both vistas for exploration:

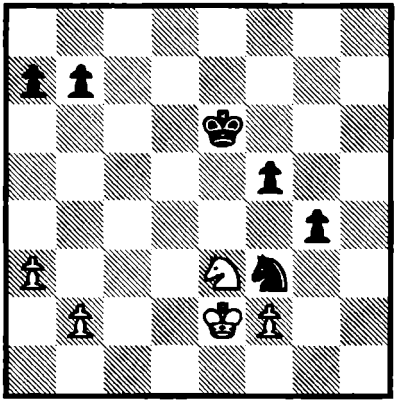


Diagram 50

1...Ne5!

The centralized Knight covers both sides of the board beautifully, threatening 2...f4 and being itself ready to jump to c4. White is at defensive crossroads: which side of the board should he work on?

2 Ng2?!

He decides to prevent the immediate advance of the f-pawn. Yet the cost is heavy since the decentralization of the Knight allows both Black's King and Knight to menace White's queenside. I believe that the alternative was better: 2 b3 f4 3 Nd1!, giving Black two options:
(1) 3...Kd5, which can be parried by 4 Nc3+ Kc5 (4...Kd4? 5 Nb5+) 5 Ne4+ when 5...Kd4?! is risky because of 6 Nd6 and it is uncertain if Black can win, e.g. 6...Kc3 7 b4 Kb3 8 Nxb7 Kxa3 9 b5 Kb4 10 Nd6, with the threat 11 Nc8.
(2) 3...Nf3! is correct, threatening 4...Nd4+. If 4 b4, Black's King will penetrate the queenside starting with 4...Kd5; if 4 Kd3, Black forces a passed pawn: 4...g3! 5 fxg3 fxg3 6 Ne3 Ke5! 7 Ng2 Nd4 8 b4 Nf5 and in due course Black's g-pawn will cost White his queenside. Nevertheless, this would have been a better chance for White, since after the text move Black has an easier time in penetrating.

2...Nc4! 3 Nf4+ Ke5 4 Nd3+ Kd4 5 a4 Ne5!

Recentralizing the Knight makes White's Knight give way, thus allowing Black's King to get at White's pawns.

6 Nf4 Kc4! 7 Ne6 Kb4 8 Ke3 b6!

By preventing a Nc5(+), Black safeguards his queenside.

9 Kf4?!

As Black is bound to win White's queenside, a routine pawn for pawn exchange on the Kingside must be inherently hopeless. Only 9 Nd4 Kxa4 10 Nxf5 offers a bit of practical

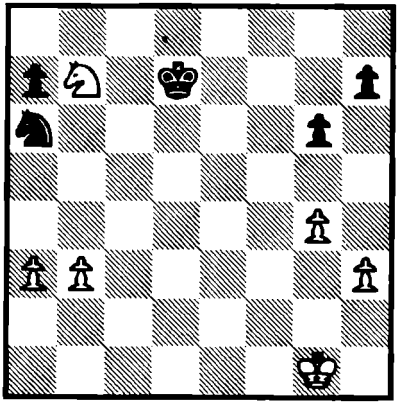
chances, though of course Black's position remains won after 10...Kb3.

9...Nd3+ 10 Kxf5 Nxf2 11 Kf4 Nd3+ 12 Kxg4 Nxb2 13 Kf3 Nxa4

Two connected passed pawns win routinely. The conclusion was:

14 Ke3 Nc5 15 Nd4 a5 16 Nc6+ Kc3 17 Nd4 a4 18 Nb5+ Kb4 19 Nd4 a3 20 Nc2+ Kb3 21 Kd2 a2 22 Kc1 Kc3 White resigns.

Diagram 51



The stronger side's task is considerably harder from Diagram 51, D. Lazic - M. Dimitrijevic, Kragujevac 1977, after Black's 36th move. White's only advantage is the extra pawn; Black has the active King and the potentially more active Knight. White's first order of business must be to consolidate the pawn advantage and the first step is to centralize the King:

37 Kf2! Kc6 38 Na5+ Kb5

The text does succeed in forcing back White's Knight (39 b4? Ka4 40 Nc4 Kb3), but allows White's King to achieve a domineering central role. A bit more promising for longer term resistance is 38...Kd5!.

39 Nc4 Nc5 40 Nd2 a5 41 Ke3

The queenside is sufficiently protected so that White's King is ready to head for Black's kingside pawns.

41...Ne6 42 h4! a4

If Black does nothing, White walks in with Ke4, Ke5, etc., while retaining his queenside majority.

43 b4

It is difficult to resist having a protected passed pawn. However, a clearer win is to be had with the direct kingside penetration approach: 43 bxa4+! Kxa4 44 Ke4 Kxa3 45 Ke5 Nc7 46 Ne4! Kb3 47 Nf6 h6 48 Ng8 etc.

43...Nc7 44 Kd4

Already the first problem is apparent: if 44 Kf4?!, Black gets counterplay after 44...Nd5+ 45 Kg4 Nxb4!.

44...h5 45 g5 Kc6 46 Ke5 Nd5 47 Kd4?!

White unnecessarily gets cold feet. The King should remain active and the Knight used for defense via 47 Nb1!. Black then is, in effect, in zugzwang and White wins easily, e.g. 47...Ne7 48 Kf6 Kd6 49 Nc3 etc.

47...Ne7 48 Kc4 Nf5 49 b5+

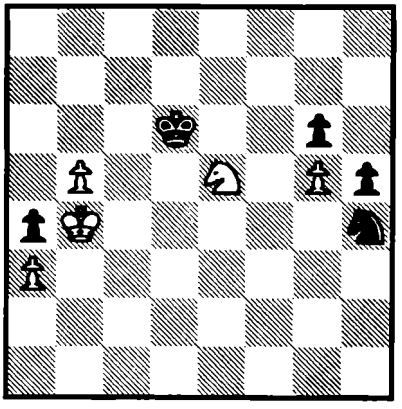
Activity is a must, as 49 Nf3?! Nd6+ 50 Kd3 Kd5 has Black threatening both 51...Nb5 and 51...Nc4.

49...Kb6 50 Kb4 Nxh4 51 Nc4+ Kc7 52 Ne5! Kd6

See Diagram 52 on the next page.

If Black temporizes with his King, White takes off the a-pawn and wins routinely with the two connected passed pawns. Therefore Black has to free his Knight. The text forces White to advance the b-pawn with the result that its weakness will prevent White from capturing the a-pawn. Yet, all this effort is for naught - White still has a win.

Diagram 52



53 b6 Nf5 54 Nxg6 Kc6 55 Ka5 Kb7 56 Nf4 h4 57 g6

With the a-pawn for now immaterial, what we have is an endgame of a b- and a g-pawn vs. the h-pawn. This same situation existed in the study by J. H. Marwitz in the previous section - see Diagram 46. The solution in this practical game is quite similar.

57...Ng7 58 Kb5 Nf5 59 Nh3 Ng7 60 Ng5!

The winning procedure will be as follows: (1) To get the b-pawn to the 7th rank, White needs to check on d8, so that (2) the Knight can get to c6, thus covering the queening square. During this process, Black's h-pawn will be free to advance so that White must time his moves most exactly.

60...Ne8 61 Ka5 Ng7 62 Nf7 h3 63 Nd8+ Kc8

The game continuation is reached sooner after 63...Kb8 64 Ka6 h2 65 Nc6+.

64 b7+ Kc7 65 Ka6 h2 66 Nc6! h1=Q 67 h8=Q+ Kd7

Obviously 67...Kxc6?! drops the Queen after 68 Qb7+. (This would also have been the conclusion if Black had played

66...Kxc6?!.)

68 Qb7+ Kd6

68...Ke8 runs into mates by 69 Qe7 or 69 Qc8; 68...Ke6 drops the Queen to 69 Nd4+ or 69 Nd8+.

69 Qe7+! Kd5 70 Nb4+ Kc4 71 Qf7+ Black resigns.

After 71...Kc5 72 Qxg7 White is up a Knight and a passed pawn.

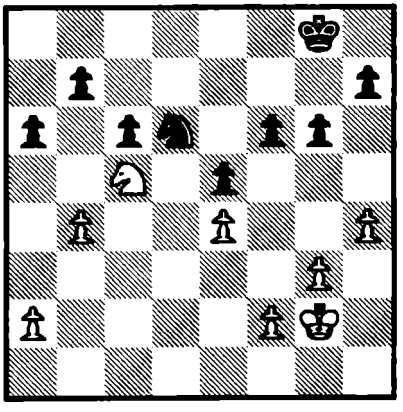


Diagram 53

In Diagram 53, Bajec - G. Tringov, Ljubljana 1969, White to move, Black is up a sound queenside pawn. The large number of pawns remaining favors Black; however, the excellent placement of White's Knight makes it very hard for Black to create a passed pawn from his queenside majority. As will be seen, Black will need a very creative method to accomplish this. in any case, Black's first object must be King "activation". Here also this means King centralization

1 f3 Kf7 2 Kf2 Ke7 3 a4 b6!! 4 Nxa6

White might as well take, as after the passive 4 Nd3 Nb7! Black even has the luxury of choosing either ...a5 or ...c5 as his break.

4...Kd8

Black plans to walk over to b7, forcing White to give

back the pawn with b5. A "normal" continuation now would be 5 Ke2 Kc8 6 Kd3 Kb7 7 b5 cxb5 8 axb5 Nxb5, when Black has obtained a passed pawn and will win using the techniques of Section 2.

Since such a course is rather prospectless for White, he decides to try to take advantage of the absence of Black's King from the kingside to generate some action there. Note also that 5 a5 fails after 5...bxa5 6 bxa5 Nc4 and White loses the a-pawn for nothing.

5 h5!? gxh5!?

Black accepts the challenge. of course, he could have continued with the normal 5...Kc8, but then White would have gained a routine exchange of one kingside pawn.

6 Kg2 Kc8 7 Kh3 f5!?

Black again chooses the most dynamic way. The simple 7...Kb7 also wins and does so "simpler".

8 exf5

Worse is 8 Kh4?! fxe4 9 fxe4 Kb7 10 b5 c5! 11 Kxh5 Nxe4 and Black's two passed pawns lead to an easy win.

8...Nxf5 9 b5 c5!

There is no reason why 9...cxb5 should not be good enough in the long run. However, the text is stronger as it immediately gives Black a powerful passed pawn.

10 Kg2?!

To follow up active play with passive is seldom advisable. Only 10 a5!? is worth trying, even though 10...c4 11 axb6 c3 12 Nb4 Nd4 must ultimately lead to a win for Black since he will capture the b-pawns and then be two pawns up.

10...h4!

Either dissolving the doubled pawns or creating a powerful passed h-pawn.

11 f4 exf4!

Unusual, but well thought out. White's resulting passed f-pawn will be impotent, whereas Black will have two powerful and widely separated passed pawns.

12 gxf4 c4! 13 Nb4 c3 14 Kf3 Nd4+ 15 Kg4 c2 16 Nd3?!

White overlooks the pretty response. Necessary is 16 Nxc2 Nxc2 17 Kxh4, though 17...Nd4 18 Kg5 Ne6+ 19 Kf3 Nc5 or 19...Nxf4 wins for Black.

16...Nf5!! White resigns.

White's King is tied to stopping the h-pawn and his Knight is chained to the c1 square. Thus Black's King can unperturbed and decisively penetrate into White's position.

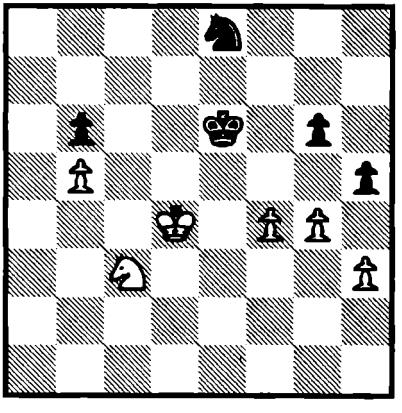


Diagram 54

White is fortunate that it is his move in the routine appearing position of Diagram 54, L. Portisch - G. Barcza, Hungary 1968. If Black would be on move, he would capture on g4 and the resulting position then is drawn for the following reasons: (1) White is left with only 3 pawns, (2) Black's King is properly placed for coping with the f-pawn, and (3) the weakness of White's b-pawn does not allow White's Knight to go after Black's b-pawn since Black's Knight then attacks White's

pawn with ...Nd6.

To win, GM Portisch must come up with a non-routine, beautiful and strategically well justified plan:

1 f5+!! gxf5

Not capturing is worse: 1...Kf7?! 2 gxh5! gxh5 3 Ke5! (White has obtained a strong passed pawn and a domineering King for nothing.) 3...Nc7 4 h4! Ne8 5 Nd5 and White wins easily.

2 gxh5

White has created an outside passed pawn - the RP being the most difficult one for the Knight to stop - and will use the time that Black's King needs to stop it, to activate his own King and Knight.

2...Kf6 3 Nd5+!

White must strike quickly less his advantage is gone. Too slow is 3 h4?! f4! when Black has surprisingly good counterchances, e.g. 4 Ke4 Kg7! 5 Kxf4 Kh6 6 Ke5 Nc7! and Black holds.

3...Kg5 4 Ke5! Kxh5 5 Ke6 f4 6 Kd7!

Time continues to be of essence. Insufficient is the greedy 6 Nxf4+?!: 6...Kg5 7 Nd5 Ng7+ 8 Kd7 Nf5 9 Kc7 Nd4 10 Kxh6 Nxb5! 11 Kxb5 Kh4 12 Nf4 Kg3, with a draw.

6...Ng7 7 Nxb6 Nf5 8 Nc4

Compared to the previous note, White is a decisive tempo ahead on the queenside. This enables his b-pawn to live, while the Knight can get back in time to stop the f-pawn.

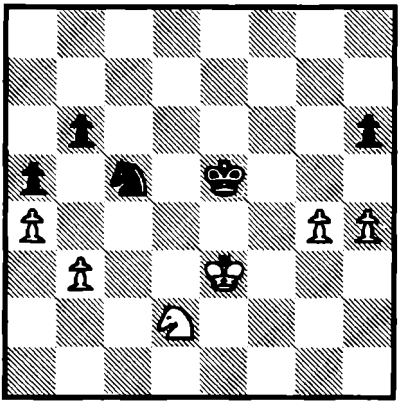
8...Nd4 9 b6 Nb3 10 Kd6!

Preventing 10...Nc5(+) and sealing Black's fate.

10...f3 11 b7 f2 12 Ne3 Na5 13 h8=Q Nc4+ 14 Ke6 Nxe3 15 Qe5+ Black resigns.

White picks off the f-pawn with a check either on f4 or g3.

Diagram 55



The position of Diagram 55, R. Holmov - V. Moiseev, Uzhgorod 1972, after Black's 42nd move, appears to be unexceptional. White is up a good pawn on the kingside, the queenside is symmetrical with each side handicapped by a weak b-pawn and at the moment Black has the more active King and Knight. White's general plan is the usual one: create a passed pawn on the kingside and while Black is busy stopping it, penetrate Black's queenside to capture both pawns.

I have selected this "unexceptional" position to demonstrate how exceedingly complicated Knight endgames are. The Knight is just so versatile that both sides have many logical possibilities to explore. To get even close to the truth, a tremendous amount of work is required. GM Holmov has published a detailed analysis of this ending in *Shakhmatny Biulletin*, #5 of 1973 and I have made grateful use of some of his work.

Even though White's general plan is apparent, he must make a specific decision now: should he aim to crate a passed pawn on the f- or h-file? And the answer is . . .

43 h5!

The h-file! the reasons are strategically clear: the h-pawn is the more difficult one for the Knight to stop and if the King stops/captures it, he will be one square farther away from the queenside than if he had captures the g-pawn. Therefore the text is superior to 43 g5.

43...Ne6

I have chosen the text as the main line, because to me it is the most rational defense since it aims to make the g5 break more difficult to achieve. The two main alternatives are:

(1) **43...Ke6**

This is the game continuation. White won as follows: 44 Kd4 Nc7 45 Nc4 Nf6 [Here also there are two alternatives: (a) 45...Nc5 leads to a lost K &P endgame after 46 Nxa5 Nxa4 47 bxa4 bxa5 48 Kc5; (b) the activation of the King with 45...Kf6 46 Kd5 Kg5 also turns out to be insufficient: 47 Kc6 Nf6 (Or 47...Kxg4 48 Kxd7 Kxh5 49 Nxb6 Kg4 50 b4!; or 47...Nc5 48 Nxa5! Kxg4 49 Kxb6 Nd7+ 50 Kb5 Kxh5 51 Nc6 Kg5 52 a5 Nf6 53 Ne7 Ne8 54 Kh6! and the a-pawn queens.) 48 Nxb6 Kxg4 (Equivalent is 48...Nxg4 49 Nc4 Kxh5 50 b4! axb4 51 a5 b3 52 Nb2! Ne5+ 53 Kc7 and again the a-pawn can't be stopped.) 49 Nc4 Kxh5 50 b4! axb4 51 a5 b3 52 Nb2! Ne5+ 53 Kc7 and again the a-pawn can't be stopped.) 49 Nc4 Kxh5 50 b4! axb4 51 a5 b3 52 a6 Ng4 53 Nb2! Ne5+ 54 Kc7, winning.] 46 Ne3! (With White's King in position to head for b5, there is no reason to allow Black immediate counterplay. Moreover, 46...Kd6 is prevented because of 47 Nf5+ followed by 48 Nxh6.) 46...Kf7 47 Kc4 Nd7 48 Nf5! Ne5+ 49 Kb5 Nxg4 50 Kxb6 Ke6 51 Nxh6! (The culmination of White's plan starting with 46 Ne3!: Black is left without pawns and counterplay. The slow Knight cannot cope with White's widely separated passed pawns.) 51...Nxh6 52 Kxa5 Kd7 53 Kb6 Kc8 54 Ka7! Black resigns. There is nothing to be done about the coming advance of the b-pawn.

(2) **43...Nd7**

Black protects the b-pawn, but allowing the g5 break

leads to a fairly routine loss:

44 Nf3+ Ke6 (After 44...Kf6 45 Kd4 Black must either allow immediate penetration by the King or transpose into the main line with 45...Ke6.) 45 g5! hxg5 46 Nxg5+ Kf5 (Also after 46...Kf6 White's King has a ready route to the queenside: 47 Ne4+ Kg7 48 Kd4! Kh6 49 Kd5 b5!? 50 axb5 a4 51 bxa4 Nb6+ 52 Kc6 Nxa4 53 Ng3 and White wins.) 47 h6 Kg6 48 h7 Kg7 49 Kd4 Kh8 50 Kc4 Nc5 51 Nf3! Kxh7 52 Nd2 (Now that his pawns are protected, White can crunch both of Black's.) 52...Kg6 53 Kb5 Nd7 54 Kc6 Ne5+ 55 Kxb6 followed by 56 Kxa5, winning.

44 Nf3+ Kf6

Without prospects is 44...Kd5?! 45 g5! hxg5 46 h6 Nf8 47 Nxg5.

45 Kd3 Nc7

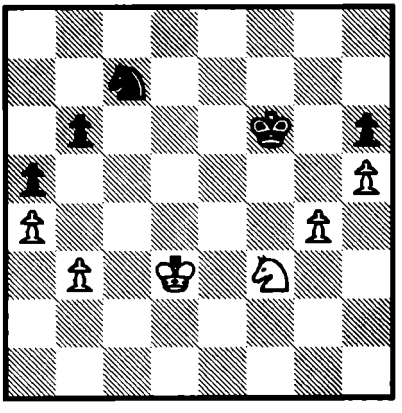


Diagram 56

Black prepares to try to keep out White's King from both b5 and d5.

The significant alternative is to go for a counterattack with 45...Ng5. GM Holmov demonstrates the following forced win against it: 46 Nd2 Nh3 [46...Ke5 47 Kc4 Kf4 48 Kb5 Kxg4 49 Kxb6 Kxh5 (Or 49...Nf7 50 Kxa5 Kxh5 51 Kb6 Nd6 52 Nc4! etc.) 50 b4! axb4 51 a5 Nf7 52 Kc7 and the a-pawn cannot be stopped.] 47 Kc4 Nf2 48 Kb5 Nxg4 49 Kxb6 Ke6 (If

49...Kg5, White's a-pawn gets to run: 50 b4! axb4 51 a5 Ne5 52 a6 Nd7+ 53 Kc7.) 50 K a5 Nf6 51 Kb6 N h5 52 a5 Nf4 53 a6 Nd5+ 54 Kb7 Kd7 55 a7 Nc7 56 b4! and White wins, since Black is defenseless against he winning advance of the b-pawn to b6.

46 Kc4 Ke6

Because of zugzwang Black has to allow either Kb5 or g5.

47 g5! hxg5 48 Nxg5+ Kf6

The win is just as thematic after 48...Kf5: 49 Nf3! Kf6 50 Nd4 Kg5 51 Nb5! Ne6 52 Kd5 Nc5 53 Nd4 K h5 54 Kc6 Kg5 55 Kxb6.

49 Ne4+ Kg7 50 Nc3! Kh6 51 Nd5 Ne6 52 Nxb6 Kxh5 53 Nd7 Kg5 54 Nc5 Nc7 55 Nb7 Kf5 56 Nxa5 White wins.

Section 5:

The Stronger Side Cannot Force (Create) A Passed Pawn

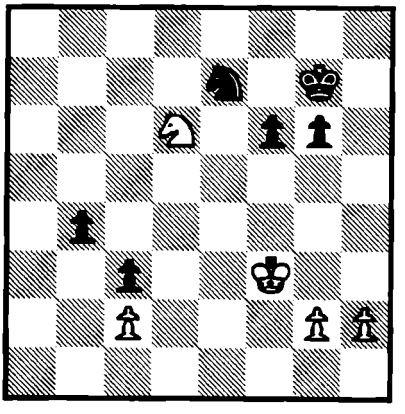
There can be a number of reasons why a passed pawn cannot be forced under satisfactory conditions from a one pawn advantage position. The two most important reasons are King location (the defending King has the more active location) and pawn configuration (the stronger side's pawns are backward, blockaded or partly blockaded, doubled). This section will consider four thematic situations.

The following important principle should always be remembered: **if the stronger side cannot turn its one pawn advantage into a useful passed pawn, its winning chances are significantly reduced. Often there is no win.**

Our first example, Diagram 57, K. Regan - M. Rohde, New York (Marshall/Goichberg) International 1977, after Black's 49th move, shows Black handicapped by both of the factors mentioned above. Clearly, White's King is the more active one in getting to the queenside. Black's King is also too

far back at present to expect to penetrate White's kingside. Moreover, to create as passed pawn on the queenside, Black will have to break with ...b3, thereby sacrificing a pawn. The silver lining here is that the resulting passed c-pawn will be a far advanced one and this prevents White's King from wandering too far afield. My over-all evaluation is: White has fair practical drawing chances, but Black probably has a theoretical win.

Diagram 57



50 Ke2

Both necessary to prevent the threatened 50...b3 and desirable so that the King can head for c4.

50...Nc6

After the more active 50...Nd5, White does best by being active himself: 51 Kd3! (51 g3?! weakens the kingside.) 51...Nf4+ 52 Kc4 Nxg2 53 Kxb4 Ne1 54 Kxc3 Nf3 55 Kc4! Nxh2 56 Kd5 and the passed c-pawn should give sufficient counterchances to stymie Black on the kingside.

51 Kd3 Ne5+

There seems little logic in pushing White's King forward. More to the point is 51...f5!, e.g. 52 Kc4 Kf6, when 53 Kc5?? is refuted by 53...b3.

52 Kd4 f5 53 Ne8+

White correctly aims to use his Knight to go after the b-pawn. Of course, 53 Kxe5?? fails to 53...b3.

53 ...Kf7

Though at first glance the text appears to be less active than 53...Kh6, centralizing the King is the more logical approach.

54 Nc7 Ng4?

But trading off the queenside pawns for just the h-pawn is a bad bargain since Black risks winding up with a theoretically quite drawn ending.

The correct plan is to hold on to the queenside pawns for as long as possible starting with 54...Nc6+!. For example: 55 Kc4 Kf6! 56 Nd5+?! Ke5 57 Nxb4 Nxb4 58 Kxb4 Kd4! 59 g3 Ke3!! 60 Kb3! (60 Kxc3? loses to 60...g5 61 h4 gxh4 62 gxh4 f4 63 h5 f3 64 h6 f2 65 h7 f1=Q 66 h8=Q Qa1+ followed by 67...Qxh8.) 60...Ke2! 61 Kb4! Kd2 62 Kb3 g5 63 h4 gxh4 64 gxh4 f4 65 h5 f3 66 h6 f2 67 h7 f1=Q 68 h8=Q Qh5+ 69 Ka3 Qb2+ 70 Ka4 Qxc2+ leads to a won Q & P endgame.

Therefore, White would have to vary with 56 Na6 Ke5 57 Nc5 or even earlier with 55 Kd3. However, in either case Black keeps realistic winning chances.

55 Nd5!

Correct and clearest. though White also draws with 55 Kc4 Ne3+ 56 Kxb4 Nxc2+ 57 Kxc3 Ne3 58 g3 Nf1 59 Kd3! Nxh2 60 Ke3. However, wrong is 55 h3? b3! 56 Kxc3 bxc2 57 Kxc2 Ne3+ 58 Kc3 Nxg2, when Black has marvelous winning chances because the f-pawn is passed and White's h-pawn quite vulnerable.

55...b3 56 Kxc3 bxc2 57 Kxc2 Nxh2 58 Kd2!

As already discussed in Chapter 3, Section 2, normal positions of N + 2P vs. N + P with all pawns on the same side

are fairly easy draws. Here, White has no difficult in protecting the g-pawn, while Black can't hope to create a passed pawn except by the routine exchange of a pair of pawns. The position is drawn.

58...g5 59 Ke2 Ke6 60 Nc3 Ke5 61 Kf2 Kd4 62 Nb5+ Kd5 63 Nc7+ Ke5 64 Kg3 Draw.

Routine play will not work for Black from Diagram 58, A. Sznapik - O. Romanishin, World Student Championship, aracas 1976, after White's 41st move. For instance, 41...g5?! 42 hxg5 hxg5 43 f3 f5+ 44 Kd4 leaves Black with no viable follow-up, e.g. 44...g4 45 fxg4 fxg4 46 Ke4 allows White an easy draw. Therefore, Black must leave the kingside alone and look for other plans.

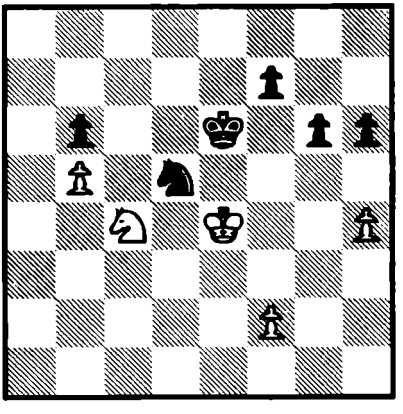


Diagram 58

Black's particular problem is that there is only one White pawn available for capture on the queenside and, moreover, Black's b-pawn is vulnerable to an attack by White's Knight. There are two viable plans for Black. The first is to simply exchange off the b-pawns and aim to win on the kingside by taking advantage of the weakness of White's h-pawn. The alternative is to head for the queenside while leaving the kingside pawns as is. In either case, Black's first move is the same:

41...Nc3+ 42 Kf4

The passive 42 Kf3 makes little sense, because after

42...Nxb5 43 Nxb6 Nd4+ 44 Kf4 h5! (45 Kg5? Nf3+) the best that White can achieve is the game continuation.

42...Nxb5

An interesting practical and psychological moment, because Black chooses the line which entails zero risk for him while, he hopes, still retaining sufficiently realistic pros cts for the win. Theoretically, the more ambitious 42...Nc4!? appears stronger: 43 Ke4 f6! (43...h5 44 Kf4 Kd5 45 Ne3+ Kc5 46 Ke5 allows White counterplay.) 44 Kf4 Kd5 45 Ne3+ Kc5 46 Ng4 Kxb5 47 Nxf6 Kc4 48 Ne4 and now 48...Kd5! keeps White's King out, while preparing the b-pawn's advance.

43 Nxb6 Nd4 44 Na4 Nf5 45 Kg4 Kf6

Now there are two alternatives:

(1) **46 h5??** = Game continuation.

This is just horrible because on h5 the pawn will be in imminent danger of going lost for nothing.

46...g5 47 Nc5 Ng7 48 Ne4+ Ke5 49 Nxg5

Fails for a simple tactical reason, but the "normal" 49 Ng3 leads to an elementary prosaic loss of the h-pawn: 49...f5+ 50 Kf3 f4 51 Ne2 Nxh5.

49...hxg5 50 Kxg5

Or 50 h6 Ne8 when 51 h7? is refuted by 51...Nf6+.

50...Ne6+ 51 Kh6 Kf6 52 Kh7 Ng7!

Black is setting up a zugzwang position.

53 h6 Nf5 54 f4 Ke6 White resigns.

Zugzwang is here and the h-pawn goes lost.

(2) **46 Nc5** = Correct continuation.

White should bring the Knight back, create no new weaknesses and hope for the best. Thematic play now would be:

46...h5+ 47 Kh3 Ke5 48 Nd3+ Ke4 49 Ne1 f6

49...Kf4 50 Nd3+ Kf3? allows 51 Ne5+.

50 Nc2 Kf3 51 Nb4 Ne7!

White has a sure draw after 51...Kxf2? 52 Nd5 g5 53 Nxf6 g4+ 54 Nxg4.

52 Nd3 with continuing drawing chances for White.

After 52...Ke2, White has 53 Nc5!; after 52...g5 53 hxg5 fxg5, White plays 54 Kh2!, when 54...Ke2 55 Nc5 Kxf2? allows 56 Ne4+ followed by 57 Nxg5.

In Diagram 59, V. Korchnoi - B. Spassky, Sochi 1966, after Black's 49th move, White's chances are poor for turning his extra pawn on the queenside into a viable passed pawn. In addition, White's pawn configuration is just too inflexible to directly accomplish anything by pawn advances. Therefore, White should leave his pawns alone and aim first for penetration into Black's side of the board. Sophisticated King and Knight maneuvers will be required to make progress. GM Korchnoi's maneuvering - utilizing the whole board - is of the highest order.

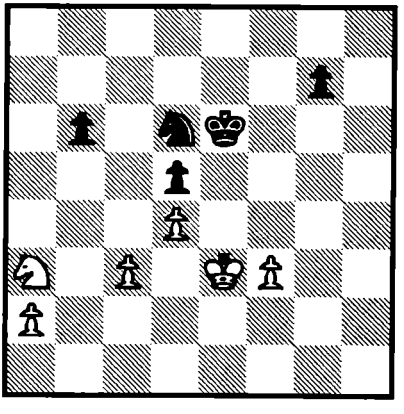


Diagram 59

Since White's Knight is poorly placed on the edge of the baord, the first step should be to get it centralized:

50 Ne2! g5 51 Kd3 b5?!

A controversial move. On the one hand, it prevents a4 and pretty much ensures that Black's two pawns can hold back White's three pawns on the queenside; on the other hand, the b-pawn becomes now much more vulnerable to an attack by White's King. In such unclear situations, the guiding spirit should be the rule of thumb which says: "Don't touch a pawn unless there is a very good reason for it, because you can't move it back!" Because the text violated this "rule", I have attached the dubious mark.

52 Ne3 Nf7 53 Kc2

With White's King & Knight well centralized, the next question is where to try to penetrate. Obviously the first logical choice is the queenside. Recognizing White's plans, Black send his Knight to defend.

53...Nd8! 54 Kb2! Nc6 55 Kb3

The bit of triangulation on moves 54 and 55 by White has caused Black to now be on move. To prevent immediate damage, Black's response is forced, giving White time to redeploy the Knight without having to worry about penetration by Black's King.

55..Kd6 56 Nd1 Ke6 57 Nf2 Kf6

Black is in no condition to play 57...Kf5 58 Nd3 g4? because White wins easily after 59 fxg4+ Kxg4 60 Ne5+ Nxe5 61 dxe5 Kf5 62 Kb4.

58 Nd3

What has White accomplished by moving his apparently well placed Knight from e3 to d3? Well, it stood well on e3, but

had no prospects for further meangful action. From d3 it can head into Black's position via b4, c5 or e5.

58...Ke6 59 Kb2 Kd6 60 Nc5 Na5 61 Kc2!

White is juggling the possibilities for King penetration on both sides so well that Black finds it impossible to cope with all the threats. If now 61...Nc6, White has 62 Na6! Na5 63 Kd3 Nc6 (63...Ke6? loses to 64 Nc7+.) 64 Ke2 Ne7 65 Kf2 Nf5 66 Nb4 Ke6 67 Nc2! Kd6 68 Kg2 Ke6 69 Kh3 when Black will not be able to keep out White's King while simultaneously protecting the weak b- and d-pawns. For example, 69...Nh6 loses the b-pawn after 70 Na3 - one more example of the faults in 51...b5?!.

Convinced that passive defense is hopeless, GM Spassky decides to activate his Knight. This, however, allows White's King to get to the curcial b4 square.

61...Nc4 62 Nd3! Ke6

By now it's too late for the Knight to try to return: 62...Na5 63 Ne5! Ke6 64 Kb2 Kf5 65 Ka3 Kf4 66 Kb4 and White wins. Thus Black's King immediately heads for the Kingside.

63 Kb3! Nd2+ 64 Kb4 Nb1

Perhaps a bit of a better *practical* try is 64...Nxf3?! as then the immediate 65 Kxb5?! allows 65...g4! with excellent counterchances. Instead, White needs to first play 65 Nf2! and only then capture the b-pawn.

65 Nf2 Kf5 66 Nh3

White plans to protect the c-pawn just long enough to be able to take off the b-pawn and start the a-pawn on its run. Passive play by Black is again hopless, e.g. 66...Kf6 67 Ng1 Kf5 68 Ne2 Nd2 69 Kxb5 Nxf3 70 a4 etc. Black, therefore, sends his King into White's position, even at the cost of giving up any dreams of having a passed g-pawn.

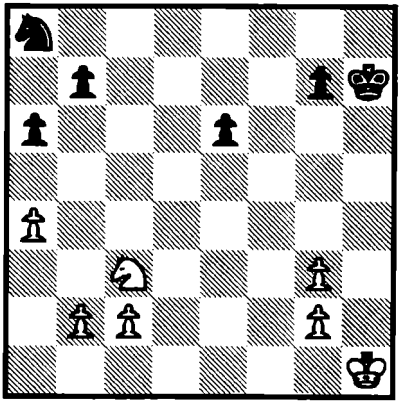
66...g4 67 fxg4+ Kxg4 68 Nf2+ Kf3 69 Nd1 Ke2 70 Kxb5!

The key, ever since 64 Kb4, has been to turn the a-pawn into a tiger. The text enables this; the next move ensures it.

70...Kxd1 71 Kb4! Kc2 72 a4 Black resigns.

The a-pawn can't be stopped: 72...Nxc3 73 a5 Ne4 74 a6 Nd6 75 a7.

Diagram 60



Another unbalanced pawn configuration is shown in Diagram 60, A. Adorjan - G. Iskov, Bagneux 1975, after Black's 25th move. The kind of situation depicted happens often enough to be considered important. White's extra pawn is in the form of a normal 3P vs. 2P queenside majority, though without any near term prospects of creating a passed pawn therefrom. On the other side of the board the pawn story seems to be all Black's: a passed e-pawn while his g-pawn can handle both of White's g-pawns.

Therefore dynamic factors become the significant ones. Black's King is shunted off to one corner of the board and his Knight misplaced on exactly the other corner. As soon as White activates his Knight, various Black pawns will be in trouble:

26 Ne4!

With a powerful central location: the Kni ht threatens

to go to g5 to capture the e-pawn and to c5 to menace both the h- and e-pawns. Something has to give.

26...Nc7?!

As so often happens in an actual game, the defender chooses a line wherein he has some counterchances - here coming from holding on to the e-pawn. Nevertheless, the cost is very high: White obtains a 3P vs. P queenside majority and Black's a-pawn remains vulnerable. Better chances for a draw were to be had with the defensive and exchanging 26...b5! 27 axb5 axb5 28 Ng5+ Kg6 29 Nxe6 Kf6 30 Nd4 Nc7. The small number of pawns remaining and the offensive impotence of White's extra g-pawn mean that White faces serious technical difficulties in realizing his material advantage. Moreover, it is Black who has the active King, e.g. 31 Kg1 Ke5 32 Nf3+ Ke4, making White's task even more difficult.

27 a5!

Fixing Black's queenside thwarts any possible defense based on ...b5. White again threatens 28 Nc5 (and 28 Nd6) and the only way to save the b-pawn is 27...Nb5 28 Nc5 Nd6, allowing the e-pawn to go. Black is reluctant to part with that pawn because his dreams of counterplay would be dashed. Nevertheless, it was the right decision.

27...Kg6?! 28 Nd6 Kf6 29 Kg1! Ke5 30 Nxb7 Kd4 31 Kf2 g6

The bankruptcy of Black's "counterplay" strategy is demonstrated by the choice of the text move. Black has no meaningful way of pressing an attack and therefore satisfies himself in safeguarding the g-pawn against a potential Ne6+ (e.g. 31...Nd5 32 Nd8 e5 33 Ne6+).

32 Nd8 e5 33 Nc6+ Ke4 34 c4

Keeping Black's Knight away from both b5 and d5. It has to search for longer routes now.

34...Ne8 35 Ke2!

The centralized King blockades the passed pawn and keeps Black's King out of the queenside.

35...Nd6 36 b3 Nf5 37 g4 Nh4

Runs into a pretty refutation. Black had nothing satisfactory, anyway. The K & P endgame after 37...Nd4+ 38 Nxd4 is hopeless and 37...Ng3+ 38 Kf2 Kf4 allows White to choose between 39 Ne7, 39 Nb4 and 39 b4.

38 Nxe5! Black resigns.

His Knight gets trapped after 38...Kxe5 39 g3 Ng2 40 Kf2.

Part II

Positional Considerations

Of course, position consideration also exist in situations where one side has a material advantage - as demonstrated in many of the examples in Part I. Nevertheless, the controlling element in Part I was having a material advantage. In this part the key feature is sitional in nature.

Because the Knight is a short range piece, there is one major difference between Knight endgames and those of other pieces: the increased importance of passed pawns. Therefore a considerable amount of time will be spent on passed pawns and this is the first subject to be considered.

CHAPTER 5: PASSED PAWNS

Section 1: The Role of Passed Pawns - General Considerations

The Knight's characteristics have both a good side and a bad side in endgames with passed pawns:

Good side = Because of its flexibility, the Knight can control any square in front of its passed pawn and thereby help it advance.

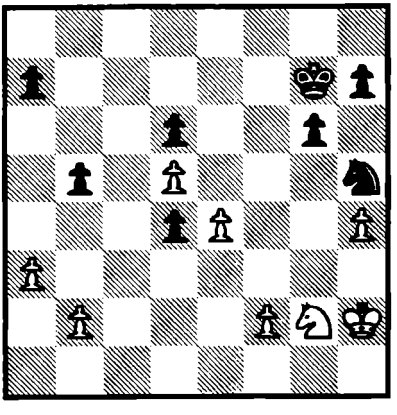
Bad side = Because it is a short range piece, the Knight cannot help its passed pawn advance unless it already is close to it; correspondingly, the Knight has great problems in catching up to a far advanced enemy passed pawn.

The two general situations are: I.) only one side has a passed pawn, II.) both sides have passed pawns.

I. Only One Side Has A Passed Pawn

If the passed pawn is secure and the defenders are not near, this gives excellent winning chances. Apart from the obvious situation where the pawn queens by force, what often happens is that as the defenders rush to stop the passed pawn, they are forced to leave open a road through which the enemy forces can infilitrate decisively into another part of the board.

Diagram 61



An excellent example is from Diagram 61, P. Benko - S. Tartakower, Budapest 1948, after Black's 39th move. Black's passed pawn on d4 is isolated and may appear "sickly", yet White's pieces are not in a position to effectively cope with it. Black scored an instructive win as follows:

40 Ne1

Getting ready to blockade on d3. GM Benko's Analysis shows that the alternatives are no better:
a) 40 f4 d3 41 e5 Nxf4! 42 exd6 Kf7 43 Ne3 d2 44 Kg3 Nxd5 45 Nd1 Ke6 and Black wins.
b) 40 Kh3 Kf6 41 f4 Nxf4+!! 42 Nxf4 Ke5, when "White's chances look dim" (Benko).

40...Kf6 41 Nd3

The logical follow up to the previous move. There is little point in 41 Nf3 d3 42 Kg2 Nf4+ 43 Kf1 h6! 44 Kel Nh3! 45 b3 g5 46 hxg5+ hxg5 47 Kd2 g4 48 Nh2 Nxf2 with a routine win (Benko).

41...g5!

Black must work to infiltrate with his King or alternatively create two widely separated passed pawns. Thus Black wins routinely after both 42 Kh3 Nf4+ 43 Nxf4 gxf4 44 Kg4 d3 45 Kf3 Ke5 and 42 hxg5+ Kxg5 43 e5 (otherwise 43...Nf4 wins) 43...dxe5 55 d6 Nf6 45 Nxe5 Kf5 (46 d7 Nxd7!) etc.

42 Kg2 gxh4 43 f4

White hopes to build an impregnable wall, but Black demonstrates that the ultimate key to the position is his passed d-pawn.

43...h3+! 44 Kxh3 Nxf4+! 45 Nxf4 Ke5 46 Kg3 Kxe4 47 Ng2 Kxd5

Black already has three passed pawns for the piece and White's Queenside remains indefensible. For instance, 48 b3

d3 followed by 49...Kd4. White's King cannot help the Knight on the Queenside as then the h-pawn will run. White is lost.

48 Kf3 Kc4 49 Nf4 Kb3 50 Nd3 d5 51 Nb4 Kxb2 52 Nxd5 Kxa3 53 Nc7 Kb4! 54 Ne6 Kc3 55 Nc7 Kc4 Black won. The last moves are not available. A likely end could be 56 Na6 b4 57 Ke2 b3 58 Kd2 d3 59 Kc1 h5 etc.

Even when the defenders are well pleased, the passed pawn is usually a tangible advantage. Consider now Diagram 62, L. Polugaevsky - H. Mecking, 1977 Match, Game 11, after Black's 39th move. While the d-pawn can be securely blockaded, Black has potential infiltration routes via b4 and f4. White therefore must defend very carefully. The first step is to blockade on d3:

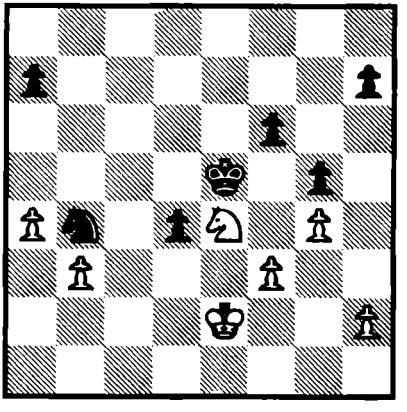


Diagram 62

40 Nc5! Kd6 41 Nd3!

White played this move quickly, thus forcing Black to seal his response. This was to be a most difficult decision as Black has at least four reasonable moves. Moreover, the nature of the position is such that the variations cannot be calculated to a conclusion in the very limited time (1 hour) available. Thus, Black has to rely mostly on his intuition. GM Polugaevsky's second, GM Vladimir Bagirov, had to do the heavy analysis work during the adjournment and has published his findings. What they show is that the adjourned position is extremely complicated. What I will be giving is only the main lines of Bagirov's work.

41...Nc6!

The extensive analysis showed that the text is the best way to retain winning chances. The logical alternatives are: 1) **41...Nxd3?!** was the game continuation which led to a rather clearly drawn K & P endgame: 42 Kxd3 Kc5 43 a5! Kb4 44 Kxd4 Kxb3 45 Kd5 Kb4 46 a6 Kb5 47 Ke6 Kxa6 48 Kxf6 h6 49 Ke5! Kb5 50 f4! gxf4 51 Kxf4 a5 52 Ke3 Kc5 53 h4 Kd5 54 Kd3 Ke5 Draw.

2) **41...Na2:** 42 Kd2 43 Kc2 a5 44 Kb2 Nc3 45 Kc2 Ne2 46 b4! Ng1 47 bxa5 Nxf3 48 Nb4+ Kc5 49 a6 Kb6 50 Nd5+ Kxa6 51 Nxf6 Nxh2 52 Kd3 Ka5 53 Kxd4 Kxa4 with equality, as the Kingside pawns will also soon disappear.

3) **41...Nd5:** 42 Nf2 Kc5! 43 Ne4+ Kb4 44 Kd3 Kxb3 45 Kxd4 Nf4 46 a5! Kb4 47 a6 Kb5 48 Nxf6 Kxa6 50 Kc4 with equal chances. Because of his active position, White's King is well placed to cope with the a-pawn, while the extra Kingside pawn gives White couterplay on the Kingside.

The important *practical* question, of course, is how to select 41...Nc6 from the maze of possibilities as Black's best move. As Bagirov's work has shown, there is no real substitute for time and effort. Yet when in doubt, stick to basic principles: on c6 the Knight is centrally placed while protecting the valuable passed pawn.

42 Nf2 Kc5! 43 Nd3+

White must first practice defensive measures, since 43 Ne4+? Kb4 44 Kd3 Kxb3 45 Nxf6 h6! 46 Ng8 Kxa4 47 Nxh6 Kb3! leaves Black's King too active, compared to both the variations after 41...Nd5 and the later main line.

43...Kd5 44 Nf2 a5! 45 Ne4 h6! 46 Nxf6+ Kc5 47 Kd3 Kb4 48 Ng8

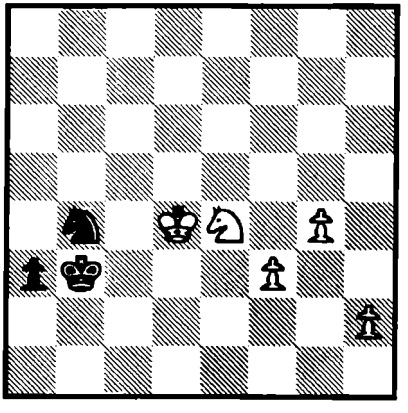
Since in the long run the situation on the Queenside is hopeless, White must create courterchances on the Kingside.

48...Kxb3 49 Nxh6 Kxa4 50 Nf7 Kb3 51 Nxg5 a4 52 Ne4 Nb4+!

White is safe after 52...a3 53 Nd2+: 53...Kb2?! 54 Nc4+; 53...Kb4 54 Kc2. Therefore, Black plays out his major trump: since the RP is the most difficult pawn for the Knight to stop, Black airms to mobilize it as quickly as possible.

53 Kxd4 a3

Diagram 63



The obvious 54 Nc3? does not lose to the fancy 54...Nd5? (with the idea 55 Nxd5 a2) because of 55 g5! Nxc3 56 g6. Instead, the prosaic 54...Nc6+ 55 Kd3 Ne5+ 56 Kd4 Nxf3+ 57 Kd3 Ne5+ 58 Kd4 Nxg4 does the job, e.g. 59 h4 Nf6 60 Kd3 Nh5 61 Kd4 Nf4 etc.

Therefore, White's defensive plan must be much more sophisticated:

54 Nd2+! Kc2 55 Kc4! a2 56 Nb3 Nc6! 57 Na1+!

There is no other defense to the threatened 57...Na5+. With the text White uses a well known method in defending against the RP: he sacreifices the Knight to imprison the stronger side's King.

57...Kb2 58 Kd3! Ne5+ 59 Kd2 Nxf3+ 60 Kd1 Kxa1 61 Kc2! Drawn

Black's Knight cannot deny simultaneously both c1 and c2 to White's King. This exact position is drawn even without the Kingside pawns - see Diagram 1!

II. **Both Sides Have Passed Pawns**

The main line play from Diagram 62 could already be considered to have been an introduction to the situation where both sides have passed pawns. Now I shall consider "purer" examples. Because Knights are slow movers, the most important factor in positions where both sides have passed pawns becomes how far advanced the respective passed pawn is. In other words, the side with the further advanced passed pawn has the advantage.

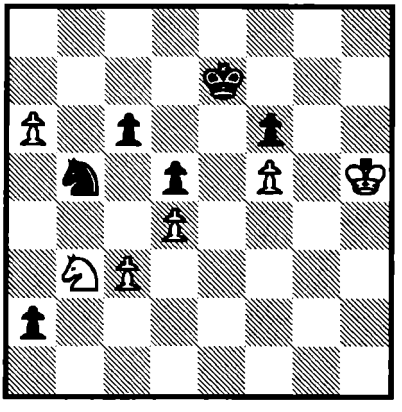


Diagram 64

The first instructive example is Diagram 64, Domont - I. Rogers, Biel II 1983, Black on move. The locations of the respective a-pawns look unreal, but are quite genuine. Because Black's a-pawn is ready to queen, White's Knight is much more tied to its passive location than is Black's Knight. Moreover, Black's King can get at the enemy passed pawn faster than White's King can do the same. This factor liberates Black's Knight for the important offensive duty. Black won as follows:

1..Kd6! 2 Kg6 Kc7 3 Kxf6 Nxc3 4 Ke7 Ne4 5 a7

After 5 f6 Nxf6 6 Kxf6 Kb6 7 Kf5 Kxa6 8 Kf4 Kb5 Black's King gets decisively into White's position: 9 Ke3 Kc4 10 Na1 Kc3 11 Ke2 Kxd4 (not 11...Kb2? because of 12 Kd2!

Kxa1 13 Kc1 - the same motif as in the previous example) 12 Kd2 Ke4! 13 Kc2 d4 14 Kb2 d3 15 Nb3 Ke3 16 Kxa2 d2 17 Nxd2 Kxd2 18 Kb3 Kd3 19 Kb4 Kd4 20 Kb3 c5 21 Kc2 Kc4 and Black wins.

5...Kb7 6 Kd7 c5!!

Ensuring that Black remains with the d-pawn ensures the win. White draws after 6...Kxa7? 7 Kxc6 Nf6 8 Kb5 or 8 Kd6.

7 dxc5 Kxa7 8 c6 Nc5+ 9 Nxc5

According to GM Rogers, White's best try was 9 Kd6! Nxb3 10 c7, but Black still wins after 10...Kb7! 11 Kd7 Nc5+ 12 Kd8 a1=Q 13 c8=Q+ Kb6.

9...a1=Q 10 c7 Qg7+ 11 Kd6 Qf8+ 12 Kxd5 Qxf5+ 13 Kc6 Qc8 14 Kd6 Qe8 15 Na4 Kb7 White resigns

A far advanced passed pawn can easily outweigh the material disadvantage of a pawn. This is well illustrated from Diagram 65, A. Sydor - I. Dorfman, Warsaw 1983, after Black's 54th move. White has an extra pawn and two passed pawns, but Black's far advanced passed pawn is full compensation. Play continued:

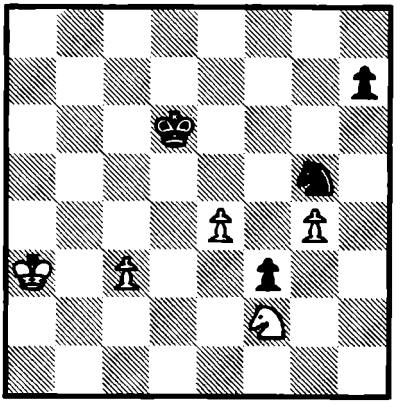


Diagram 65

55 c4

Short of time, White decides to mobilize both of his passed pawns. This should have been sufficient to draw, yet a simpler way is given by GM Dorfman: 55 Kb3 Ke5 56 Kc2 and White holds after both 56...Nxe4 57 Nxe4 Kxe4 58 Kd2 Kf4 59 Ke1 Kxg4 60 Kf2! h5 61 c4 h4 62 c5 and 56...Kf4 57 Kd2! Kg3 58 Ke1.

55...Kc5 56 Kb3 Kd4 57 c5 Ne6! 58 c6 Ke3 59 Nb1 f2 60 Nxf2

The nasty pawn must be eliminated. In the game White played the ridiculous 60 Ng3??? and lost after 60...Nd4+ 61 Kc4 Nxc6 62 Kd5 Kf4! 63 Nf1 Ne5 64 g5 Nf3 65 e5 Nxe5 66 Kd4 Nf7 White resigns.

60...Kxf2 61 Kc4 Kf3

There are no winning chances after 61...Ke3, e.g. 62 Kd5 Nc7+ 63 Ke5 followed by 64 Kf5.

62 Kd5 Nc7+ 63 Kd6 Nb5+ 64 Kc5 Na7

The only try for a win though fraught with some risk, since the Knight is placed on the edge. After 64...Nc7, White draws with 65 Kd6 or 65 e5.

65 e5

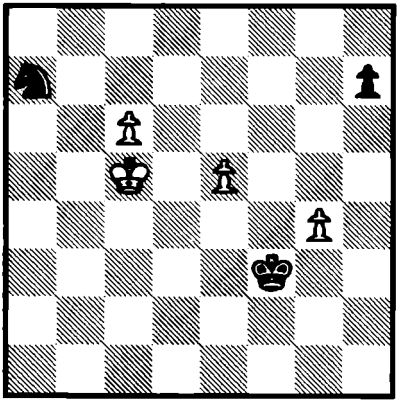


Diagram 66

This endgame shows off the great difficulty that the

Knight has in coping with passed pawns. Instead of the text losing is 65 Kb6?? Nxc6 66 Kxc6 Kxe4, since White's King is one square too far away after 67 Kc5 Kf4 68 Kd4 Kxg4 69 Ke3 Kg3 70 Ke2 Kg2.

65...Nc8

Black loses after 65...Kxg4?? 66 Kb6 Nc8+ 67 Kc7 Ne7 68 Kd7, as he does after 65...Kf4 66 Kd6 Nxc6?? 67 e6! since 67...Na7 is met by 68 Kd7 and 67...Nd4 by 68 e7 as Black lacks the check on f5. Instead of 66...Nxc6?? the draw can be retained with 66...Nb5+ 67 Kc5 or 67 Ke6.

66 Kd5!

But not 66 e6?? Kxg4 and Black wins because White's King cannot penetrate fast enough.

66...Kxg4 67 Ke6 Kg5!

Black's King must be in a position to help stop the e-pawn. Losing are 67...h5? 68 Kd7 Nb6+ 69 Kc7 Nd5+ 70 Kd6 as well as 67...Kf4? 68 Kd7 Nb6+ 69 Kc7 Nd5+ 70 Kd6 Nb6 71 e6.

68 c7

Simplest, though White also draws with 68 Kf7 h5 69 e6 h4 70 e7 h3 71 e8+Q Nd6+ 72 Kf8 Nxe8 73 Kxe8 h2 74 c7.

However, the routine 68 Kd7? now actually loses: 68...Nb6+ 69 Kc7 Nc4!: (a) 70 e6 Kf6 71 Kd7 Ne5+; (b) 70 Kb7 Kf5! 71 c7 Kxe5 72 c8+Q Nd6+; (c) 70 Kb8 Nxe5 71 c7 Nc6+ 72 Kb7 Ne7.

68...h5 69 Kd7 Nb6+ 70 Kc6 Nc8 71 Kd7

71 e6?? Kf6 wins for Black as he then has ...Ne7, blockading and winning.

71...Nb6+ 72 Kc6 Draw

Neither side can afford to avoid the move repetition. The play from Diagram 66 was a wonderful example of the role of the Knight in coping with passed pawns.

The ultimate endgame with far advanced passed pawns is when both sides have the pawn one step away from queening. A wonderfully instructive position is shown in diagram 67, Dudkin - Gofman, USSR 1989, Black on move. It is true that Black's passed pawn is ready to queen, whereas White's lacks the support of the King to do so. Yet the c-pawn is a tremendous power also and Black may not underrate it. I shall first look at Black's immediate promotion and then the much more sophisticated, correct plan. My work is mostly based on GM Vladimirov's published anaylsis.

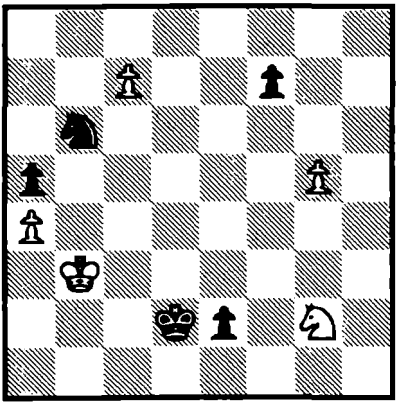


Diagram 67

A) Black rushes to queen: 1...e1=Q? 2 Nxe1 Kxe1 3 Kc3

White's King now is liberated and this gives just enough counterplay to draw.

3...Nd5+

The draw is simpler after 3...Nxa4+ 4 Kc4 Nb6+ 5 Kb5 Nc8 6 Kxa5 Ke2 7 Kb5! Ke3 8 Kc6 Kf4 9 Kd7 Na7 10 Ke7 Kxg5 11 Kxf7.

4 Kc4 Nxc7 5 Kc5

White's pride and joy has gone lost, but the new theme

of the Knight being a short distance piece and having particular problems with passed RPs allows White to achieve the draw.

5...Ke2

There is no time for 5...Ne6+ 6 Kb6 Nxg5 ecause after 7 Kxa5 Ne4 8 Kb6 Nd2 9 Kc5 f5 10 a5! Nb3+ 11 Kd5 Nxa5 12 Ke5 Black's pawn goes lost.

6 Kb6 Nd5+ 7 Kxa5 Nc3

White's King is also fast enough after 7...Ke3 8 Kb5 Nc3+ 9 Kc6! Nxa4 10 Kd6 Kf4 11 Ke7.

8 Kb6! Nxa4+ 9 Kc6 Nc3 10 Kd6 Ne4+ 11 Ke7 Nxg5 12 Kf6 Draw

B) Bringing about zugzwang starting with 1...Kd1! = Game continuation

Because 2 Ka3 now or later allows Black to queen with White's King misplaced, Black starts triangulating with his King so as to put White's Knight in zugzwang.

2 Ne3+

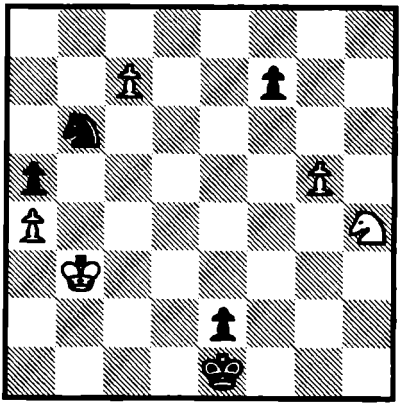
Hopeless is 2 Kc3 because of 2...Nd5+ 3 Kc4 Nxc7 4 Kc5 Ne6+ 5 Kb5 Nf4! - the e-pawn is much more valuable than either White's or Black's Knight.

2...Kc1 3 Ng2 Kd2 4 Nh4 Ke1!! -See Diagram 68 on the next page.

Only so. The materialistic 4...e1=N? 5 g6 hxg6 6 Nxg6 Nc8 7 Kc4 allows White to capture Black's last pawn.

The game comtinuation was 4...Kc1 5 Ng2 Kd1 6 Ne3+ Ke1? (Black could still get into the winning line with 6...Kc1 7 Ng2 Kd2 8 Nh4 Ke1) 7 Nd5!! Nc8 8 Nf4 Nb6 9 Nd5. The game was now called a draw, though Black could have continued to play on without risk. Nevertheless, with

Diagram 68



thematic play White does draw after 9...Nc8: 10 Nf4 Kd2 11 Nxe2 Kxe2 12 Kc4 Ke3 13 Kb5 Kd4 (13...Kf4 14 Kxa5 Kxg5 15 Ka6 f5 16 Kb7 is also drawn) 14 Kc6! (White loses after 14 Kxa5?? Kc5) 14...Ke5 15 Kd7 Na7 16 Ke7, simplifying down to equality after 16...Kf5 17 Kxf7 Kxg5 18 Ke6! etc.

Ng2+

After 5 Nf3+ Kd1! the zugzwang is instantaneous.

5...Kf1! 6 Ne3+ Kg1! 7 Nc2 Kf2 8 Kc3

Just as unpalatable is 8 Ka3 e1=Q 9 Nxe1 10 Kb3 Kd2 etc.

8...Nd5+ 9 Kc4 Nxc7 10 Kc5 Ne6+ 11 Kb6 Nd4 Black wins

Section 2: **Outside Passed Pawn**

It is well known that in King and pawn endgames, the side with the outside passed pawn has a major advantage. The reason is that while the defending King is stopping this pawn, the other King can penetrate into the other side of the board and generally gain enough material to win the game. Yet in Queen and pawn, Rook and pawn and Bishop and pawn endgames, the quetion of the outside passed pawn is generally

Irrelevant. All these are long range pieces and thus have no difficulty in stopping any kind of a passed pawn from far away. However, in Knight endgames, the outside passed pawn again becomes a significant factor. The reason is that the Knight, being a short range piece, has great difficulty in stopping far away passed pawns. By definition, the outside passed pawn is the passed pawn farthest away from the major ultimate scene of action.

A perfect example of the realization of the advantage of having the outside passed pawn is shown from Diagram 69, D. Bronstein - A. Chistyakov, 1978 Moscow Championship, after Black's 50th move. White's passed g-pawn is much greater threat than Black's potential passed c-pawn and he won as follows:

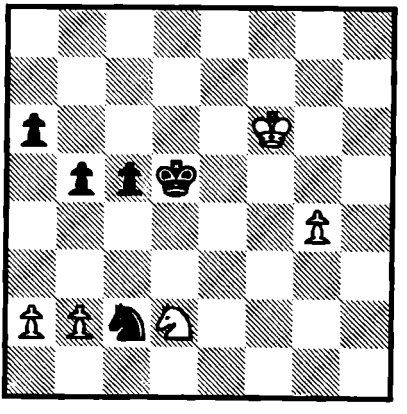


Diagram 69

51 g5!

Passed pawns must be pushed!

51...Nd4 52 g6 Ne6 53 Kf7!

Insufficient is 53 g7?! Nxg7 54 Kxg7 c4 and Black hs a certain draw. White, of course, wants to queen for nothing and therefore with the text move prevents Black's threatened 53...Nf4 54 g7 Nh5+, followed by 55...Nxg7.

53...c4?

GM Bronstein now demonstrates a forced win. IM C. Crouch has pointed out that things are not so clear after 53...Nd4!: (1) 54 Kf6 Ne6 repeats the position; (2) 54 Nf3 Ne6 also seems to hold; (3) 54 g7 Nf5 55 g8+N c4 gives Black sufficient counterplay. White's winning chances rest only with 54 Nf1!, working to deny Black's Knight the crucial f5 square.

54 Ne4! Nd4

Black looks to sacrifice the Knight via f5. On the obvious 54...b4, winning is the non-obvious 55 Nc5!! : 55...Kxc5 (Or 55...c3 56 bxc3 bxc3 57 Nxe6 c2 58 Nf4+ Ke4 59 Ne2) 60 Kxe6 c3 61 bxc3 bxc3 62 g7 c2 63 g8+Q c1=Q 64 Qc8+.

55 Nc5!!

Again there is nothing in 55 g7? Nf5 56 g8=Q? Nh6+.

55...Nf5

Both 55...Kxc5 and 55...a5 are met by 56 Kf6! and the g-pawn cannot be prevented from queening.

56 Nxa6 Nh4

And so Black succeeds in sacrificing the Knight, but the fact that White's Knight has captured on a6 gives White sufficient material to win. If 56...c3, White wins after 57 b3! and 58 Nb4.

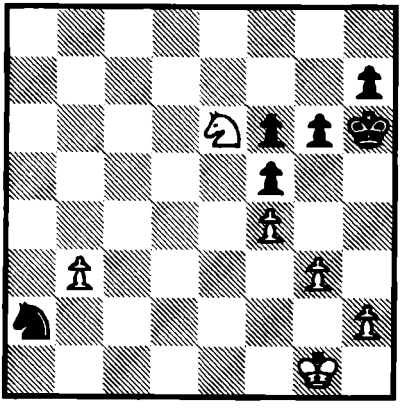
57 a3 Nxg6 58 Kxg6 Kd4 59 Nb4 c3 60 b3 c2!? 61 Nxc2+ Kc3

Black has set a nice trap into which a careless White can fall: 62 a4? bxa4 63 bxa4 Kc4! 64 Kf6 Kc5 65 Ke6 Kb6! 66 Kd5 Ka5, with a draw.

62 Na1! Black resigns

Both White's pawns are safe and bringing back the King wins easily.

Diagram 70



However, to demonstrate that the outside passed pawn is an advantage, you must actually try to utilize it. An excellent example of what *not* to do is shown from Diagram 70, S. Martinovic - A. Gipslis, Belgrade 1968, White on move. White has a passed b-pawn, whereas Black's extra pawn on the King-side, being doubled, will not be able to become passed. Yet note how White absolutely goes nowhere:

1 Kg2?!

King centralization with 1 Kf2! is in order.

1...g5 2 Kf3?!

Logical is 2 Nd4! Kg6 3 Nc2, followed by 4 b4.

2...Kg6 3 Ke3

Note that it has taken White three moves instead of the normal two to go from g1 to e3. Again 3 Nd4! makes more sense.

3...Kh5 4 h3 Nc3

After 4...Nb4, strong is 5 Kd4!.

Kd3?

White apparently has not yet noticed that he also has a Knight. Good winning chances were still to be had after 5 Nd4! Nd5+ 6 Kf3 Kg6 7 Nc2, followed by b4.

5...Ne4! 6 g4+ Kg6 7 Ke3

Black now has enough counterplay for the draw and in particular he will also get a passed pawn. No better than the text are 7 Nd4 Nf2+ 8 Ke3 Nxh3 9 gxf5+ Kh5! 10 fxg5 Nxg5 with equality (Maric) or 7 fxg5 fxg5 8 Nf8+ Kg7 9 gxf5 Nc5+! 10 Kc4 Nxb3! 11 Ne6+ Kf6 12 Kxb3 Kxf5, with Black having no problems at all in drawing.

7...Nc3! 8 gxf5+ Kxf5 9 Nd4+ Kg6 10 f5+ Kb5 11 Kf3 Kh4 12 Kg2 g4 13 hxg4 Kxg4

Both sides have outside passed pawns now and the chances are fully equal.

14 b4 Nd5 15 b5 Kf4 16 Kh3 Ke4 17 Ne6 Kxf5 18 Nf8 h6 19 Kh4 Draw.

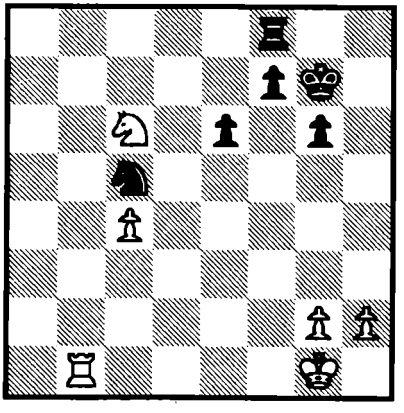


Diagram 71

Though the outside passed pawn is usually an advantage, that does not mean that it is a cure-all for any and all situations. This is shown from Diagram 71, D.Kopec - W. Browne, Canada 1976, after Black's 32nd move. Despite the reduced number of pawns, Black does have a clear advantage, since his passed e-pawn is a sound, protected one whereas White's c-pawn is more of a weakness than strength. White

should work now to improve the position of his Knight and King. For this, moves such as 33 Kf2 or 33 Nd4 come into view. Instead, he becomes mesmerized with the idea of achieving a Knight endgame where White will have the outside passed pawn:

33 Rb5?! Ne4 34 Rb8?! Rxb8 35 Nxb8 Kf6!

White's mission has been accomplished, yet the war is lost. In the first place, the c-pawn is just a bit of an outside passed pawn. And even more importantly, it is quite weak here, requireing much care and demonstrating little power. White is lost.

36 Nd7+ Ke7 37 Ne5 g5! 38 h3 f6 39 Nd3 Kd6 40 Kh2 e5! 41 g3

Since the center is all Black's, White aims quite correctly at creating a truly useful outside passed pawn, the h-pawn. But Black's central activity comes first.

41...Nd2! 42 c5+ Kd5 43 h4 e4 44 Ne1 Nc4!

Ensuring that the Knight can get back via e5 to stop the h-pawn.

45 c6 Kxc6 46 h5 Ne5 47 Kh3 Nf7 48 g4 Kd5 49 Kg3 Kd4 50 Kf2 Nh6 51 Nc2+ Kc3!

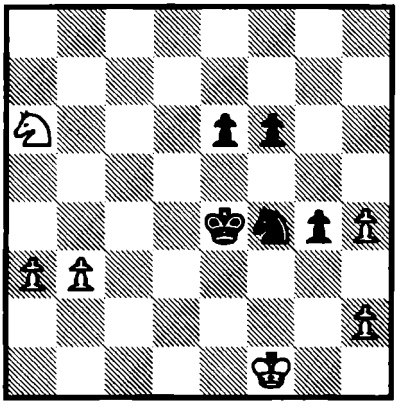
Black's active King, in combination with the extra pawn in the form of a passed e-pawn, is decisive.

52 Ne3 Kd3 53 Nf5 Nxf5 54 gxf5 e3+ White resigns

Black queens with mate after 55 Ke1 g4 56 h6 g3 57 h7 g2 58 h8=Q g1=Q.

In complicated - even wild looking positions - it is important to remember the inherent power of the outside passed pawn(s) in Knight endgames. This principle is illustrated perfectly from Diagram 72, M. Taimanov - B. Larsen, Leningrad Interzonal 1973, after White's 45th move.

Diagram 72



Larsen had quite wrongly airmed for this position. On a superficial basis Black's passed e- and f-pawns appear powerful, aided as they are by the actively placed King and Knight. yet this power is nothing compared to that residing in White's outside passed pawns. White has a won position:

45...Kf3 46 Nb4!

The Knight heads back to stop the most dangerous passed pawn: the e-pawn.

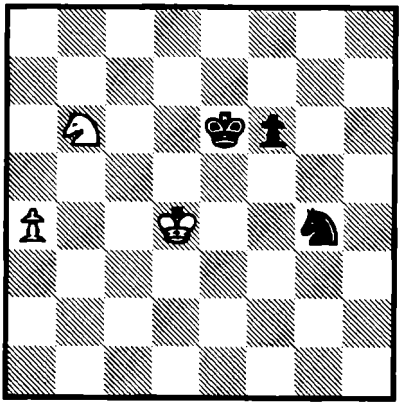
46...e5 47 Nc2! e4 Draw??!

What a curious finish! After White's 47th move Larsen offered a draw, whereupon Taimanov correctly asked him to first make his move. Larsen did and after 30 minutes thought Taimanov accepted. In fact, after either one of his normal moves, White wins by force: (1) 48 b4 e3 49 Nxe3 Kxe3 50 b5 Nd5 51 h5 and the h-pawn queens.

(2) 48 a4 e3 49 Ne1+! (Not 49 Nxe3? Kxe3 50 a5 Ke4! 51 a6 Nd5, stopping all of White's pawns.) 49...Ke4 50 a5 Kd5 51 Nc2! e2+ 52 Kf2 Kc5 53 b4+ Kb5 54 Nd4+1 Kxb4 55 Nxe2 and one of the Rook pawns will be victorious.

The Rook pawn is by far the most difficult one for the Knight to stop. There are two reasons for this. Firstly, it is the most outside pawn. Secondly, once the RP has reached the 7th

Diagram 73



rank, the Knight by itself cannot cope with the enemy King and thus will go lost. A clean crisp example of the first reason is shown from Diagram 73, Vilela - Augustin, Prague 1980, White on move. White only has one pawn and it is only on the fourth rank. Yet being the a-pawn, it wins:

1 Kc5!!

Black's Knight by itself will not be able to stop the pawn and it is imperative to prevent the King from helping out. Insufficient is 1 a5? because of 1...Kd6! 2 a6 Ne5! followed by 3...Nc6.

1...f5

Putting his hopes on the f-pawn, since the Knight cannot get back, e.g. 1...Ne5 2 a6 Nd7+ 3 Kc6! Nb8+ 4 Kb7 and White wins.

2 a5 f4 3 a6 f3 4 Nc4!

Whereas Black's Knight cannot handle the Rook pawn, the less outside Bishop pawn is no problem for White's Knight.

4...f2 5 Nd2 Nf6 6 Kc6!

Care is always required. The impatient 6 a7? allows 6...Ne4+! and a draw.

6...Ne4 7 Nf1 Black resigns

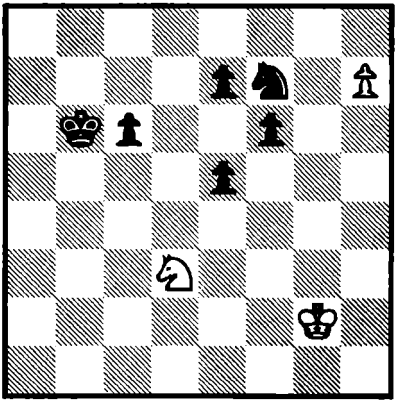


Diagram 74

The unique power of a RP on the 7th rank can be demonstrated from Diagram 74, Kikilashvili - Neuronov, U.S.S.R. 1977, White on move. In earlier play, White had sacrificed three (!) pawns to get his h-pawn on the 7th. This should have been sufficient to draw. Play continued:

1 Kg3!

White's King wants to get to g7 which will force Black's Knight to give up watch over the key h8 square.

1...c5 2 Kg4 c4 3 Nb4!!

White's Knight must be placed so that it can combine effectively defense and offense. In the game White put the Knight on a clumsy square with 3 Nb2?!. After 3...Kc5 he committed a King placing error, 4 Kf5?, and lost as follows: 4...Nh8! 5 Ke6 Kd4 6 Nd1 e4 7 Kxe7 f5 8 Kf6 e3 9 Nxe3 Kxe3 10 Kxf5 (After 10 Kg7 c3 11 Kxh8 c2 12 Kg8 c1=Q 13 h8=Q Qc8+ Black's f-pawn is the winner.)10...c3 11 Kf6 c2 12 Kg7 c1=Q 13 Kxh8 Kf4! 14 Kg7 Kg5! 15 h8=Q Qc7+ 16 Kg8 Kg6 and White resigned.

However, instead of 4 Kf5?, the more direct 4 Kh5! seems to draw: 4...e4 5 Nd1! Kd4 6 Kg6 Nh8+ 7 Kg7 c3 (After 7...e3??? 8 Nxe3 Kxe3 9 Kxh8 c3 10 Kg7 c2 11 h8=Q c1=Q 12 Qh6+ Black's Queen is lost.) 8 Nxc3 Kxc3 9 Kxh8

e3 10 Kg7 e2 11 h8=Q e1=Q 12 Qc8+! Kb3! 13 Qb7+ 14 Qd5+ and White's threats of perpetual check will force the gain of the e-pawn and with it a draw.

3...Kc7

Equally instructive is the play after 3...Kc5 4 Nc2 c3 5 Kh5! Kd6 6 Kg6 Ke6 7 Kg7 f5 and now the Knight heads to deflect black's King from defense of his Knight: 8 Ne1! f4 (Or 8...e4 9 Ng2! followed by 10 Nf4+.) 9 Nd3! c2 10 Nc5+ Kf5 11 Nb3!, with Black having nothing better than to acquiesce in the repetition of moves after 11...Ke6 12 Nc5+ etc. (analysis by Gufeld and Milic).

4 Kh5! Kd7 5 Nd5! Kd6

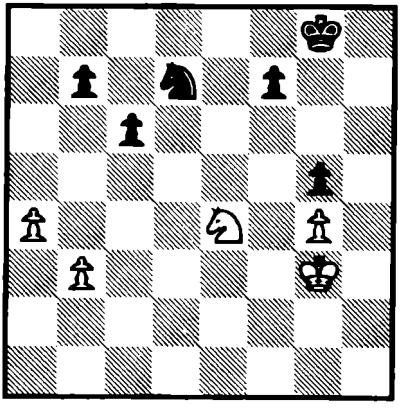
Heading back with 5...Ke8 is foiled by the active 6 Nc7+: (1) 6...Kf8 7 Ne6+ Ke8 8 Nc7+ etc., (2) 6...Kd8 7 Nd5 e6 8 Kg6! Nh8+ 9 Kg7! and Black must rush to draw with 9...Ke8! (10 Nxf6+ Ke7 11 Ng8+ Ke8 12 Kxh8 Kf8 etc.).

6 Nc3! f5 7 Kg6 Ke6 8 Kg7! Nh8! 9 Na41! f4 10 Nc5+ Kd5 11 Kxh8 f3 12 Kg7 Drawn

Both sides will queen, with the resulting Q + N vs. Q + 3P endgame offering Black no real winning chances (analysis by Gufeld and Milic).

Of course, examples such as the previous one are rare in practical play. Yet, an important part of any master's "bag of tricks" for endgame play is the knowledge that a RP in the role of an outside passed pawn can turn around an otherwise routine evaluation of a position. An instructive example from practical play is shown from Diagram 75, E. Mednis - Spassky, World Student Championship, Varna 1958, after Black's 40th move. Black is a pawn up and White can't regain it with 41 Nxg5? because of 41...Nc5. Nevertheless, it is White who is significantly better because of the potential of creating a passed a-pawn. The game was to be adjourned here and while I was preparing to seal, GM Spassky offered me a draw. I refused it via sealing my move:

Diagram 75



41 a5!

The immediate 41 Nd6? has no punch because of 41...b6. But after the text 42 Nd6 becomes a threat which cannot be parried. Black has to try to find a way to minimize the damage to come.

41...Kf8!

After a full night of analysis Black finds the only correct defense, activating the King and blockading White's to-be-passed a-pawn by placing the Knight on a6. Then White's passed pawn is kept back as far as possible.

Inferior is 41...b5? 42 b4!, and even after Black's best defense, 42...Kf8 43 Nc5 Ke7, with 44 a6! Nb6 45 Kf3 Kd6 46 Ke4 White establishes such a total bind ove the position that Black's situation is hopeless. For instance, 46...Na8 47 Kd4 Kc7 (or 47...f6 48 Ne4+ Ke6 49 Kc5) 48 Ne4 Kb6 49 Nxg5 Kxa6 50 Nxf7, when Black's pieces are in no condition to stop the g-pawn.

42 Nd6 Nc5!

Though this may appear useless, since the Knight does not actually protect the b-pawn, GM Spassky's analysis had demonstrated that he must keep his Knight as active as possible. Again inferior is 42...b5? 43 a6 Nb6 (43...Ke7? 44 Nc8+

followed by 45 a7.) 44 a7 Na8 45 Kf3 Ke7 46 Ne4 f6 47 Ke3 Ke6 48 Kd4 when Black has kept his material advantage, but it is White who has a won position. A thematic example for Knight endgames then is 48...f5 49 Nxg5+ Kf6 50 Nh7+! Kg6 51 gxf5+ Kxh7 52 Kc5 Kg7 53 Kxc6 Kf6 54 Kb7 and White wins. In such variations, the abyssmal location of Black's Knight on a8 is just too much of a burden to overcome.

Therefore, GM Spassky, at the cost of his extra pawn, transfers the Knight to the much more superior blockading square of a6. I must admit that in my analysis I had given scant attention to the text move - giving up a pawn while still allowing White a passed a-pawn just looked "obviously hopeless." The only "excuse" for my inattention could be youth - I was only 21!

43 Nxb7! Na6

Obviously both 43...Nxb7?? & 43...Nxb3?? lose to 44 a6.

44 Kf3 Ke7 45 Ke4

So far so good - and I felt quite confident here. White has the outside passed pawn *and* the active King. With such obvious advantages why shouldn't White have an easy win? What reasonable moves does Black have? Black loses a pwn after 45...Ke6? 46 Nd8+; after either 45...f6 or 45...Kd7, White plays 46 Kd4! and then displaces Black's Knight by 47 Nc5.

45...c5!!

It was only after this move that I realized that there may not be a win after all: Black prevents Kd4 and threatens to walk over to c7 and capture White's Knight. White therefore must play either 46 Kd5 or 46 Ke5.

After 46 Ke5 Kd7! (Not 46...f6+? 47 Kf5 Kd7 48 Kxf6 Kc7 49 Nxc5 Nxc5 50 b4! and White wins.) 47 Nd6 Black draws by a hair as follows: 47...f6+ 48 Kd5 Nc7+! 49 Kxc5 Na6+!! (White gets a pleasant Q + b-pawn vs. Q endgame after 49...Ne6+?! 50 Kb6! Kxd6 51 a6 Nc7 52 a7! f5 53 gxf5 g4 54 f6 g3 55 Kb7! etc.) 50 Kb6 Kxd6 51 Kxa6

f5 52 gxf5 g4 53 Kb5 g3 54 a6 g2 55 a7 g1=Q 56 a8=Q Qc5+! 57 Ke4 Qd4+! 58 Kb5 (58 b4?? Qa1+) 58...Qc5+ with perpetual check.

46 Kd5 f5!!

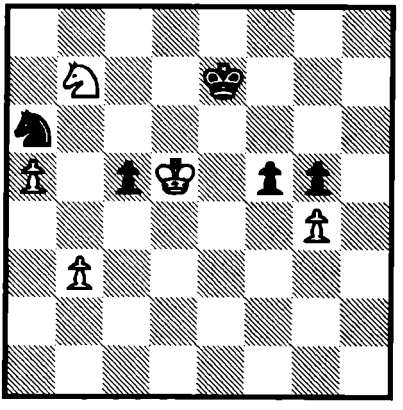


Diagram 76

With White's King now removed by one square from the Kingside, Black immediately establishes counterplay by creating a passed pawn there.

47 Nxc5

The alternative is 47 gxf5 g4! 48 Ke4 g3 49 Kf3 Kf6 50 Kxg3 Kxf5 when Black's active King ensures the draw. The sacrifice 52 Nxc5 Nxc5 52 b4 is neutralized by 52...Nd7.

47...fxg4!

While it is true that the K & P endgame after 47...Nxc5 48 Kxc5 f4 49 Kd4 Kd6 is drawn, White can do better with 49 a6! (instead of 49 Kd4) 49...f3 50 a7 f2 51 a8=Q f1=Q, when the Q & P endgame with an extra pawn and well placed pieces gives excellent winning chances.

Black therefore prefers to stay in a Knight endgame where - he hopes - the passed g-pawn(s) will give him sufficient counterchances. The future shows GM Spassky to be right. Obviously now 48 Nxa6?? loses to 48...g3.

48 Ne4 Kd8!

Black's King must help out the Knight in stopping/blockading the pawns. But inferior is 48...Kd7? because after 49 Nf6+ Kc7 50 Nxg4 White is blockading the g-pawn one square earlier.

49 Kc6

We have an instructive and thematic positon where White, in effect, is a pawn up and each side has passed pawns on opposite wings. Being on the g-file, Black's passed pawn is far enough away from the Queenside (an "outside passed pawn") and being on its fifth rank it is sufficiently advanced to significantly tie down White's Knight. I have not been able to find a win for White.

49...g3

There was no need for this sacrifice and also no apparent benefit from it. Perhaps Black wanted to make sure that in some nebulous future he is not thwarted in a stalemate bid by an extra g-pawn.

50 Nxg3 Kc8 51 Ne4 g4 52 Kb6

Or 52 Kb5 Nc7+ 53 Ka4 Kb7 54 b4 Kc6 and black has a sufficiently firm blockade. Then after 55 Nc3 g3 56 b5+ Kb7! (After 56...Nxb5? 57 Nxb5 g2 58 Nd4+ Kd5 59 Nf3 Ke4 60 Ng1 White wins by one tempo.) 57 Ne2 (57 b6 Nd5! 58 Ne2 Nxb6 draws.) 57...Nxb5! 58 Kxb5 g2 Black has a theoretical draw.

52...Nb4 53 Kb5

Neither is there a win after 53 a6 Kb8.

53...Nc2 54 Kc5?!

This allows Black to set up a blockade. Black's task would be considerably more difficult after the immediate 54 b4!, though 54...Kb7 should hold, e.g. 55 Ka4 Nd4 56 b5 Ne2

57 Nc5+ Kb8 58 Nd3 g3 59 Ne1 Nf4 60 b6 g2 61 Nf3 Nd5 62 Kb5 Nc7+! 63 bxc7+ (Or 63 Kc6 Na6!) 63...Kxc7 64 Ka6 Kb8 and Black just draws. Note that both here and in the variation given after White's 52nd move, White's problem is that he is left with a RP. With any other pawn White would win.

54...Kb7 55 b4 Ka6! 56 Ng3 Na3

Black's King and Knight have excellent defensive locations and White cannot make any progress.

57 Ne2 Nc2 Draw

A fantastic defensive performance by Black!

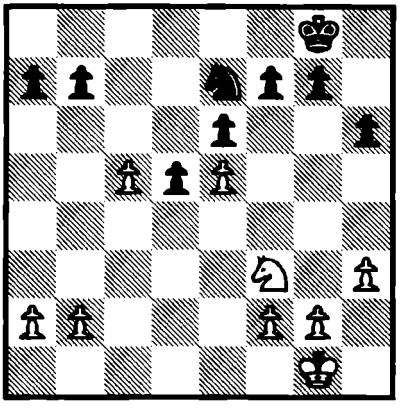
Section 3: **Protected Passed Pawn**

The inherently superior passed pawn to have is what is called the *protected passed pawn*, i.e. a passed pawn which is protected by another pawn. The value of the protected passed pawn comes from its security, because it cannot be attacked by an enemy pawn and it can be caputred by a piece only at the cost of that piece's life. Once the endgame is reached, this security frees its King and piece(s) for attacks in other parts of the board, while the protected passed pawn pins down the enemy to prevent its ultimate queening.

Of all the pieces, it is the Knight which is the premier blockader. Moreover, because of the nature of its jump-moves, it is able to attack from its blockading location the pawn that is protecting the "protected passed pawn". Therefore, Knight endgames are the best endgames to aim for when you have to cope with a protected passed pawn. Of course, the protected passed pawn is a clear advantage in Knight endgames also, but less so than in other endgames. In this section I will discuss the factors that help determine the value of the protected passed pawn in Knight endgames.

What to me seems the most picture-perfect example of the value of the protected passed pawn in Knight endgames is shown by Diagram 77, M. Basman - P. Benko, Hastings

Diagram 77



1973/74, after White's 24th move and the play therefrom. Just on the previous move White had quite erroneously offered the exchange of Queens (23 Qc3 - c5?? Qc6xc5 24 dxc5) to arrive at Diagram 77. Black's d-pawn is a wonderful and secure protected passed pawn. On the other hand, White has no prospects for a viable passed pawn on the Queenside. Other important features of the positon will become clear as the play unfolds:

24...Nc6!

With a dual purpose: immobilizing White's Knight and preventing b4. Because his Knight is stuck to protecting the e-pawn, White has scant chances for meaningful counterplay on the Kingside. This gives Black plenty of time to work on infiltrating via the Queenside.

25 a3 a5 26 b3

White prevents the fixing of his Queenside with 26...a4, but loses a tempo for activating his King. Either situation is unpleasant.

26...Kf8 27 Kf1 Ke7 28 Ke2 Kd7 29 Kd3

As will be seen, White cannot stabilize his Queenside in any event. There is no satisfactory defense, but better practical chances are offered by 29 h4, with the idea of 30 g4 and 31 g5;

if 29...h5, then White can play 30 Ke3 and 31 Kf4 and either redeploy his Knight or try Kg5.

29...Kc7 30 g4 g5!

Stopping any potential Kingside play.

31 Kc3 b6! 32 cxb6+ Kxb6 33 Kd3

33 a4 is also met by 33...Kc5; equally hopeless is 33 b4 axb4+ 34 axb4 Kb5.

33...Kc5 34 Ke3 a4!

Opening up infiltration squares. If now 35 b4+ Kc4 Black's King is in and he has the dominant protected passed pawn: a) 36 Nd2+ Kc3 37 Nf3 Nxb4! 38 axb4 a3, winning; b) 36 Kd2 Na7! 37 Kc2 Nb5 38 Kb2 Kd3, winning.

35 bxa4 Kc4 36 a5 Nxa5 37 Nd4 Kc5 38 Kd3 Nc4 39 f4

The loss can be only delayed with 39 Nb3+ Kb6! etc.

39...Nb2+ 40 Kc2

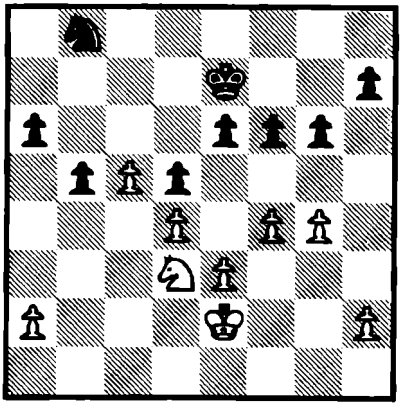
Or 40 Kc3 Nd1+ 41 Kd3 Nf2+ 42 Kc3 gxf4 etc.

40...Kxd4 41 fxg5 hxg5 White resigns

The K + P endgame after 42 Kxb2 Kxe5 is hopeless. The decisive element was Black's protected passed d-pawn, even though it never had to move.

Historically, the favorite example of the value of the protected passed pawn in Knight endgames, as presented in reference books on the endgame (GM Reuben Fine, GM Yuri Averbakh etc.) has been Diagram 78, H. N. Pillsbury - I. Gunsberg, Hastings 1895, after Black's 26th move. White has a secure passed c-pawn, yet it seems rather blockaded and if Black would have time for 27...Nc6, the defense could not be broken. However, with a characteristic pawn break White is able to undermine Black's insecure central pawn formation.

Diagram 78



27 f5!! g5

If 27...gxf5 28 gxf5 exf5, 29 Nf4 will give White connected passed pawns in the center, as will 27...exf5 28 gxf5 g5 29 Nb4; 27...Nc6 loses to 28 Nf4 Nb4 29 a3 Nc2 30 Nxe6 Nxa3 31 Nc7 a5 32 Nxd5+.

28 Nb4! a5 29 c6!

The momentary awkward location of the black Knight allows this tactical shot. The threatened 30 c7 forces Black's reply.

29...Kd6 30 fxe6 Nxc6 31 Nxc6 Kxc6 32 e4!!

The key to the White's previous play: he wins the K & P endgame by one tempo as a result of creating in the center far advanced connected passed pawns. This is an important theme in K & P endgames, but does not have much to do with the theme of the protected passed pawn in Knight endgames

Black might as well take, since 32...Kd6 33 exd5 Ke7 34 Ke3 Kd6 35 Ke4 Ke7 36 Kf5 b4 37 d6+ Kxd6 38 Kxf6 is hopeless.

32...dxe4 33 d5+ Kd6 34 Ke3 b4

Or 34...f5 35 gxf5 b4 36 f6 a4 37 f7 Ke7 38 d6+ Kf8

39 d7 etc.

35 Kxe4 a4 36 Kd4 h5 37 gxh5 a3 38 Kc4 f5 39 h6 f4 40 h7 Black resigns. This last round game enabled the unheralded Pillsbury to finish first, ahead of Tchigorin, World Champion Emanuel Lasker, Tarrasch, Steinitz, etc.

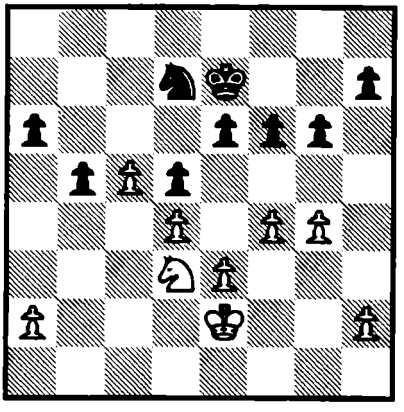


Diagram 79

However, if we return to the previous game just a half move earlier, the evaluation becomes different. Diagram 79 shows the position in H. N. Pillsbury - I. Gunsberg, Hastings 1895, after White's 26th move. In the game, Gunsberg played the careless 26...Nb8?. Instead, Emanuel Lasker subsequently recommended:

26...a5!

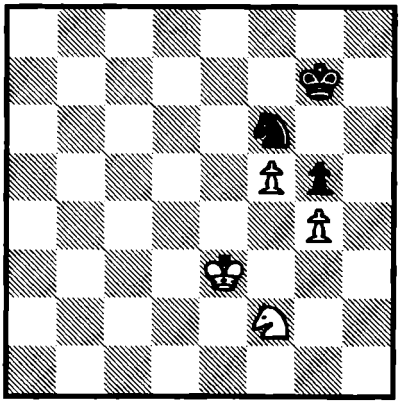
Because White's Knight no longer has access to b4, Black is ready to continue with 27...Nb8 and 28...Nc6, with a stable position. After the text, Pillsbury's pawn break is no longer successful. The following analysis is by Emanuel Lasker in the tournament book:

27 f5?! g5! 28 c6 Nb6 29 Nc5 exf5 30 gxf5 Kd6 31 Nb7+ Kxc6 32 Nxa5+ Kc7!

Lasker here gives the following evaluation: "Black has, if anything, the better chances, as he threatens 33...Nc4 followed by 34...Nd6."

Because the defensive Knight is such a great blockader, even positions where the protected passed pawn is an extra pawn may not be won. Such positions usually have the blockading Knight attacking the "protecting" pawn. First, we will consider positions where all the pawns are on the same side. In Diagram 80, Y. Averbakh 1955, White is up a protected passed f-pawn, but his g-pawn is vulnerable. There is no win, e.g.:

Diagram 80



1 Kf3

Or 1 Kd4 Kf7 2 Ke5 Ke7 and there is no way for White to progress.

1...Nd7! 2 Ke4

White's King is too passive after 2 Ne4 Ne5+ 3 Kg3 Kh6.

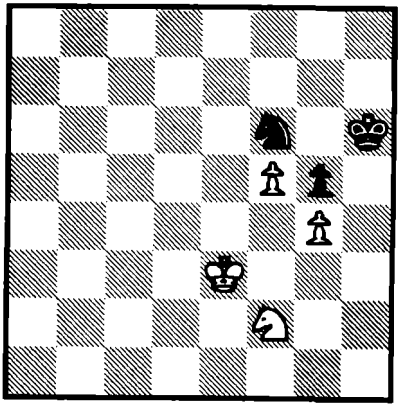
2...Nf6+ 3 Ke5 Kf7 4 Kd6 Ne8+ 5 Kd7 Nf6+ 6 Kd8 Kf8 Draw

Even if we misplace Black's King by a tempo in Diagram 80 to give Diagram 81 (on the following page), Y. Averbakh 1955, there seems to be no win:

1 Kf3!

There again is nothing in 1 Kd4 Kg7 Ke5 Kf7 3 Kd6 Ne8+ 4 Kd7 Nf6+ 5 Kd8 Kf8.

Diagram 81



1...Nd7!

The passive 1...Kg7? 2 Ne4 Nh7 (forced), allows White's King to simply march in: 3 Ke3 Kf7 4 Kd4 Ke7 5 Ke5 Kf7 6 Kd6 Kf8 7 Ke6 Kg7 8 Ke7 Kh6 9 Kf7.

2 Ke4

Again, there is nothing in 2 Ne4 Ne5+ 3 Kg3 Nf7 etc.

2...Kg7 3 Kd5 Kf7!

Averbakh gives as the main line 3...Nf6+? 4 Ke6 Ng8 5 Ne4 Nh6 6 f6+ Kg6 (6...Kg8 7 Nxg5 Nxg4 8 f7+ Kg7 9 Nh7) 7 Nd6! Nxg4 8 f7 Kg7 9 Ke7 and White wins.

4 Ne4

"and wins" - Averbakh. Yet Black has a defense:

4...Ke7! 5 Kd4 Ke8!!

It is imperative that White's Knight not have a check after 6 Nxg5 Nf6.

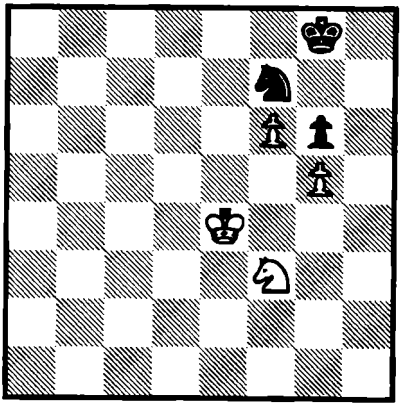
6 Nxg5

What else? After 6 Ke3 or 6 Kc4?! Black has 6...Ne5(+).

6...Nf6 7 Ke5 Nxg4+ 8 Ke6 Kf8 9 Nh7+ Kg7 Draw

White does win if we move the position up by one rank because Black has less maneuvering room. In Diagram 82, Averbakh 1955, the win is achieved as follows:

Diagram 82

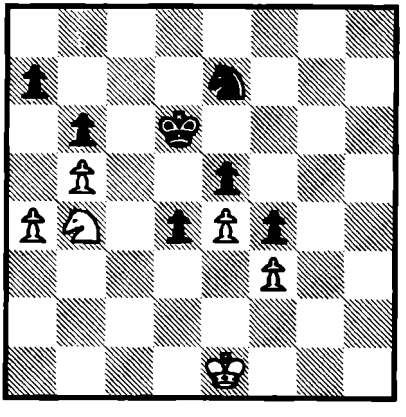


1 Kf4! Nd8 2 Ke5 Nf7+ 3 Ke6 Kf8 4 Kd7! Nh8 5 Ne5 Nf7 6 Nxg6+

Also 6 Nxf7 Kxf7 7 Kd6 Kf8 8 f7! Kxf7 9 Kd7 wins.

6...Kg8 7 Ne7+ Kf8 8 g6 White wins.

Diagram 83



A thematic example where an extra pawn in the form of a protected passed pawn is insufficient to win, even with pawns

on both sides of the board is shown in Diagram 83, M. Botvinnik - G. Lissitsin, Moscow 1935, White on move. White's Knight has access to the ideal defending/attacking d3 square and this is sufficient to hold the game:

1 Kd2 Ng6

1...Kc5 2 Nd3+ Kc4?! 3 Nxe5+ Kb3 4 Nc6 cannot offer Black winning chances.

2 Kd3 Nf8 3 Kc4 Ne6 4 Nd3! Ng4

The K & P ending after 4...Nc5 5 Nxc5! bxc5 6 a5! is drawn, e.g. 6...Kd7 7 Kd3 c4+ 8 Kxc4 Kd6 9 Kb4 d3 10 Kc3 Kc5 11 b6 axb6 12 axb6 Kxb6 13 Kxd3 Kb5 14 Kc3 Kc5 15 Kd3 Kb4 16 Kd2! etc. (Fine).

5 Ne1 Ke6 6 Kb4!

It is useful to leave d3 available to the Knight. In the game White chose the passive 6 Kd3, but still held on after 6...Kd6 7 Kc4 Nh3 8 Nd3 Ng1 9 Ne1 Ke6 10 Kd3 (10 Kb4!) 10....Nh3 11 Kd2 Kf6 12 Kd3 Ke7 13 Ke2 Kd6 14 Nd3 Ng5 15 Nb2 Nf7 16 Nd3 Nd8 17 Nb2 Nb7 18 Kd2 Nc4 19 Kc2 Ke6 20 Kd1 etc. The text is a suggestion by GM Fine.

6...Nh3 7 Nd3 Ng1 8 Ne1 Kf6

The attempt to infiltrate the Kingside will not work because White's King can now penetrate Black's side of the board. But if 8...Ne2 9 Kb3 Ng3 10 Nd3 Nf1 11 Kc2 Kf6 12 Kd1 Black's King remains chained to his e-pawn.

9 Kc4 Kg5?! 10 Kd5 Kh4 11 Kxe5 Kg3 12 Kxd4 Nxf3+ 13 Nxf3 Kxf3 14 e5 Drawn (Fine)

Whatever winning chances there are belong to White after 14...Kg2 15 e6 f3 17 e7 f2 18 e8=Q f1=Q 19 Qg8+ Kh3 20 Qh7+ followed by 21 Qxa7. This shows that attempts by Black to play for a win by abandoning his center pawns can beoomerang very easily.

Chapter 6

Pawn Structures

Because the Knight is inherently a short range piece, by far the most important element of pawn structures in Knight endgames is the existence of passed pawn(s) and in particular the outside passed pawn. The important aspects of passed pawns in Knight endgames were thoroughly covered in earlier sections. Here I will take a look at the remaining important subjects regarding pawn structures: the Queenside pawn majority and characteristic deficiencies in pawn structures.

Section 1: The Queenside Pawn Majority

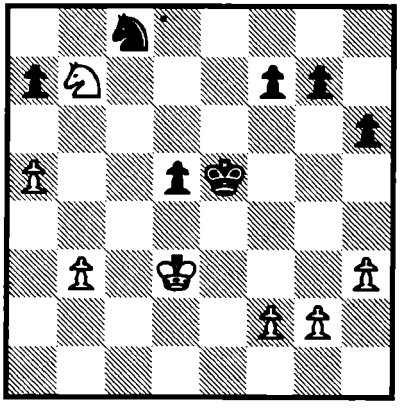
The side having a pawn majority on the Queenside generally has some endgame advantage. Assuming that the pawn majority is healthy and can lead to a passed pawn, this passed pawn would be *an outside passed pawn.* If the enemy King gets tied down to stopping such a pawn, your King and Knight have excellent chances for decisively infiltrating on the other side.

Please note that I am using the term "Queenside pawn majority" because it is the common one and is in by far the majority of cases also the accurate description. Yet the truly accurate expression would be the generic one: Qualitative Pawn Majority On One Side. You can visualize that if both sides are castled on the Queenside, that then it is the *Kingside* pawn majority that is the potential advantage.

A very favorable case of the Queenside pawn majority is shown in Diagram 84 (on the following page), I. Radulor - J. Pinter, Pernik 1978, after White's 31st move. Even though it is Black who already has a passed pawn, the *potential* White passed pawn on the Queenside is the significant factor in the position. Black does have the more active King, yet the fact that White's Knight is the active one more than outweighs the King factor. The game continued:

31...f5

Diagram 83



The attempt at improving the Knight position with 31...Nd6? fails after 32 Nd8!, threatening 33 Nc6+. If then 32...Kf6, 33 Kd4; if 32...a6, 33 Nc6+ Ke6 34 Nb8 Nb7 35 b4.

32 b4! g5?

Allowing White's b-pawn to get to b5 must be suicidal: White is ready to create a powerful outside passed pawn while the important defensive c6 square is denied Black. Only 32...Nd6 offered chances for defending because, at this moment, the K & P endgame after 33 Nxd6 Kxd6 34 Kd4 Kc6 appears drawn.

33 b5! h5

Now it's too late for 33...Nd6 34 Nxd6 Kxd6 since after 35 Kd4 White gets a decisive outside passed pawn.

34 Nd8! g4 35 hxg4 hxg4

35...fxg4 gets the same 36 g3 response. Black has succeeded in only exchanging off one Kingside pawn, leaving him with two potentially vulnerable pawns there.

36 g3 Kd6 37 Kd4 Ne7

After 37...Kd7, White puts Black in zugzwang with 38 Nc6 Kd6 39 a6! (IM Minev).

38 Nf7+ Ke6 39 Kc5! d4

After 39...Kxf7 40 b6 axb6 41 axb6 the b-pawn queens. Passive defense with 39...Nc8 loses to 40 Nd8+ Ke5 41 Nc6+ Ke4 42 Nxa7+!. We are seeing again the problem the Knight has in stopping outside passed pawns.

40 Ng5+ Kf6 41 Nh7+! Kg7

Now Black's King is too far away from the Queenside, but if 41...Ke5 White queens with check after 42 b6! axb6 43 axb6 d3 44 b7 d2 45 b8=Q.

42 Kxd4 Kxh7 43 Kc5 Nc8 44 Kc6 f4 45 Kd7 fxg3 46 fxg3 Nb6 47 axb6 Black resigns

And so the Queenside majority won by itself. While Black was kept busy safeguarding his pawns elsewhere, White infiltrated the Queenside.

Where the Queenside pawn majority is sound, but chances for crating a viable outside passed pawn scant, the position most likely is in *dynamic* balance. This means that with correct play the game will be drawn, but that there are plenty of opportunities for one side to misplay things. An instructive example is shown from Diagram 85, A. Kotov - S. Reshevsky, Zurich Candidates 1953, after Black's 49th move.

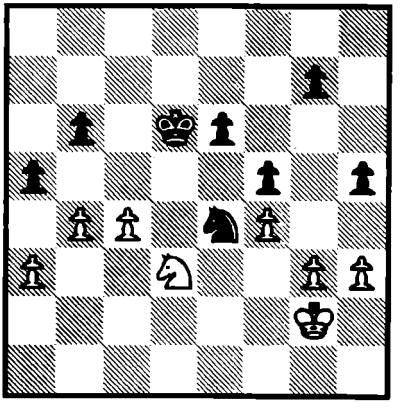


Diagram 85

White has a healthy Queenside pawn majority, yet the

prospects for a successful break with c5 are poor. In the meanwhile Black is ready to respond to 50 Kf3? with 50...Nd2+, winning the c-pawn. White therefore prevents that threat by activating his Knight:

50 Ne5 a4?!

Black seriously misjudges the position and by playing for a win risks a loss. With the text, he fixes White's a-pawn on a3 and plans to play the Knight to b1, capturing the pawn. Yet the position turns out to be much more complicated than that. Correct is the routine 50...axb4 51 axb4 when White's Queenside is secure, yet also there is no way to progress there. Therefore: continuing equality.

51 Kf3 g5

The first cloud starts to appear on Black's horizon. It turns out that after the direct 51...Nd2+ 52 Ke3 Nb1? 53 Kd3 Nxa3 54 b5 Black's Knight is trapped. This same motif will appear later also.

52 Ke3! g4

White has effectively centralized his King and suddenly Black has no attractive continuation on either side of the board.

Witness the other two main lines:
(a) 52...Nc3? 53 Kd3 Nb1 54 Kc2 Nxa3+ 55 Kb2 h4 56 Kxa3 hxg3 57 Nf7+ Ke7 58 Nxg5. The g-pawn gets stopped and White wins.
(b) 52...Nxg3? 53 Nf7+ Ke7 54 Nxg5 and to extricate the Knight Black will lose at least the h-pawn.

53 hxg4 hxg4 53 Nxg4 Nc3?

Black keeps dreaming of a win on the Queenside when the need was to search for a drawing line. For that the normal 54...Nxg3 55 Nf2 Nf1+ 56 Kd3 e5 sequence should be good enough.

55 Ne5! Nb1 56 Kd3 Nxa3 57 b5!

Traps the Knight, as already given in the note to Black's 51st move. Inferior is the fancy 57 Kc3? (threatening 58 Kb2) because of 57...b5! 58 c5+ Kd5 when Black's Knight is safe and the position drawn.

57...Nxb5

Black grabs two pawns for his Knight since after the "normal" 57...Kc5 he would wind up with less: 58 Nd7+ Kb4 59 Nxb6 Nb1 60 Nxa4! Kxa4 61 b6 and the pawn queens.

58 cxb5 Kc5 59 Nf3 Kxb5 60 Nd4+ Kb4 61 Kc2! e5

Black hopes to weaken White's pawns and to use his connected passed pawns to keep White's King passive. But his situation is soon shown to be hopeless.

62 fxe5 Kc5 63 e6 Kd6 64 Kc3 b5 65 Kb4 Ke7 66 Kc5! a3 67 Kd5 Black resigns

The Knight stops Black's pawns leaving White's King in charge of a routinely won K & P endgame.

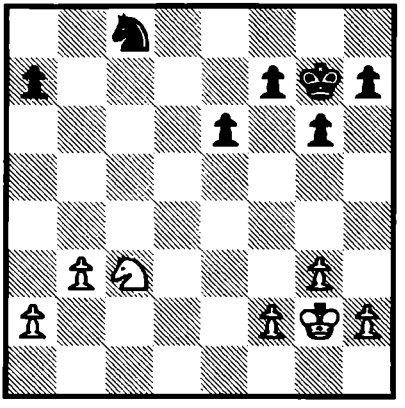
Of course, having the Queenside pawn majority will not by itself lead to an advantage. You must purposefully work to capitalize on it, by either mobilizing the pawns, the King or both. Otherwise the potential advantage is a fleeting one. Instructive indeed is the sequence of play from Diagram 86 (on the following page), A. Karpov - J. Timman, Final Candidates Match 1990, Game 2, after Black's 27th move.

It is truly a classical thematic position: White has a sound Queenside majority, Black a healthy Kingside majority, with neither majority as yet mobilized. White's majority should mean a tangible advantage, yet see how quickly it disappears:

28 f4?!

GM Timman calls this "not a good move". Instead he was worried about the immediate 28 Kf3! f5 29 Ke3 e5 30

Diagram 86



Nb5!. In the post mortem, best play for both sides seemed to be 30...Kf6 31 Kd3 Kg5! (Black must look for counterplay on the Kingside. After 31...Ke6?! 32 Kc4! White is making significant riskless progress.) 32 f3 h5 33 Kc4 h4 34 Kd4 hxg3 35 hxg3 e4! 36 fxe4 f4! 37 gxf4+ Kxf4, when, according to Timman, "the g-pawn should guarantee the draw". I think that this is correct, yet as long as White is in position to sacrifice his Knight for the g-pawn, White's prospects on the Queenside mean that only he has winning chances. Remember what happened in the play from Diagram 84!

With the text White makes it possible to exchange off Black's e-pawn for his f-pawn, but at the large cost of a lost tempo for King activation. Timman remarks that "after the text Black is not worse".

28...f5 29 Na4

The Knight's routing leads nowhere. Better is 29 Kf3.

29...Kf6 30 Nc5 Nb6 31 Nd3

31 a4?! Ke7 32 a5 Nd5 only weakens White's Queenside pawns.

31...Nd7 32 Nb4?!

Continuing to lose valuable time. In order is 32 Kf3,

with a drawn K & P endgame resulting after 32...e5 33 fxe5+ Nxe5 34 Nxe5 Kxe5 35 Ke3.

32...e5 33 Nc6 a6 34 fxe5 Nxe5 35 Nd4

Already it is too late for 35 Nxe5? Kxe5 36 Kf3 Kd4! and the extra tempo allows Black's King to get into White's Queenside for the win.

35...Ke7 36 Kf1?!

More lost time. Correct is 36 h3 followed by 37 Kf2 and 38 Ke3.

36...Kd6 37 Ke2 Kd5

Because of White's tarrying, it is Black's King who is lord of the board. The text keeps the advantage but it could have been enlarged with 37...Kc5! 38 Nc2 g5! followed by 39...f4! (Timman), when Black has created a powerful "outside" passed pawn. Note the change of the theme of the position: because the potential danger for White now is the Queenside, the f-pawn becomes an outside passed pawn.

38 Nc2 Ke4?!

Black gets a wonderfully active centralized King, yet affords White the chance to finally mobilize his Queenside. Instead correct is 38...a5! 39 a3 (39 b4? a4 critically weakens the c4 square) 39...Ke4 when after 40 h3 White's position is very unpleasant but still defensible.

39 a4! Nf3 40 b4

Simpler is 40 h4 and after 40...f4, 41 Kf2. Yet understandably, after the previous passive suffering, Karpov prefers activity.

40...Nd4+

A "safety first" approach to the last move of the time control. More consistent is 40...Nxh2, even though sub quent analysis showed that the position is drawn after 41 b5 axb5 42

axb5 Kd5 when after either 43 Ke3 or 43 Nd4 White can sacrifice his Knight in time for enough of Black's pawns.

41 Nxd4 Kxd4 42 b5 Draw

After 42...axb5 43 axb5 Kc5 44 Ke3 Kxb5 45 Kf4 Kc5 a draw results after 46 Kg5 Kd4 or 46 h4 Kd4.

Section 2:

Characteristic Deficiencies in Pawn Structures

If a double pawn is part of a pawn majority, this is a serious handicap. The reason is simply that it is much more difficult to create a passed pawn from such a formation. A model exploitation of this factor is shown from Diagram 87, K. Pytel - J. Bielczyk, Polanica Zdroj, 1976, after Black's 23rd move.

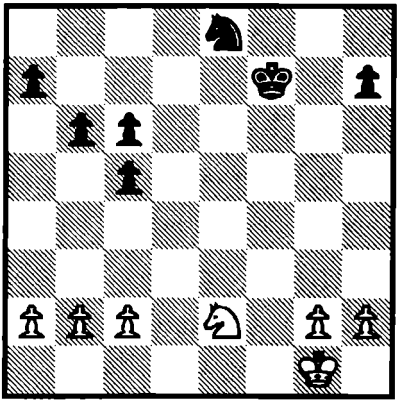


Diagram 87

White has a qualitative pawn majority on the Kingisde and excellent prospects for creating a viable passed pawn there. Black's extra pawn, being doubled, will be much less of a help in creating a passed pawn on the Queenside. White's pieces at the moment are modestly placed; therefore, his first order of business is to activate them. There will be time enough to start mobilizing the Kingside pawns.

24 Kf2! Nd6 25 Kf3 Kf6 26 Kf4! Nc4 27 b3 Na3 28 c3 a5 29

Ng3!

Because Black's Knight has succeeded in loosening up White's Queenside, Black's chances there must be taken seriously. Thus the immediate 29 g4?! is premature because of 29...c4 30 g5+ Kg6. But after the text, 29...c4 can be met by 30 Ne4+ Kg6 (30...Ke6 31 Ng5+) 31 Ke5!, with White's King in position to penetrate Black's Queenside. Nevertheless, Black's chances are real enough after 31...cxb3 32 axb3 b5! and this was the way to go. As played, Black turns out to be slow on either side of the board.

29...h6?! 30 Ne4+ Ke6 31 c4!

Giving Black no more chances for ...c4, and thereby making the creation of a passed pawn a much more difficult job.

31...a4 32 g4! axb3 33 axb3 Nc2 34 h4!

White's K + N stand well enough so that it is time to get the pawns going.

34...Nd4 35 Nd2

According to IM Pytel, the immediate 35 g5 hxg5 36 Kxg5! is winning. Yet it is more than understandable that White has no interest in making such a decision before the time control on Move 40. Moreover, there is no need for it.

35...Kf6 36 Ne4+ Ke6 37 Nd2 Kf6 38 Ke4 Ke6

Black's c-pawn disappears after 38...b5? 39 cxb5 cxb5 40 Kd5 (40...Ne6 41 Ne4+). However, after the text White can paralyze Black's majority long enough with ...

39 b4! Kd6 40 bxc5+ Kxc5

After 40...bxc5 41 Nf3! White has a riskless won position, yet the counterplay after the text is too slow.

41 Ke5! b5 42 g5! hxg5 43 hxg5 Nc2

43...bxc4 just drops the Knight after 44 Ne4+ Kb4 45 Kxd4.

44 g6 Ne3 45 Kf4!

Preventing the Knight from getting back (45 g7?? Ng4+ 46 Ke5 Nh6 is a last nice finishing touch to White's exemplary play.

45...bxc4 46 Kxe3 Black resigns

The isolated d-pawn by itself is not a serious problem. This is because the flexible Knight can be used to either protect the pawn or the key squares around it, as the need may be. The play from Diagram 88, V. Korchnoi - G. Kasparov, Semi-Final Candidates Match 1983, Game 8, after Black's 25th move, demonstrates the correct approach to coping with this situation. Apart from having the isolated d-pawn, there is nothing wrong in Black's camp and with the proper care he draws without too much sweat:

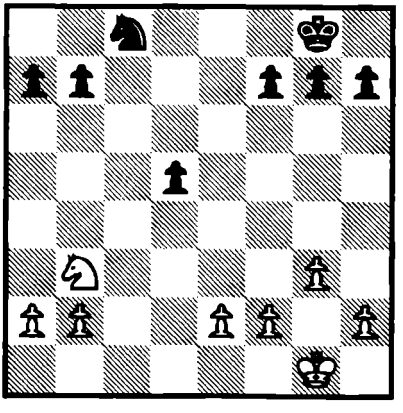


Diagram 88

26 Nc5

There is nothing in 26 f3 Kf8 27 Kf2 Ke7 28 Ke3 Kd6 29 Nd4 Ne7 and everything is secure in Black's position (30 Nb5+? Kc5 31 Nxa7?? Kb6).

26...Nd6 27 Kg2

Here too analysis by Kasparov and Shakarov shows that 27 f3 f6 28 Kf2 Kf7 29 Ke3 is easily parried by 29...b6! (Not 29...Nc4+? 30 Kd4 when Black has allowed White's pieces to become very active.) 30 Nd3 Ke6 and Black is safe since 31 Kd4 is met by 31...Nb5+.

27...Kf8 28 Kf3 Ke7 29 Kf4 f6 30 h4!

White tries to both grab some space as well as to induce potentially damaging weaknesses in Black's position. Thus 30...h5?! 31 f3 b6 32 Nd3 Ke6 33 g4! hxg4 34 fxg4 Ne4 35 h5 would lead to some permanent weakness of Black's g-pawn. The coming World Champion refuses to bite.
30...g6! 31 g4 b6 32 Na6 Ne4! 33 f3 Nc5 34 Nc7 d4!

Working to exchange off his weakness, e.g. 35 Nb4 d3!. Neither can 35 b4 d3 36 Nd5+ Ke6 37 e4 d2 38 Nc3 Nd3+ 39 Ke3 Nxb4 40 Kxd2 lead to any advantage for White. After 34... 4! Black is not worse.

35 Nd5+ Ke6 36 Nb4 a5 37 Nd3 Kd5 38 g5 f5 39 Kg3 Nxd3 Draw

Since Black has no winning chances either, GM Kasparov simplifies into a dead drawn K & P endgame.

Pawn formations which have unquestioned strengths in opening and middlegame play can well turn out to be a weakness in endgames.

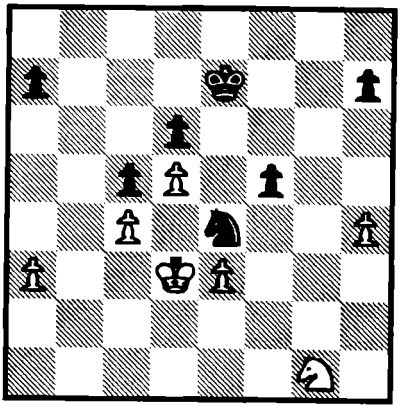


Diagram 89

Consider now Diagram 89, M. Pètursson - M. Marin, Manila Interzonal 1990, with Black on move. The pawn formation on the left side of the board is a frequent guest in games where Black has chosen the King's Indian or Benoni defenses. White's d5 pawn, supported by the c4 pawn, has taken control of the c6 and e6 squares in Black's side of the board and provides White a useful space advantage during the opening and middlegame pha . Yet as the position dwindles down to the endgame, the negatives start to come out loud and clear: e5 is accessible to Black's pieces and the c4 pawn is vulnerable to an attack, particularly in a Knight endgame. By itself these factors would not be lethal but when added to something else - in Diagram 89 the weakness of White's h-pawn - the combination can be deadly. IM Marin, with his outstanding play, proves that Black has a forced win:

1...Nf2+!

Black repositions the Knight so that it can readily attack both vulnerable points: c4 and h4. According to IM Marin, after 1...Kf6? White can set up a defensive formation with 2 Nh3!.

2 Ke2 Ng4 3 Nf3

Obviously 3 Nh3? loses to 3...Ne5.

3...Kf6 4 Nd2 Ne5 5 Kf2 h6!

The immediate 5...Nd3+ 6 Ke2 Nb2 7 Kf2 Ke5 leads to nothing after 8 Nf3+ (8...Ke4? 9 Ng5+). Therefore Black brings the h-pawn to safety on h5 in a way that he is on move again with White's King on f2.

6 Kg3 h5! 7 Kf2 Ng6 8 Nf3

Black's King break in after 8 Kg3?! Ke5 9 Kh3 f4!

8...Ne5! 9 Nd2

After 9 Nxe5? Kxe5 10 Kf3 Black puts White in Zugzwang with 10...a6! 11 a4 a5 and wins easily, e.g. 12 Kf2

Ke4! 13 Ke2 f4 etc.

9...Nd3+ 10 Kf3

IM Marin gives the following variation after 10 Ke2: 10...Nb2 11 Kf2 Ke5 12 Kf3 a6! 13 Kg3 a5! 14 Kf3 a4! 15 Kg3 Nd1! 16 Kf3 Nc3 "and White is in zugzwang and loses". This is obvious after 17 Nf1 Nb1 as well as 17 Kf2/Kg3 Ne4+. It is less obvious after 17 Kg2, though 17...f4 18 Kf3! fxe3 19 Kxe3 Nd1+ 20 Ke2 Nb2 21 Ke3 Kf5 22 Kf3 Nd3 should be good enough to win.

10...a6! 11 a4

After 11 Ke2 Nb2 12 Kf2 Ke5 13 Kf3 a5! 14 Kg3, decisive is 14...Nd3! 15 Kf3 f4 and Black breaks through.

11...Ke5 12 Ke2 Nb2 13 a5 f4 14 Kf3 fxe3 15 Kxe3 Kf5 16 Kf3 Nd3! 17 Ke2

White's ug wang is complete after 17 Kg3 Ne5.

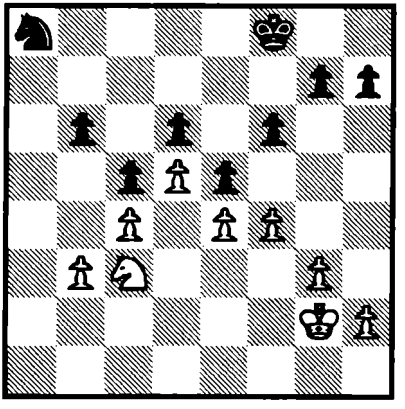
17...Ne5 18 Ke3 Kg4 19 Ke4 Ng6! White resi ns

IM Marin gives the following exhaustive analysis as proof that White is lost: 20 Nf3 Nxh4 21 Ne5+ (21 Nxh4 Kxh4 22 Kf5 Kg3 23 Ke6 h4 24 Kxd6 h3 25 Kc7 h2 26 d6 h1=Q 27 d7 Qe1! wins) 21...dxe5 22 d6 Nf5 23 d7 Nd6+ 24 Kd5 Nb7 25 Kc6 Nd8+ 26 Kxc5 h4 27 Kd6 h3 28 Ke7 Nb7 29 c5 h2 30 c6 h1=Q 31 c7 Qh7+ and Black wins.

A weak point in a blocked position is usually defensible. But if the opponent also has a considerable spatial advantage, be very careful you do not wind up with another permanent weakness in your position. Witness what happens from Diagram 90 (on the next page), G. Kasparov - R. Hübner, Training Match, Hamburg 1985, Game 4, after Black's 33rd move. Black has an obvious weakness on b6, yet that is defensible readily enough. However, White's spatial advantage which derives from the d5 - e4 - f4 pawn formation cramps Black's style. For Black not to become suffocated he will need to make some decision about his Kingside pawn formation. As we will soon see, it better be a

correct decision!

Diagram 90



34 Na4 Kf7

Short of time, Black tries not to make a "risky" decision. Yet what is required is to prevent White from getting into Black's Kingside. For that it is best if Black places pawns on g5 and h5. Therefore, GM Kasparov suggests the following as Black's best defense: 34...g5! 35 fxg5 (Black is safe after 35 Kf3 h5!) 35...fxg5 36 g4 Kg7 37 Kg3 Kg6 38 h4 gxh4+ 39 Kxh4 h6!. White's King cannot progress by himself and if White starts bringing back the Knight, Black activates his with ...Nc7 etc. The position remains drawn.

35 Kf3

Playable, but better is 35...g5!. White prevents that with his next.

36 h4! h6??

Already the decisive error. Correct is 36...h5! and after 37 f5, 37...g5! and again White will not be able to break through on the Kingside. However, if 37...gxf5? White has the following instructive win, as given by Kasparov: 38 exf5 Kg7 39 g4 hxg4+ 40 Kxg4 Kh6 41 Nc3 Nc7 42 Ne4 Ne8 43 Ng3 Ng7 44 Kf3 followed by Ke3, Kd3, Kc3 and breaking through on the Queenside with b4.

37 g4! g5

By now, doing something loses and doing nothing loses. GM Kasparov provides the following analysis: (a) 37...exf4 38 Kxf4 g5+ 39 hxg5 hxg5+ 40 Kf5 Nc7 41 e5! dxe5 42 Nxb6 and White wins; (b) 37...Kg7 38 h5! Kf7 39 Kg3 Kg7 40 Nc3 Nc7 41 Nd1 Ne8 42 Ne3 Kf7 43 hxg6+ Kxg6 44 Nf5 Kh7 45 Ne7 followed by Nc8.

Kasparov does not consider 37...h5 as a defense. Presumably 38 f5 will lead to play similar to that given in the variations above.

38 fxg5 fxg5

After 38...hxg5 39 h5 the passed protected h-pawn is a terror, yet after the text Black has weaknesses on h6 (and d6) added to the original one on b6.

39 h5 Ke7 40 Nc3 Nc7 41 Nd1 Ne8 42 Ne3 Ng7 43 Ke2 Kd7 44 Kd3 Kc7 45 Kc2 Kc8

Staying on the Kingside allows White to win as follows: 45...Kd7 46 b4 Ke7 47 Kb3 Kf8 48 bxc5 bxc5 49 Ka4 Ne8 50 Nf5 Nf6 51 Nxh6 Nxe4 52 Nf5 53 h6 Kf7 54 h7! Nxh7 55 Nxd6+ Ke7 56 Ne4 Nf6 57 d6+ Ke6 58 Nxf6 Kxf6 59 Kb5 e4 60 Kc6 (Kasparov).

46 b4!

Black is secure enough on the Kingside, but will not be able to also protect the Queenside.

46...Kc7 47 Kb3 Kb7 48 Ka4 Kb8

After 48...Ka6 49 Nf5! Nxf5 50 exf5 White's Queen mates Black on a8.

49 bxc5 bxc5 50 Ka5! Kb7

If 50...Ka7 White again forces a won Q + P endgame with 51 Nf5: 51...Nxf5 52 gxf5 g4 53 f6 g3 54 f7 g2 55 f8=Q

g1=Q 56 Qe7+ Ka8 57 Kb6 Qb1+ 58 Kc6.

51 Kb5 Kc7 52 Ka6 Kc8 53 Kb6 Kd7 54 Kb7 Ne8

White has been playing, in effect, a won K & P endgame. If instead, 54...Kd8, White progresses further with 55 Kc6 Ke7 56 Kc7 Ne8+ 57 Kb6! Ng7 58 Kc6 (Kasparov).

55 Nf5 Nf6 56 Nxh6 Nxe4 57 Nf5 Nf6 58 h6 e4 59 Kb6 Nh7 60 Kb5 Black resigns

GM Hübner does not want to be shown GM Kasparov's winning method: the King returns to e2, then White plays Ng3 and follows with Nxe4.

Chapter 7

The Active King And Knight

What is the value of an active King? Of course, the King himself is priceless, but is it possible to assign a net worth to him as a doer? GM Mikhail Tal has suggested that its value then is about 3 points, i.e. that of a minor piece. Such a relationship makes sense to me. However, its field of activity is quite different from that of the long range Bishop. Yet the King and Knight are both short range pieces and therefore King and Knight endgames give an excellent demonstration of the use of these pieces, both in combat with each other and when used as a team.

The advantages of the better King and the better Knight can turn out to be transient ones. The fle ible Knight can often check away the enemy King from its active location; the more active Knight can be deflected away by a defending Knight. Moreover, the inability of the Knight to bring about zugzwang positions limits its power as an attacker.

Here I will look at three distinct situations: first, the active King and active Knight separately, and then the combination of the active King and active Knight.

Section 1: The Active King

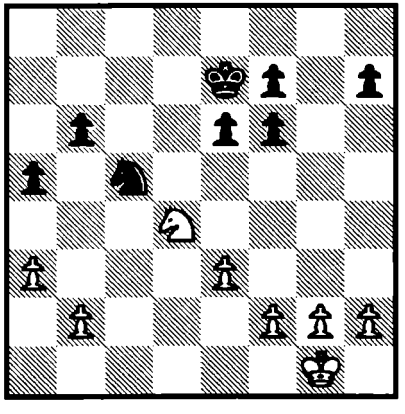


Diagram 91

I will start off with a most instructive and for practical play important example, as shown in Diagram 91, A. Segal - B. Ivkov, Sao Paulo 1978, after Black's 22nd move.

In earlier play the Brazilian IM had rushed to exchange off pieces without bothering to notice that Black's uncastled King is much more actively placed than White's castled King. White's pawn formation is faultless (Black is the one handicapped by doubled pawns) and his Knight centralized - yet the difference in Kings is too much to overcome. Black won as follows:

23 Kf1 Kd6 24 Ke2 Kd5 25 Nf3

Heading for d2 to keep Black's King out of c4, but has the demerit of deactivating the Knight. Yet there is nothing good, e.g. 25 b4 axb4 26 axb4 Na6! 27 b5 Nc5 followed by 28...Kc4 will be the kiss of death for the b-pawn. After 25 Kd2 GM Ivkov gives the following winning line for Black: 25...Ne4+ 26 Ke2 Kc4 27 f3 Nc5 28 Kd2 e5 29 Nf5 (or 29 Ne2) 29...Kb3.

25...e5 26 Nd2 e4!

By taking away access to d3 from White's King, Black severely cramps White's defenses. Because after 27 f3, Black can support his e4 strongpoint with 27...f5, White strives to prevent that by his next move.

27 g4 Na4 28 b3 Nc3+ 29 Kf1

Since from e1 the King has no future, White sends him back to the Kingside.

29...b5! 30 Kg2 a4 31 b4 Ke5!

White's Queenside has been loosened up (c4!) and the a3 pawn made vulnerable, but before undertaking decisive action there, Black puts his potentially vulnerable Kingside in order. In any case, 31...Na2?! 32 Kg3 Nxb4?? 33 axb4 a3 fails to 34 Nb1.

32 Kg3 f4! 33 gxf5 Kxf5 34 f3 Ke5 35 Kf2 f5! 36 Kg3 Nd1 37 fxe4 Nxe3 38 exf5 Nxf5+ 39 Kf3 Kd4 40 Kf4 Nd6 White resigns

Black's active King will penetrate decisively into White's Queenside, e.g. 41 h4 Kc3 42 Ke5 Nc4+ 43 Nxc4 Kxc4 and Black wins all pawn races.

Compared to Diagram 91, White is better off in Diagram 92, M. Taimanov - L. Polugaevsky, U.S.S.R. Championship 1976, after Black's 26th move, yet Black's powerfully centralized King gives him a clear advantage. In fact, White's position is close to critical.

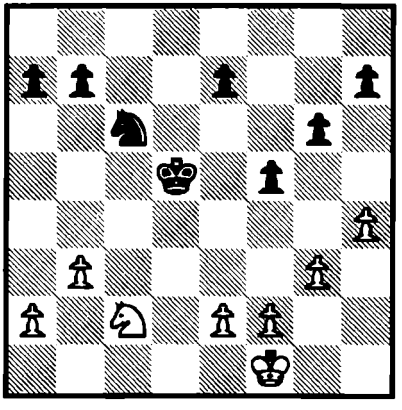


Diagram 92

27 e3?

By creating a permanent weaknesses on f3 and d3 while delaying King activation by a move, White already makes his position critical. Mandatory is 27 Ke1, when all the K & P endgames after 27...Kc5 28 Kd2 Nb4 (or 28...Nd4 29 Nxd4) 29 a3 are just drawn.

27...Kc5 28 a3

Unavoidable since 28 Ke2? Nb4 wins for Black. But after the text Black can force further weaknesses in White's Queenside.

28...a5! 29 a4

White now gets squeezed into a pretzel. Therefore worth trying was 29 Ke2!? a4 30 bxa4, though White's prospects are most unpleasant after 30...Kc4.

29...Nb4 30 Ne1

Enabling the Knight to go to d3 if Black's Knight now moves. After 30 Nd4 Na2! 31 Nc2 Black wins with 31...Nc1 32 Nd4 Kb4.

30...e5! 31 Ke2 e4 32 Kd2 Nc6! 33 Nc2

Or 33 Kc3 Ne5 followed by 34...Ng4 - another legacy of 27 e3?.

33...Ne5 34 h5

As strange as it seems, White is already in zugzwang: a Knight move allows 34...Kb4; 34 Kc3 loses to 34...Ng4; 34 Ke2 loses to 34...Nd3, threatening 35...Nc1+.

34...Nf3+ 35 Kc3 gxh5 36 Na3 h4! 37 gxh4 h5 38 Nb5 Nxh4 39 Nd4 Nf3

The outside passed pawn in the form of the h-pawn is so powerful that Black can afford to give up the f-pawn, e.g. 40 Nxf5 h4 41 Kb2 Kb4 42 Kc2 h3 44 Ng3 h2 45 Nh1 Ng5, followed by ...Ne6 and Nc4. Still, White's choice of remaining a pawn down in a hopeless position makes no sense at all.

40 Ne6+ Kd6 41 Nf4 h4 42 Kc4 Ng1 White resigns

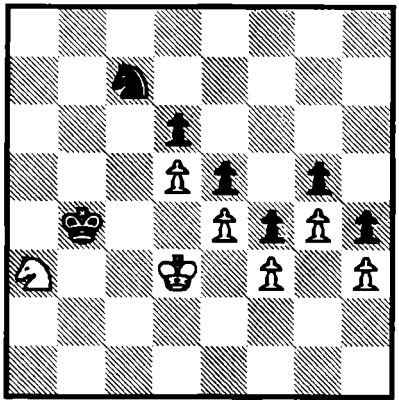
White had sealed 43 Kb5, but resigned without continuing the game in view of 43...h3 44 Nxh3 Nxh3 45 Kxa5 Kc6 followed by 46...Nxf2.

It is important that the side with the active King does not become too complacent because the agile Knight is very capable of creating counterplay. This is well demonstrated from Diagram 93 (On the following page), I. Boleslavsky - P. Keres, USSR Absolute Championship 1941, after Black's 58th move. Black's active King gives him the advantage, yet the

fundamental pawn weaknesses on d6 and g5 makes the ultimate result uncertain. The game continued:

59 Nc2+?

Diagram 93



A poor move. At this point White apparently felt that strictly defensive measures will be sufficient to draw. Since this will be insufficient, immediate activity with 59 Nc4! should have been tried. The main line to me then seems to be 59...Nb5 60 Nb6 Nd4 61 Nc4 Kc5 (61...Nxf3 62 Nxd6 is O.K. for White) 62 Na5! Kb6 (62...Nxf3 63 Nb7+ Kb6 64 Nxd6 is again satisfactory for White) 63 Nc4+ Kc7 64 Nd2 Kd7 65 Kc3 Ne2+ 66 Kc2! when 66...Ng1?? 67 Kd1 Nxh3 68 Ke1 traps Black's Knight. It is of course possible that a way exists to improve Black's play in the above line, yet White has chances for real counterplay.

59...Kb3 60 Ne1 Na6 61 Kd2 Kc4! 62 Nd3 Nc7 63 Kc2 Nb5 64 Nb2+

By now it has become apparent to White that passive play will not do, e.g. 64 Ne1 Nd4+ 65 Kd2 Kb3! 66 Kd3 Kb4! 67 Kd2 Kc4 68 Kd1 Kc3 69 Kc1 Ne2+ 70 Kd1 Ng1 and Black wins. However, White starts his activity under conditions significantly inferior to those available at Move 59.

64...Kc5 65 Na4+ Kb4 66 Nb6 Nd4+ 67 Kd3 Nxf3 68 Nd7

White has nothing better than this bluff, but it should

have been called: 68...Ng1 69 Nxe5 dxe5 70 d6 f3 71 Ke3 f2! 72 Kxf2 Nxh3+ 73 Kf3 Nf4 74 d7 Ne6 and White can resign. Instead, by trying to be careful, Black allows White genuine counterplay.

68...Nd4? 69 Nf6 Nb3 70 Ke2 Nc5 71 Kf3 Nb3 72 Ke2 Nc5 73 Kf3 Kc3! 74 Ne8 Kd2 75 Nxd6 Ke1 76 Nc4 Kf1! 77 Nd2+

Black's active King prevents 77 Nxe5? because after 77...Nb3! Black mates either on d4 or d2.

77...Kg1 78 Nc4 Nd7?

Black puts too much credence on his active King and not enough on the active Knights for both sides. GM Botvinnik has demonstrated the following win: 78...Nb3! 79 Ke2 (Otherwise 79...Nd4 Mate) 79...Nd4+ 80 Kd3 f3 81 d6 f2 82 Ne3 Ne6 83 Kc4 Nf4! 84 d7 Ng2.

79 Nd6 Nc5 80 Nc4 Nd7? 81 Nd6 Kh2??

Still enamored by the active King, Black even loses. After 81...Nc5 White could have claimed a draw because of three fold repetition of the position (in view of 82 Nc4), but a draw is a lot better than a loss.

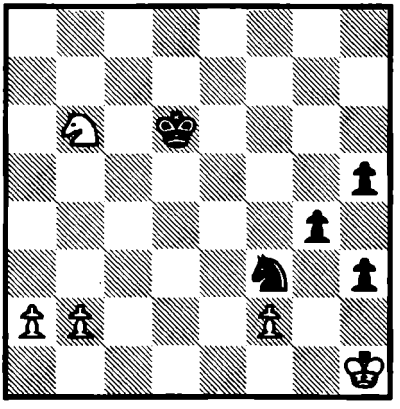
82 Nf7 Kxh3 83 Nxg5+ Kh2 84 d6 h3 85 Nxh3! Kxh3 86 g5

Black's Knight cannot stop both passed pawns, while White's passive King can do its job.

86...Nc5 87 g6 Ne6 88 d7 Ng5+ 89 Ke2 Kg3 90 d8=Q Black resigns

The flip side of the active King is one so passively placed that it not only has no hope of being worth 3 points, but is an insufferable liability. Such an instructive situation is shown from Diagram 94 (on the following page), S. Tartakower - M. Botvinnik, Groningen 1946, after Black's 41st move (41...h5). Not only is White's King useless, but is in imminent danger of being mated after 42...h4, 43...g3, 44...g2. White lost as follows:

Diagram 94



42 Nc4+

The Knight heads back to help its King. Of course, unless White can mobilize his Queenside pawns he is sure to lose in the long run. However, the attempt with 42 a4 fails by a move after 42...Nd2! 43 a5 h4 44 a6 g2 when GM Botvinnik gives the following variations:
(1) 45 a7 gxf2! 46 a8=Q f1=Q+ 47 Kh2 Nf3+.
(2) 45 fxg3 hxg3 46 a7 g2+ 47 Kh2 Nf3+ 48 Kxh3 g1=Q 49 a8=Q Qh2+ 50 Kg3 Ne5+ 51 Kf3 Qf2+ 52 Kg5 (52 Ke4 Qf3+ 53 Kd4 Qd3 Mate) 52...Qg3+ 53 Kf5 Qg4+ 54 Kf6 Qg6 Mate.

42...Kd5 43 Ne3+ Ke4 44 a4

A better practical try is 44 b4 when Black must play 44...Nd4! (preventing the immediate 45 b5), followed by 45...Kf3, winning by a tempo.

44...Kd3 45 Nd5 Ke2 46 Nf4+ Kxf2 47 Nxh3+

White is also a tempo short after 47 Nxh5 g3 48 Nxg3 Kxg3 49 a5 h2 50 a6 Ng5 51 a7 Ne4 52 a8=Q Nf2 Mate. But notice that Black cannot allow the b-pawn to queen in such variations.

After the text Black can also win with 47...gxh3, but GM Botvinnik chooses a more thematic continuation which does

not require a particularly demanding calculation.

47...Kf1! 48 Nf4 g3 49 Ng2 Kf2! 50 a5 h4 51 Nf4 Kf1

To ensure that after ...h3, White can't capture with check.

52 Ng2 h3 53 Ne3+ Kf2 54 Ng4+ Ke2 White resigns

The "bad" King gets mated.

Section 2: The Active Knight

There is little point in looking at the trivial situations where one Knight is placed so well that it routinely gobbles up the vulnerable enemy pawns. For instructional purposes the important cases are where the more favorably situated ("active") Knight can cause a long term strategic deficiency in the enemy camp. This will be wonderfully illustrated from Diagram 95, A. Yusupov - V. Ivanchuk, Linares 1991, after White's 32nd move.

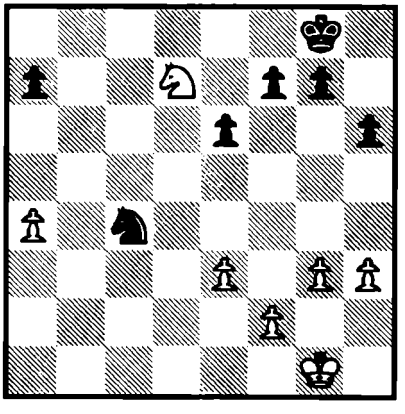


Diagram 95

On the Kingside everything (including the Kings) is rather equivalent, each player has an isolated a-pawn, White's Knight is the one deeper into enemy territory. Yet it is Black who has the truly *active* Knight because it can achieve something significant in short order, thereby giving Black a significant advantage. In my comments that follow I have made

grateful use of GM Yusupov's fine analysis in *Informant #51.*

32...Nb2! 33 a5 Nc4! 34 a6 f5! 35 Kf1 Kf7

Black's Knight has chased White's a-pawn deep into Black's territory where it is vulnerable to an attack by both Black's King and Knight. Moreover, Black's King gains a valuable tempo by the attack on White's strayed Knight and thus can assume a powerful centralized location.

36 Ke2

Further "activity" by 36 Nb8? leads to an immobile Knight after 36...Na5 37 Ke2 Ke7 and a lost K & P endgame: 38 Kd3 Kd6 39 Kc3 Nc6! etc.

36...Ke7 37 Nc5 Kd6 38 Nb7+!

Keeping the Knight truly active, by affording it the opportunity to get into Black's Kingside. As will be seen later, this will turn out to be White's saving grace.

38...Kd5 39 f3 e5?

A bad move for two reasons: (1) It leads to a loosening of Black's Kingside, thereby giving White undeserved counter-chances, and (2) Black's strong Knight repositioning via 39...Ne5! is not only delayed but even prevented. After 39...Ne5 Black threatens to simply snip off White's a-pawn after 40...Nc6 and 41...Nb4. Therefore 40 Na5 is forced when GM Yusupov gives the following convincing variation: 40...Nc6 41 e4+ (Or 41 Nb3 e5! 42 f4 Kc4) 41...fxe4 42 fxe4+ Kc5 43 Nb3+ Kc4 44 Nd2+ Kb5 and after capturing the a-pawn, Black's prospects for a win are bright.

After the text move, the position is already drawn - though not without sweat on White's part.

40 g4! g6

GM Yusupov gives the following alternatives:
(1) 40...fxg4 41 e4+ Kd4 42 hxg4 g6 43 Nd8 Kc5 44 Nf7 h5

45 g5 followed by 46 Nh8 with sufficient counterplay.
(2) 40...f4 41 e4+ Kc6 42 Nd8+ Kb6 43 h4 Kxa6 44 h5 followed by 45 Ne6, again with full counterplay.

41 Nd8 Nd6 42 gxf5

In his notes GM Yusupov gives the text a dubious mark and instead recommends 42 h4 as the simpler drawing line: 42...fxg4 43 fxg4 e4 (White is safe after 43...h5 44 Kf3 hxg4+ 45 Kxg4 Nf5 46 Kg5 with the threat 47 h5.) 44 Kf2 h5 (Or 44...g5 45 hxg5 hxg5 46 Ke2 Kc4 47 Ne6.) 45 Kg3 hxg4 46 Kxg4 Nf5 47 h5! Nxe3+ 48 Kf4 "with a draw". However, if we continue this by just a bit with 48...gxh5! 49 Kxe3 h4, it becomes clear that Black's pawn can't be stopped. Therefore it is highly dubious that 42 h4 does the job.

42...gxf5 43 h4! Kc5 44 e4! fxe4

White is happy to exchange all the Kingside pawns, but 44...f4 also does not win: 45 Kd3 Kb6 46 Kc3 Kxa6 47 Nc6 Nf7 48 Kc4 Kb6 49 Kd5! a5 50 Nxa5! Kxa5 51 Ke6 Kb4 52 Kxf7 Kc3 53 Kg6 Kd4 54 Kxh6 Ke3 55 Kg5 Kxf3 56 h5 Kxe4 57 h6 f3 58 h7 f2 59 h8=Q f1=Q 60 Qa8+ (Yusupov) and the Q & P endgame is drawn.

45 fxe4 Kb6

Obviously 45..Nxe4 allows 46 Nf7 with a draw. After the text White's King must be used to stop the a-pawn while the Knight menaces the Kingside pawns. Therefore losing is 46 Kf3? h5! 47 Ne6 Ne8! 48 Ng5 Nf6 49 Nf7 Nd7 when Black's pawns are safe, White's a-pawn goes lost and his King can't get back to the Queenside in time.

46 Kd3! Kb5! 47 h5! Kb6! 48 Ne6!

Thanks to triangulation, Black has forced White's Knight to give up its best location, yet the Knight's activity is still good enough to draw. In the early play Black's active Knight led to his advantage; now White's active Knight saves the draw.

48...Kxa6 49 Nc5+ Kb5 50 Nd6 Nf7 51 Kc3 Kc6

Nor is there a win after 51...a5 52 Kb3 a4+ 53 Ka3, e.g. 53...Kc4 54 Kxa4 Kd4 55 Nf6 Ke3 (55...Ng5 56 Ng4) 56 Kb5 Kf4 57 Kc5 Kg5 58 Nd7 Kxh5 59 Kd4, with a draw (Yusupov).

52 Nf6 Kc5 53 Nd7+ Kb5 54 Nf6 a6 55 Nd7 Kc6 56 Nf6 Kc5 57 Nd7+ Kb5 58 Nf6 Ng5

Here too 58...a5 59 Kb3 a4 (Or 59...Kc5 60 Ka4) 60 Ka3 leads to nothing more than in the note to Black's 51st move.

59 Ng4! Nxe4+ 60 Kc2 Ng3 61 Nxh6 e4

Black can't save the e-pawn (61...Nxh5 62 Nf7) and the endgame of N + a-pawn vs. N is a routine draw.

62 Nf7 Nxh5 63 Nd6+ Draw

Section 3: The Active King and The Active Knight

Since we already saw the tremendous power that just the active King by himself can generate, it is to be expected that the combination of an active King with an active Knight would be doubly powerful. If the defensive side also is

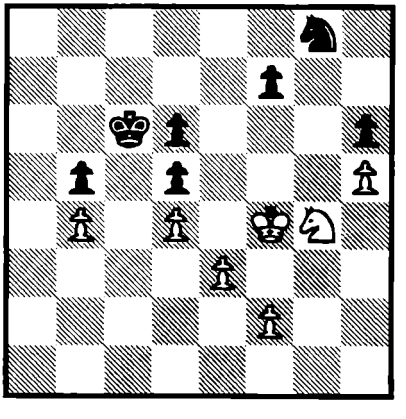


Diagram 96

burdened with a chronic structural weakness, then indeed its life expectancy is short. Consider now Diagram 96, J. Smejkal - K. Langeweg, Wijk aan Zee 1975, White on move. Black's King is in a box and his Knight is back home to protect the problem child on h6. White's active King + Knight duo breaks through immediately with:

1 Nxh6! Nxh6

In lieu of experiencing the inevitable, Black actually resigned. I am continuing with the main line as given by IM N. Minev.

2 Kg5 Ng8 3 h6 Nxh6 4 Kxh6 Kd7 5 Kg7 Ke6

White has the proper tempo moves with the f-pawn also after the other King steps onto the e-file:
(a) 5...Ke7 6 f3! Ke6 7 f4 Ke7 8 f5 Ke8 9 f6.
(b) 5...Ke8 6 f4! Ke7 7 f5 etc.

6 f4! Ke7

6...Kf5 7 Kxf7 Ke4 is much too slow; 6...f5 fails after 7 Kg6.

7 f5 Ke8 8 f6 White wins

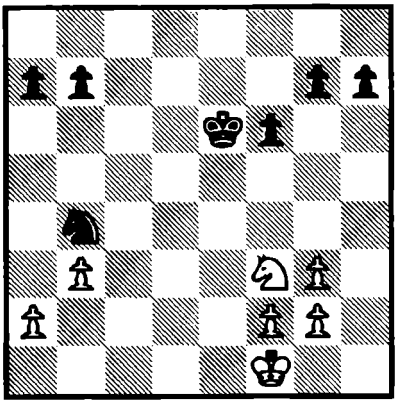


Diagram 97

The weaknesses don't have to be all that fundamental for the position to be indefensible. This is shown from Diagram

97, R. Ervin - P. Benko, Lone Pine 1976, after Black's 25th move. If White's King would already be on e2, White could hold the game. But here there is no defense:

26 a3

After 26 a4 Nd3! 27 Nd2 (27 Ke2? allows 27...Nc1+) 27...Kd5 28 Ke2 Kd4 Black also infiltrates decisively into White's Queenside.

26...Nc2! 27 a4 Kd5 28 Ke2 Na1! 29 b4

Or 29 Nd2 Kd4 followed by 30...Kc3.

29...Nc2 30 b5 Nd4+

Now that White's Queenside has been loosened up, unlike the situation that existed at Move 28, the K & P endgame is a sure win.

31 Kd3 Nxf3 32 gxf3 Kc5 33 Kc3 h5 34 f4 f5 White resigns

The likely continuation is 35 Kb3 Kd4 36 Kb4 b6 37 Kb3 Kd3 38 Kb4 Ke2 etc.

In positions which are blocked or semi-blocked often the winning method is to sacrifice the Knight so that the King can penetrate.

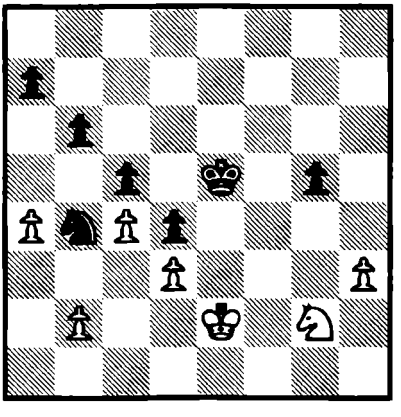


Diagram 98

This is well illustrated from Diagram 98, A. Zichichi - V. Hort, Venice 1969, White on move. Black has more space, the more active King and the more active Knight. Yet White seems to have covered all the bases. How is Black to break through?

1 Ne1 Kf4 2 Kf2 Nc6!

The Knight gets repositioned first to e5 and then to f4 so that it not only menaces d3 but also attacks other key squares.

3 Ng2+ Kf5 4 Ne1 Ne5 5 Kg3 Ng6 6 Kf3 Nf4 7 Kg3 a5 8 Kh2

After 8 b3 Black wins the b-pawn and the game with 8...Ne2+ 9 Kf2 Nc1. After the text routine play is insufficient, e.g. 8...g4?! 9 hxg4+ Kxg4 10 Kg1 Kg3 11 Kf1 and White, though passive, is safe. Stronger measures are required to allow the King to penetrate.

8...Nxh3!! 9 Kxh3 Kf4 10 Kg2 Ke3

Black's King has been unleashed onto White's Queenside and the pawns will drop like flies. White decides to activate his King and Knight since passive play is without prospects, e.g. 11 Kf1 g4 12 b3 g3 13 Kg2 Ke2 14 Nf3 Kxd3 15 Kxg3 Ke2! etc.

11 Nf3 Kxd3 12 Kf2 Kxc4 13 Ke2 Kb3 14 Nxg5 Kxb2! 15 Kd3 Kb3 16 Ne4 Kxa4 17 Kc4

White's K + N have succeeded in establishing satisfactory defensive positions, but four good connected passed pawns are too much for the Knight to cope with.

17...Ka3 18 Nf6 a4 19 Nd5 Kb2 20 Nxb6 a3 21 Na4+ Kc2 22 Nxc5 a2 23 Nb3 Kb2! White resigns

Drawing prospects depend on either exchanging off all the stronger side's pawns or creating sufficient counterplay. A model execution of the first approach is demonstrated from

Diagram 99, L. Evans - D. Verduga, Los Angeles 1980, White on move.

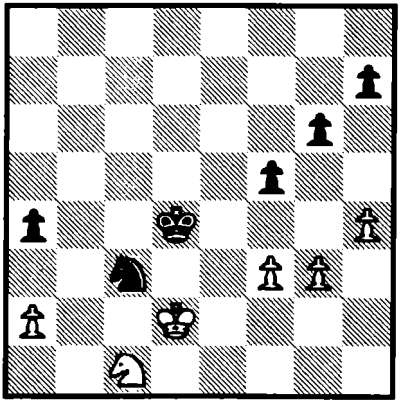


Diagram 99

Black's King and Knight have domineering locations and White's prospects look indeed bleak. For instance, 1 Ne2+? Nxe2 2 Kxe2 Kc3 leads to a lost K & P endgame, while 1 Kc2? allows Black the same type of winning sacrifice as in the previous example: 1...Nxa2! 2 Nxa2 Ke3 when Black will devour White's Kingside and win. The only drawing chance is, as GM Evans puts it so well, "liquidating pawns as fast as possible while keeping Black's King out". Therefore:

1 g4! gxf4?!

This helps White all across the board: a pawn is exchanged off and White's King liberated. More in the spirit of keeping a bind is 1...f4, though White keeps drawing chances after 2 g5! (Evans).

2 fxg4 Ne4+?!

And here 2...Nd5! is more perceptive, aiming to keep a bind on both sides, e.g. 3 Nd3 Ne3 4 Nf2 Nc4+!.

3 Ke2 Nf6 4 Kf3 Kc3 5 Kf4! Kb2 6 Ne2 a3 7 Nd4!

White's King has been liberated all right and now White must ensure that his Knight can be sacrificed for the a-pawn.

7...Kxa2 8 Nb5 Kb2 9 Nxa3 Kxa3 10 h5!! gxh5 11 gxh5 Nxh5+

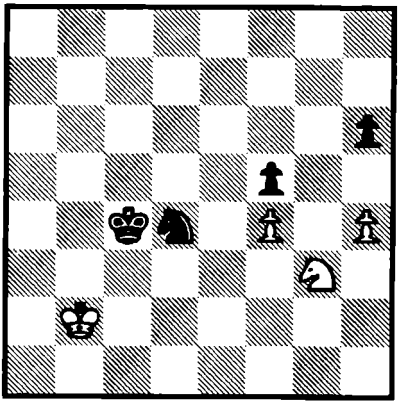
White is also safe after 11...Kb4 12 Kf5! Ng8 (12...Nxh5 13 Kg5) 13 Ke6 followed by 14 Kf7.

12 Kg5 Ng7 13 Kh6 Draw

Black's last pawn will bite the dust.

Going for counterplay is the only approach that can save White in Diagram 100, G. Barcza - T. Georgdze, Decin 1975, White on move.

Diagram 100



Black's King and Knight are ready to penetrate into White's Kingside and White's King is in no condition to prevent that. The only hope that White has is to send his Knight after Black's h-pawn. Therefore:

1 Nh5! Kd3

White's task is easier after 1...Ne2 2 Kc2! Kd4 3 Kd2 Ng1 4 Nf6! Nh3 (4...Nf3+ 5 Kg2 Nxh4 6 Ng8 h5 7 Nf6 allows White's Knight to capture the h-pawn and sacrifice itself for the f-pawn.) 5 h5! Nxf4 6 Ng8 Nxh5 7 Nxh6 f4 8 Ke2 Ke4 9 Ng4 and with White K + N well placed to stop the f-pawn, the draw is certain.

2 Nf6! Ne2 3 h5!

But not 3 Ng8?? h5 4 Nf6 Ng3! and White's pawns will go lost while Black's survive.

3...Nxf4 4 Ng8 Nxh5 5 Nxh6 f4 6 Nf7!

Since White's King can't get back to the Kingside, the active Knight has to do the job by itself. The pawn must be prevented from crossing f3 in safety. For White's Knight f7 is the ideal location since it can reach both of the critical squares: e5 and g5.

6...Nf6 7 Kc1 Ke3 8 Ng5 Ne4 9 Nf7!

Losing is 9 Nh3?? f3 10 Kc2 Ng5! 11 Nxg5 f2. But after the text 9...f3 is parried by 10 Ne5 f2 11 Ng4+ followed by 12 Nxf2.

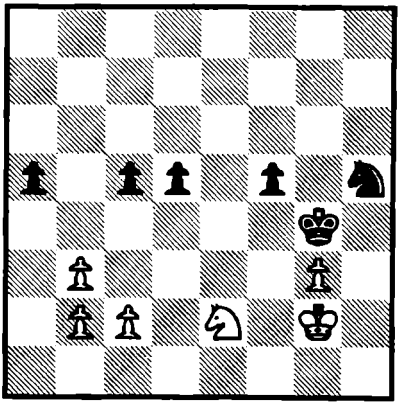
9...Ke2 10 Ne5 Nd2 11 Kb2 Ne4

11...Nc4+ 12 Nxc4 f3 is foiled by 13 Kc2 f2 14 Nd2.

12 Kc2 Draw

Black has no way of progressing.

Diagram 101



Even in desperate situations the potential activity of the Knight can give heart to the defender. An instructive and lucky (for me) example is shown from Diagram 101, E. Mednis - S. Reshevsky, U. S. Championship 1957/58, after White's 54th

move.

Black has the more active King, more active Knight and the better pawn formation - small wonder that White is lost! Yet, where "there is an active Knight, there is hope" and White goes about trying to activate his Knight:

54...d4! 55 Kf2 Nf6 56 Kg2 Ne4 57 Nf4! Nxg3 58 Nd3 Ne4 59 Ne5+ Kf4 60 Nc4

White must go for counterplay on the Queenside, even at the cost of allowing Black's King penetration because routine play a pawn down with the inferior position is simply waiting for the undertaker.

60...Nf6 61 Nxa5 Ke3 62 Kf1

White must prevent 62...Ke2, enabling the f-pawn to run victoriously.

62...Kd2 63 b4!! cxb4 64 Nc6

White's goal is simple: he wants to exchange off as many pawns as possible.

64...b3?

In wanting too much, Black comes up with too little. The simple and prosaic 64...Kxc2 65 Nxd4+ Kxb2 66 Nxf5 Kc3! was the only way to win. Black's pawn reaches b3 (i.e. the 6th rank) in safety and White's King is kept away in the passive "to the side of the pawn" location. A thematic illustrative variation then is: 67 Ke2 b3 68 Ne3 Ne4 69 Nd1+ Kc2 70 Ne3+ Kc1 71 Nd1 (71 Nc4 Nd6!) 71...Nc5 72 Ke1 Nd3+ 73 Ke2 Nf4+ 74 Ke1 Ng2+ 75 Ke2 Kc2 and Black wins.

65 cxb3 d3 66 b4!

White's only hope is that the passed b-pawn can tie down Black's Knight long enough for White to eliminate all of Black's pawns. This just turns out to be possible - by one tempo.

66...Kc1 67 Nd4! Nd5

Easier for White is 67...d2 68 Nb3+ Kc2 69 Nxd2 Kxd2 70 Kf2! Nd5 73 Kf3 Kd3 74 b5 Kd4 75 b6! Kxb6 76 Kf4.

68 b5 Kxb2 69 Nf3! Kc3 70 Ke1 Nb6 71 Kd1 Nc4 72 Ke1

White has set up an unusual blockade, which Black cannot break. For instance, 72...d2+ 73 Nxd2 Nxd2 74 b6 Nf3+ 75 Kf2 Nd4 76 b7 Nc6 77 Ke3 Kc4 78 Kf4, with a draw.

72...f4 73 Kd1 Kb4 74 b6!! Nxb6 75 Kd2 Kc4 76 Ne5+ Kd4 77 Nxd3 f3 78 Ne5! Draw

White comes just in time after 78...Kxe5 79 Ke3.

Chapter 8

Small Advantages in Knight Endgames

The practical player should strive to win slightly superior positions, whether they be middlegames or endgames. In particular, slightly superior endgames are pleasant to play since the reduction in material means that the risk of a loss has been decreased while the prospects of a win remain. Small advantages in Knight endgames give excellent prospects for a win because the defender tends to underestimate the superior side's chances. After all, the Knight is but a minor piece - and a short range one at that - so how much damage can occur? Yet, *especially the Knight* is excellent in exploiting small advantages because of its wonderful flexibility and agility. Here I will take a look at some interesting instructive examples.

First I will show the course of play from Diagram 102, M. Botvinnik - R. Holmov, Moscow Teams 1969, after White's 30th move.

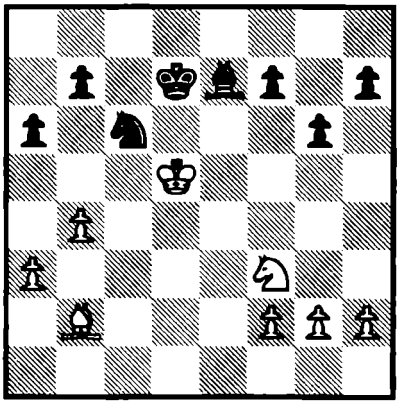


Diagram 102

White here has the smallest of advantages: the more active King. yet the King cannot penetrate further, Black's minor pieces are well placed and his pawn formation sound. The position is quite drawn, but GM Holmov does not appreciate the possible dangers and quickly lands in an untenable situation:

30...h5?!

The routine text is inexact. As GM Botvinnik has pointed out, the perceptive 30...Bd8! is in order to chase White's King away from its excellent center location with 31...Ne7+. It should be added that exchange of Knights offers no promise to White, as Black's position in a pure Bishop endgame is rock solid.

31 Bg7! Bd8

Also after 31...Bd6 White "prevents" the Knight check on e7 by means of 32 Bf6!

32 Bf8! Bb6

White is clearly better after 32...Ne7+ 33 Bxe7 Bxe7 34 Ne5+ Ke8. In this sequence, the damage from 30...h5?! comes through very clear: because of the weakness on g6, Black cannot chase the Knight away with ...f6. While the text is O.K., the plan behind it - the exchange of Bishops - is not. In any case, I would leave the Bishop on the h4 - h8 diagonal and play 32...Bf6.

33 Bc5 Ne7+

33...Bc7 or 33...Bd8 make more sense because the Black Bishop is a good defender.

34 Kc4 Bxc5?!

And here 34...Bc7 makes Black's defensive job a lot easier.

35 Kxc5 Kc7?

Already the decisive error because White's Knight can now cause a fundamental weakening of Black's Kingside. Correct is 35...Nc8! and after 36 Ng5, 36...Ke7. Black's position then remains defensible.

36 Ng5!

What a difference one move can make! Black now is

forced to create a major permanent weakness:
(1) 36...f5 37 Kd4 Nc6+ (Or 37...Kd6 38 Nf7+ Kd7 39 Ke5.) 38 Kd5 Kd7 39 Kc5 Kc7 40 Ne6+ (Pachman).
(2) 36...b6+ 37 Kd3 f6 38 Nh7 Ng8 39 Kd5 Kd7 40 Nf8+.

In each of these sequences White wins a pawn.

36...f6 37 Nh7 f5

Worse is 37...Ng8 38 Kd5 Kd7 39 Nf8+.

38 h4! f4

Black is already almost in zugzwang. After 38...b6+ GM Botvinnik gives the following variation: 39 Kd4 Kd6 40 Nf8! Nc6+ 41 Ke3 Ne5 42 Kf4 and the g-pawn goes lost.

39 Nf8 b6+?!

GM Botvinnik considers Black's best chance to be 39...f3! 40 g3 Nf5 41 Nxg6 Nxg3!, when after 42 Kd4 White will capture the f-pawn and thus be a pawn up, but Black keeps reasonable practical drawing chances.

40 Kd4 Nf5+

It's too late now for 40...f3?! 42 g3 Nf5+ because White has 43 Kd3!.

41 Ke4 Nxh4

Or 41...f3 42 Kxf3 Nxh4+ 43 Kg3 Nf5+ 44 Kf4.

42 Ne6+ Kc6 43 Nxf4 Kb5

Instead 43...g5 allows a won K & P endgame after 44 g3! gxf4 45 gxh4. According to GM Botvinnik, this is what GM Holmov had overlooked when playing 39...b6+?!.

44 g3 Nf5 45 Nxg6 Nh6 46 Ne5!

The coming Knight maneuver stops Black's counterplay

on the Queenside, allowing White to realize his advantage on the Kingside.

46...Ka4 47 Nc4 Kb3

The win is also routine after 47...Kb5 48 Nb2; it is pretty after 47...b5 48 Ne5 Kxa3 49 Nc6!.

48 Nxb6 Kxa3 49 Nd5 Kb3 50 f4 Kc4 51 Nc7 Kxb4 52 Nxa6+ Black resigns.

After 52...Kc4 53 Nb8 Ng4 54 Nd7 White has an elementary win.

Whereas White had no structural superiority at the start of the previous example, his slight advantage in Diagram 103, V. Bagirov - E. Sveshnikov, Lvov 1978, after White's 32nd move, is all structural: the potential weakness of Black's b-pawn and more central space because of the e5 pawn. Yet otherwise Black stands well: a good Knight and a King one tempo closer to the center than White's. Therefore it is nothing short of astounding how quickly Black self-destructs:

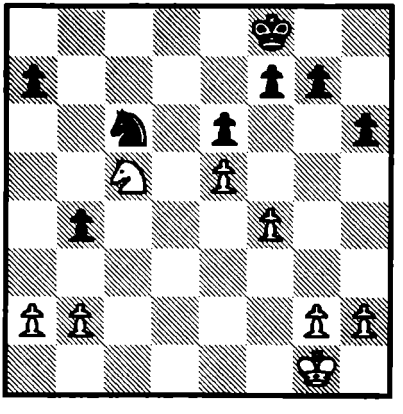


Diagram 103

32...g5?

Apparently Black only expects 33 g3?! when after 33 gxf4 34 gxf4 Kg7 a set of pawns have been exchanged and White's f-pawn is a new structural weakness. Therefore chances are equal.

Correct instead is the modest and sensible 32...Ke7 33 Kf2 f6! 34 exf6+ gxf6. White's central grip has been broken and Black's position is fully defensible.

33 fxg5! hxg5?!

This also is too routine, with Black not noticing that he is creating a new long term structural weakness on g5. Necessary is 33...Nxe5 34 gxh6 Kg8. After recapturing the h-pawn Black will have a sound e- and f-pawn couplet. White retains a clear edge because of having the outside passed pawn and opportunities of infiltrating the Queenside but Black is not without chances.

34 Nd3 Kg7 35 Kf2 f5?!

By allowing White's only weakness - the e-pawn - to disappear, Black lands himself in a hopeless situation. At least for the present Black should try to keep the status quo and play 35...Kg6.

36 exf6+ Kxf6 37 Ke3 Kf5 38 h3 a5 39 g4+! Kg6 40 Nc5 Kf6 41 Ne4+ Kg6

After the text Black's King remains a spectator while White's starts his work on the Queenside. After the active alternative, 41...Ke5, GM Bagirov gives the following convincing variation: 42 Nxg5 a4 43 h4 a3 44 b3 Ne7 45 Nf3+ Kf6 46 Kd4 Nd5 47 Nd2 Kf7 48 Ne4 Kg6 49 Kc4 Ne3+ 50 Kxb4 Nxg4 51 Kxa3 Kf5 52 Nc5 e5 53 Kb4 e4 54 Nxe4! Kxe4 55 Kc5 and White's pawns win.

42 Kd3 Ne5+ 43 Kd4 Nd7 44 Kc4 Nf6 45 Nc4 e5 46 Nb7 Ne4 47 Nxa5

The start of a successful dismantling of Black's Queenside. Black's counterplay comes too late since White's pieces can stop the e-pawn whereas Black is defenseless against White's Queenside advances. The outside passed pawn wins again!

47...Nf2 48 Nc6 Kf6 49 Nxb4 Nxh3 50 a4 Ke6 51 Kc5! e4 52

a4 e3 53 Nc2 e2 54 a6 Nf4 55 a7 Nd3+ 56 Kb5 Black resigns

A brief look at Diagram 104, G. Iskov - B. larsen, Danish Championship Match 1975, Game 1, after Black's 30th move, can even lead to the erroneous conclusion that White has some advantage: Black's a-pawn may be vulnerable, Black has doubled f-pawns and an isolated h-pawn.

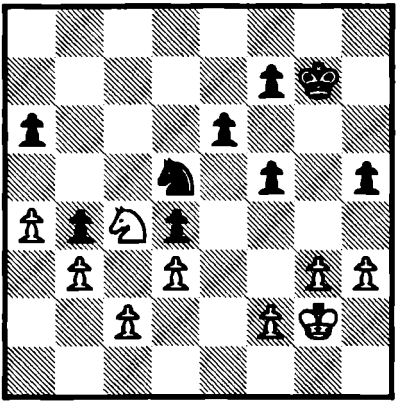


Diagram 104

The truth, however, is just the opposite: it is Black who is slightly better because of spatial advantage and the opportunity to build a strong center with ...f6 and ...e5. Black does not have to worry about the h-pawn because White can't get at it and Black can defend the a-pawn well enough. On the other hand, it is White's c-pawn that is a backward pawn, will be of no offensive help and is potentially vulnerable. Therefore, the player with the slight disadvantage must understand the essence of the position so as not to stumble into trouble. Yet, just as in the previous example, soon (within seven moves!) he is lost. This is how White brought it about:

31 f4

Playable, but not very perceptive because it weakens the e3 square at a time when Black's Knight has ready access to it. GM Larsen has suggested the following accurate way to head towards equality: 31 Na5! Ne7 32 Nb7 Nc6 33 f4! followed by 34 Kf3 and 35 g4.

31...f6 32 h4??

An absolutely criminal move. White creates a long term potential problem on h4 and forecloses the possibility of liquidating the Kingside pawns after a later g4, while achieving not an iota of value in return. GM Larsen suggests the sensible 32 Kf2, followed by activating the Knight with 33 Na5, aiming for the plan presented in the previous note.

32...Kf8 33 Kf3 Ke7 34 Kf2 Kd7 35 Kf3 Kc7 36 Kf2 Ne7! 37 a5??

After "criminally touching his h-pawn on Move 32, White now does the same to the a-pawn. The only gain from the text is that his Knight has partial access to b6 - a ridiculously small return for creating a hopelessly vulnerable a-pawn. Now White is totally lost. His position is unpleasant, of course, but that is hardly the reason for making the situation worse. A normal sequence would be 37 Kf3 Kc6 38 Kf2 ng6 39 Kf3 e5 39 fxe5 (Or 39 Nd2 Kd5 etc.) 39...fxe5 40 Nd2 Kd5 followed by ...e4.

37...Nc8 38 ke2 Kc6 39 Kf2 Kd5 40 Ke2 e5 41 Kf3 Ke6 42 Ke2 Ne7 43 Kf2

Because of the weakness of the h-pawn, White cannot avoid capturing on e5, thereby dissolving Black's doubled pawns. GM Larsen gives the following example: 43 Nd2 Ng6 44 Kf3 Kd5! (44...gxf4? 45 gxf4 Nxh4+ 46 Kg3 Ng6 47 Nf3 allows White a successful blockade.) when White is in zugzwang and must play 45 fxe5.

43...Ng6 44 fxe5 fxe5 45 Kf3 ne7 46 Nd2 Nc8 47 Ke2 Nd6 48 Nf3?!

Throwing away the a-pawn is plain silly. After the normal 48 Nc4, GM Larsen gives two methods for Black to reach a won position: (1) 48...Nb7 followed by ...Nc5 and ...e4; (2) 48...Nb5 followed by ...Na3 forcing White's King to protect the c-pawn, and then ...e4.

48...Nb7 49 Ng5+ Kf6 50 Nh7+ Ke7 51 Ng5 Nd8

Of course, the immediate 51...Nxa5 is fine, but the pawn

won't run away.

52 Nf3 Nc6 53 Kf2 Kf6 54 Nd2 Nxa5

Black is a second pawn up while retaining all his previous advantages: space, center, opportunity to create either a passed e- or passed f-pawn, vulnerability of c2. The only remaining question is Black's exact plan. GM Larsen decides on tieing down White's King to c2 and then creating a passed f-pawn.

55 Ke2 Nc6 56 Kf2 Ne7 57 Ke2 Nd5 58 Nc4 Ke6 59 Kf3 Nc3 60 Nb6 Nb5 61 Ke2 Na3 62 Na4 Kd6

There is no reason to allow White to activate his Knight after 62...Nxc2 63 Nc5+.

63 Kd1 f4!

Also 63...e4 wins, but Black chooses that passed pawn which is further from White's King. Black will use the time that White needs for stopping the f-pawn to break through on the Queenside.

64 gxf4 exf4 65 Nb6 Ke6 66 Ke2 Nxc2 67 Kf3 Kf5 68 Nd5 a5! 69 Ne7+

After 69 Nxf4, 59...a4 is the crusher.

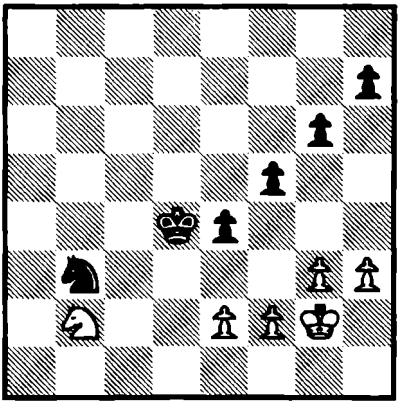
59...Ke6 70 Nc6 a4 White resigns

Our last example, Diagram 105, G. Fuster - S. Gligoric, Portoroz Interzonal 1958, after White's 41st move, shows a position which is theoretically 100% drawn and should be at least a 99% practical draw.

The time control has been reached, the game is adjourned overnight, all pawns are on the same side, there are no weaknesses in White's pawn structure. Black's only slight advantage is a *bit* more space. A pure Bishop endgame - with Bishops on either color - is a total draw and even with the flexible Knights on board, there should be no doubt of the

result: draw. Yet, nothing goes right with IM Fuster's handling of the position:

Diagram 105



41...Nc5

There is nothing in the "active" 41...Kc3 42 Na4+ Kd2 43 Kf1 Kd1 44 Nb2+ etc.

42 Nd1 Nb3 43 Nb2

Why put the Knight on the edge when a good central square is available? Of course, better is 43 Ne3! and if 43...Ke5, 44 h4, aiming for a routine exchange of the h-pawns.

43...Nd2 44 Nd1 Nc4 45 Kf1

White has "managed" to stalemate his Knight, but the position remains quite drawn, as long as White doesn't play e3, which would allow Black's King to march in to d2 via d3. Nevertheless, instead of the text move, perceptive is 45 h4!, so that if Black wants to get in ...g5 and ...f4 he has to allow the routine exchange of the h-pawns.

45...g5! 46 Kg2 h5 47 h4?!

Played at quite the wrong moment since the pawn now is more vulnerable on h4 than it would have been on h3. GM Gligoric suggests as correct 47 Kf1 and after 47...h4 48 gxh4 gxh4 49 Kg2 f4 Black lacks a viable plan to go for a win.

Even so the position remains quite drawn despite White's inferior 43rd, 45th and 47th moves.

47...g4 48 Kg1 e3

Black might as well try to confuse White since the Knight endgame remains so drawn. Of course the King & pawn endgame after 49 fxe3+! Nxe3 50 Nxe3 Kxe3 51 Kf1 f4 52 gxf4 Kxf4 53 Kg2 Ke3 54 Kf1 is quite drawn also because Black can never expect ...g3 to work. However, IM Fuster, already short of time, decides not to risk this endgame.

49 Kg2? exf2 50 Nxf2

This is the better recapture as the Knight gets into position to go to d3 and then f4.

50...Ne3+ 51 Kg1 f4 52 gxf4??

White promptly "forgets" the point of his 50th move and suddenly is lost. As GM Gligoric points out, White draws after 52 Nd3! f3 (52...fxg3 53 Nf4 is even simpler.) 53 Nf4 Nd1! 54 exf3 gxf3 55 Nxh5 Ke3 56 Nf4.

52...Nf5 53 Nd1?

White just allows Black to walk all over him. Some practical chances are offered by 53 e4.

53...Ke4! 54 e3 Kf3!

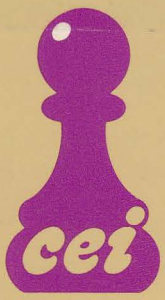
The combination of the active King, active Knight and far advanced passed pawns win easily.

55 Kh2 Nxh4 56 Kg1 nf5 57 Kf1 h4 58 Kg1 g3 White resigns

An endgame that White truly deserved to lose. If you do everything wrong, shouldn't you lose?

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